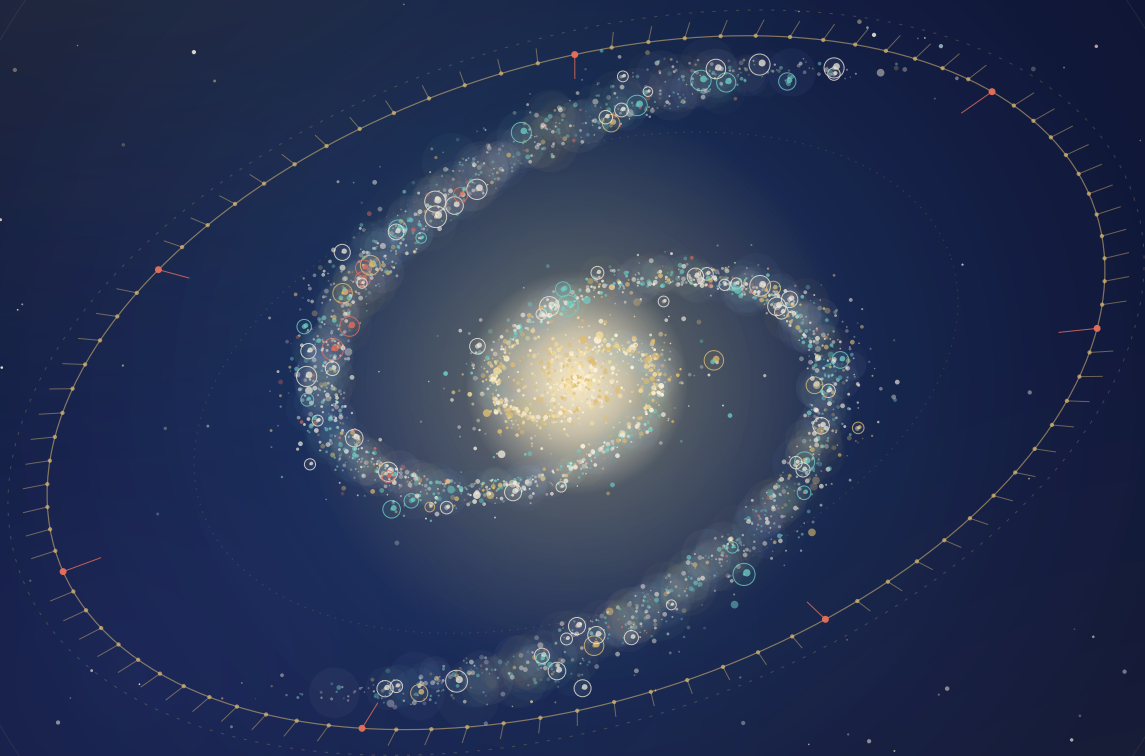


The Autoimmune Galaxy

Symbiosis, Sovereignty, and the Kenotic Unmasking in George Lucas's Star Wars

Toward a Symbiotic Theodicy — A Dissertation on the Lucas Saga, 1977–2005

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that George Lucas's six-film *Star Wars* saga (1977–2005), read as a single chiastic text in which a tragedy of the father (Episodes I–III) is enclosed within a romance of the son (Episodes IV–VI), constitutes a coherent though unsystematized biopolitical cosmology, here designated a *symbiotic theodicy*. Against the two dominant critical paradigms—the mythographic, which reads the saga as a populist recension of Joseph Campbell's monomyth, and the ideological, which reads it as nostalgic pastiche and Manichaean melodrama—I contend that its deep structure is *immunitary*: it narrates the protection of life through life's negation, and the recovery of life through voluntary exposure.

Four theses organize the argument. First, the Force is figured not as a deity, a field, or a moral substance but as an ecology of mutualism mediated by endosymbionts; the much-derided midi-chlorians of 1999, read through Lynn Margulis's theory of endosymbiosis and the Lovelock–Margulis Gaia hypothesis, disclose rather than betray an immanentist metaphysics that synthesizes Taoist *ziran*, Stoic *pneuma* and *sympatheia*, and Spinozan substance. Second, evil is figured not as an ontological counter-principle—the drafting record traces a movement from the Manichaean dyad of the Ashla and the Bogan to a single Force possessed of a "dark side," which is to say from Mani to Augustine—but as a pathology of relation: *parasitism* in the Sith, whose Rule of Two is an obligate host–parasite cycle, and *autoimmunity* in the late Jedi Order and the Galactic Republic, whose defensive self-purifications destroy what they were instituted to defend. Third, the political narrative of the prequel trilogy—the cloned army, the emergency powers, Order 66—stages with uncanny literalness Frank Macfarlane Burnet's clonal selection theory and Jacques Derrida's account of democratic autoimmunity, and finds its theoretical correlate in Roberto Esposito's dialectic of *immunitas* and *communitas*. Fourth, the prophesied "balance" of the Force names neither the parity of light and dark nor the extermination of the dark, but *homeostasis*: the restoration of a living system's capacity for self-regulation, achieved not through victory but through an act of de-immuniza-

tion that Lucas codes as compassion and that this study terms the *kenotic unmasking*.

The armored body of Darth Vader—simultaneously Plato's *sōma sēma*, Donna Haraway's unfaithful cyborg, Mircea Eliade's shaman reassembled in iron, and Søren Kierkegaard's demonic "inclosing reserve"—is accordingly the saga's central figure, and its removal at the father's own request is the paradigmatic scene of deimmunization in modern popular culture. The argument proceeds through source genealogy (Alex Raymond, E. E. Smith, Kurosawa Akira, Arthur Lipsett, Frank Herbert, Carlos Castaneda, Campbell), cosmology (Laozi, Zhuangzi, Takuan Sōhō, Yagyū Munenori, the Stoics, Spinoza, Augustine), ethics (Buddhist *pratītyasamutpāda* and the three cravings, Ernest Becker, Freud, Abraham and Torok, Kierkegaard, Meister Eckhart, Śāntideva, Kant, Milton), politics (Polybius, Plato, Tacitus, Hobbes, Weber, Schmitt, Arendt, Agamben), and comparative mythopoetics (Tolkien, Le Guin, Herbert, Asimov, Jack Kirby, the Gnostic *Hymn of the Pearl*). It concludes that the franchise's own history—from independent rebellion against the studio system to merchandising empire, from Lucas's 1988 Senate testimony against the alteration of motion pictures to his serial revision of his own—reenacts the autoimmune pathology its text diagnoses. *Star Wars* is thus best understood as the late twentieth century's most widely disseminated myth of immunity: a myth that teaches, against the grain of its own industrial afterlife, that the self survives only by consenting to be exposed.

Prefatory Note

Corpus, Conventions, Method

Corpus. The primary corpus comprises the six feature films conventionally designated the Lucas Saga: *Star Wars* (1977; retitled *Episode IV – A New Hope* for the 1981 re-release), *The Empire Strikes Back* (1980; directed by Irvin Kershner from a screenplay by Leigh Brackett and Lawrence Kasdan on a story by Lucas), *Return of the Jedi* (1983; directed by Richard Marquand from a screenplay by Kasdan and Lucas), *The Phantom Menace* (1999), *Attack of the Clones* (2002; screenplay by Lucas and Jonathan Hales), and *Revenge of the Sith* (2005). The secondary corpus comprises *The Clone Wars* (theatrical film 2008; animated series 2008–2014, developed under Lucas's supervision with Dave Filoni), Lucas's unpublished treatments and drafts as reconstructed by J. W. Rinzler (2007) and Michael Kaminski (2008), and Lucas's annotations and interviews. The licensed Expanded Universe, rebranded "Legends" in 2014, is treated as apocrypha: admissible as evidence of how the text was received and extended, never as evidence of what it means. Productions after the 2012 sale of Lucasfilm to The Walt Disney Company are treated as post-Lucasian canon and are invoked only in the Coda and for contrast.

The unstable text. *Star Wars* is among the most revised texts in the history of narrative cinema. The 1997 Special Editions, the 2004 DVD masters, and the 2011 Blu-ray masters introduced new shots, altered dialogue, recomposited characters, and in at least one notorious instance reversed the moral sequence of an action, revising the cantina scene so that Greedo fires first and Han Solo's pre-emptive killing of a bounty hunter becomes self-defense. Lucas has consistently maintained that the revised versions are definitive. This study treats the saga as a palimpsest. It cites the films in their revised state unless a variant bears on the argument, in which case both states are named and the variant itself is read as a hermeneutic datum: the 2004 substitution of Hayden Christensen for Sebastian Shaw as the spectral Anakin Skywalker, for instance, is analyzed in Chapter 10 not as an embarrassment but as a theological decision about which self survives de-immunization.

Authorship. "Lucas" designates here what Michel Foucault (1969) called an author-function: a principle of coherence under which heterogeneous collaborative labor—Kershner's and Marquand's direction, Brackett's and Kasdan's dialogue,

Ralph McQuarrie's production paintings, John Williams's leitmotivic score, Ben Burtt's sound design, and the editorial work for which Marcia Lucas, Paul Hirsch, and Richard Chew received the 1978 Academy Award—is gathered into a single signature. Authorial testimony is admitted as evidence of the text's horizon of intention but not as interpretive authority; the strictures of W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley (1946) against the intentional fallacy are observed, though not fetishized. Where Lucas's statements converge with the reading advanced here, they corroborate it; where they diverge, the text is preferred.

Method. The method is threefold. It is *genealogical*, in that it reconstructs the archive of pulp, cinematic, literary, religious, and philosophical materials from which the saga was assembled; *immanent*, in that it derives its central claims from the formal structures of the films themselves—their chiastic architecture, their visual and verbal rhymes, their recurrent motifs of dismemberment, masking, and burial; and *comparative*, in that it sets the saga beside cognate works of speculative fiction, myth, and philosophy in order to isolate what is distinctive in Lucas's synthesis. The theoretical apparatus of the later chapters—Esposito, Derrida, Agamben, Haraway, Varela—postdates the original trilogy, and in some cases the entire saga. Its use is justified not by any claim of influence but by the principle, familiar from the history of ideas, that a later conceptual vocabulary may name a structure an earlier text enacted without being able to articulate.

Conventions. The films are abbreviated *TPM*, *AOTC*, *ROTS*, *ANH*, *ESB*, and *ROTJ*; the animated series is *TCW*. Episode numbers follow the internal chronology; release dates follow the historical one. Film dialogue is overwhelmingly paraphrased, with direct quotation reserved for a handful of brief formulae whose exact wording carries the argument. Translations from Classical Chinese, Sanskrit, Pāli, Greek, Latin, German, and Danish are the author's own unless otherwise indicated. Sanskrit and Pāli are transliterated in IAST, Chinese in pinyin, and Japanese in modified Hepburn, with family names preceding given names for Japanese figures (Kurosawa Akira, Takuan Sōhō, Yagyū Munenori, Miyamoto Musashi). Citations follow an author–date system keyed to the Select Bibliography. Where the study notes onomastic resonances—Palpatine and the Palatine Hill, Padmé and the Sanskrit *padma*, Qui-Gon and *qigong*, Dagobah and the Sinhala *dāgaba*—these are proposed as resonances within the text's semantic field rather than as documented authorial derivations, unless explicitly so stated.

INTRODUCTION

The Myth That Remembers Its Sources

1.1 The Problem of the Syncretic Myth

Few artifacts of the twentieth century have been so insistently claimed as myth and so persistently dismissed as pastiche. Lucas told Bill Moyers in 1999 that he had placed the Force in the films to awaken in young viewers a generalized spirituality—nearer to a belief in God than to adherence to any confession—and that he regarded the saga as an attempt to distill the perennial concerns of religion into a modern and accessible construct (Moyers 1999). Raised a Methodist, he has elsewhere described himself, half in jest, as a "Buddhist Methodist," a phrase that compresses the saga's syncretism into two words. Joseph Campbell, having watched the original trilogy at Skywalker Ranch, endorsed it as a living instance of the mythic function he had spent his career describing, and Lucas publicly repaid the compliment by calling Campbell his Yoda. In 2001, 390,127 residents of England and Wales recorded their religion as "Jedi" in the national census, a figure that began as an organized jest but that Adam Possamai (2005) has made the paradigm case of "hyper-real religion": religiosity that draws its sacred texts from popular culture and is not thereby less religious.

Against this mythographic reception stands an ideological one of equal pedigree. Fredric Jameson identified *Star Wars* as the exemplary "nostalgia film," a pastiche that restores not the Saturday-afternoon serials themselves but an adult audience's memory of having once consumed them (Jameson 1991). Robin Wood indicted the "Lucas–Spielberg syndrome" as an infantilization of the spectator and a restoration of the Father suited to the Reagan era (Wood 1986), a charge to which Lucas's own repeated statements that he made the films for an audience of about twelve years old

lend prima facie support. Peter Biskind narrated the film's release as the event that closed the auteurist New Hollywood (Biskind 1998), and Darko Suvin's poetics of "cognitive estrangement" would exclude the saga from science fiction proper on the ground that its innovations are validated by fantasy rather than cognition (Suvin 1979). For the first camp, the saga's syncretism is the condition of its universality; for the second, the symptom of its emptiness.

Both camps share an unexamined premise: that the saga's syncretism is either self-justifying or self-condemning, and in neither case *organized*. Neither asks whether the heterogeneous materials—Flash Gordon and Kurosawa, Taoism and the Dam Busters, Castaneda and the Roman Senate—are subordinated to a governing logic that is not itself identical with any one of them. That is the question this dissertation pursues, and its answer is *immunity*.

Claude Lévi-Strauss's figure of the *bricoleur* clarifies the stakes (Lévi-Strauss 1962). The bricoleur works with a finite and heterogeneous repertoire of elements already shaped by prior uses; the meaning of the resulting construction lies not in its parts, each of which retains the trace of its former employment, but in the new structural arrangement into which they are drawn. A myth built from debris is not for that reason incoherent. Lucas's bricolage began, famously, with a failure: unable in the early 1970s to obtain the rights to Alex Raymond's *Flash Gordon*, he set out to manufacture an equivalent, and in the process assembled an archive far exceeding its occasion. What distinguishes the result from other bricolages is that it *remembers its sources inside the fiction*. The Jedi are a remnant religion mocked as superstition by the secular smuggler and as a pitiable anachronism by an Imperial officer; their weapon is introduced as a relic of a more civilized age; the narrative's opening formula, "A long time ago in a galaxy far, far away," relocates the apparatus of futurity into the mythic past. The saga does not merely draw on myth. It stages the survival of myth inside a disenchanted, bureaucratized, militarized modernity, and that staging is already, as Chapter 7 will argue, a Weberian drama.

1.2

State of the Field

Scholarship on the saga falls into five clusters. The *mythographic* cluster, inaugurated by Andrew Gordon's "*Star Wars*: A Myth for Our Time" (1978) and consolidated by Mary Henderson's catalogue for the Smithsonian exhibition *The Magic of Myth* (1997) and by Campbell and Moyers's *The Power of Myth* (1988), maps the films onto the monomyth and treats the mapping as explanation. The *ideological* cluster, from Robert Jewett and John Shelton Lawrence's *The American Monomyth*

(1977) through Wood (1986) and Jameson (1991) to Kevin J. Wetmore Jr.'s *The Empire Triumphant* (2005), reads the saga as a symptom of American political fantasy, with particular attention to race, gender, and the imperial imaginary. The *philosophical* cluster, represented by Kevin S. Decker and Jason T. Eberl's anthologies (2005; 2015) and by Cass Sunstein's *The World According to Star Wars* (2016), treats discrete problems—free will and prophecy, the ethics of the Jedi Code, the legitimacy of the Republic—in largely self-contained essays. The *religious-studies* cluster, including John Lyden's "The Apocalyptic Cosmology of *Star Wars*" (2000) and Possamai's work on hyper-real religion (2005), examines the films as sources and objects of religious practice. The *production-historical* and *reception* cluster—Dale Pollock (1983), Will Brooker (2002; 2009), J. W. Rinzler (2007), Michael Kaminski (2008), Chris Taylor (2014), Brian Jay Jones (2016)—reconstructs the drafts, the industrial history, and the fan cultures.

Four lacunae recur across these literatures. First, the prequel trilogy is routinely bracketed as an aesthetic failure and therefore excluded from interpretations of the whole, although Lucas conceived the six films as a single narrative and the original trilogy cannot be fully read without its antecedent tragedy. Second, the midi-chlorians are dismissed as a reductive literalization of the numinous, a judgment that forecloses the most philosophically consequential revision Lucas ever made. Third, the saga's metaphysics, ethics, and politics are treated in separate essays, so that no account demonstrates their integration, which is precisely what a governing logic would require. Fourth, Lucas's sources are catalogued but not *interpreted*: the literature knows that he drew on Campbell, Kurosawa, and Taoism, but not what principle selected these sources rather than others, or what the selection discloses. This dissertation addresses all four.

1.3

The Argument

The argument requires four terms of art. An *immunitary myth* is a narrative whose deep structure is the dialectic, analyzed by Roberto Esposito (2002), in which life is protected by a controlled negation of life—the logic of the vaccine generalized into a paradigm of politics—so that its antagonists are figures of excessive protection (armor, shields, walls, purges, emergency powers) and its redemptions are acts of exposure. A *symbiotic theodicy* is an account of evil that locates it neither in an independent substance, as in Manichaean dualism, nor in mere absence, as in a strict reading of the Augustinian *privatio boni*, but in a *pathology of relation*: the deformation of a living system's mutual dependencies into parasitism, in which one party

feeds upon another, or autoimmunity, in which the system attacks itself in the name of its own defense. *Homeostatic balance* names the restoration of a living system's capacity for self-regulation, and is distinguished both from *parity*, the equipoise of light and dark proposed by later fandom's "Grey Jedi," and from *extermination*, the pure victory of light. The *kenotic unmasking*, finally, takes its adjective from the Pauline *kenōsis* of Philippians 2:7, in which the divine form "emptied itself" and assumed the form of a slave; it names the narrative event in which an immunized subject voluntarily surrenders its protection and thereby dies into communion.

The governing thesis can now be stated in a single sentence. Lucas's saga is a symbiotic theodicy in immunitary form: it posits a living, symbiotically mediated Force whose health is homeostatic; it diagnoses evil as the parasitic and autoimmune deformation of that life; it narrates the corruption of a republic and a religious order by their own defensive reflexes; and it locates salvation not in the triumph of one side over the other but in a kenotic act of de-immunization, whose emblem is the removal of a mask. Several of the specific readings through which this thesis is developed—the midi-chlorians as the hinge of the saga's metaphysics, the Grand Army of the Republic as an allegory of clonal immunology, the late Jedi as Kierkegaard's knights of infinite resignation, Anakin's arc as an inversion of the Philippians hymn, the funeral pyre of *Return of the Jedi* as the restoration of a mourning prohibited in *Revenge of the Sith*—have not, to my knowledge, been advanced together, and several have not been advanced at all.

1.4

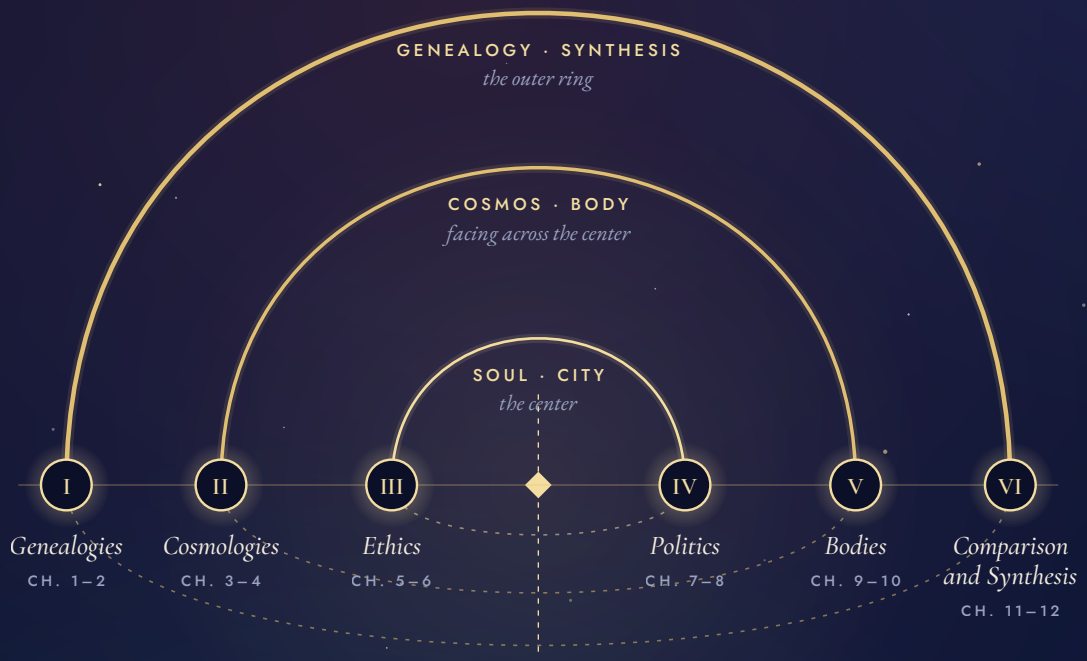
Method and Architecture

The dissertation is divided into six parts. Part One, *Genealogies*, reconstructs the archive (Chapter 1) and the monomythic armature through which it was organized, together with the inversion of that armature in the prequels (Chapter 2). Part Two, *Cosmologies*, reads the Force through Taoist, Zen, Stoic, Spinozan, and Augustinian frames (Chapter 3) and then through the symbiotic biology that the midi-chlorians introduce (Chapter 4). Part Three, *Ethics*, analyzes the pathogenesis of the dark side through Buddhist psychology and the psychoanalysis of mourning (Chapter 5) and the failure of the Jedi through Kierkegaard, Eckhart, and Mahāyāna polemic (Chapter 6). Part Four, *Politics*, reconstructs the fall of the Republic through classical, early modern, and twentieth-century political theory (Chapter 7) and then reads the clone army as an immune system (Chapter 8). Part Five, *Bodies*, interprets Vader and the Death Star as armored bodies (Chapter 9) and the climactic sequence of the saga as a kenotic unmasking (Chapter 10). Part Six, *Comparison and Synthesis*,

sets Lucas beside cognate mythopoeias (Chapter 11) and formalizes the theory of symbiotic theodicy in five propositions (Chapter 12). A Coda considers the afterlives of the mask in the post-Lucasian franchise.

The architecture is deliberately chiastic, in homage to its object. Parts One and Six, genealogy and synthesis, form the outer ring; Parts Two and Five, cosmos and body, face one another across the center; and Parts Three and Four, soul and city, occupy the center itself, joined by the analogy that Plato placed at the hinge of the *Republic* (368c–369a), where the city is introduced as the soul written in larger letters. The saga, as Chapters 7 and 8 will show, is a narrative in which that analogy holds with terrible exactness: the Republic falls as Anakin falls, by the same affect and through the same defensive reflex.

A · B · C · C′ · B′ · A′



THE HINGE

Plato, Republic 368c–369a: the city introduced as the soul written in larger letters

PLATE I

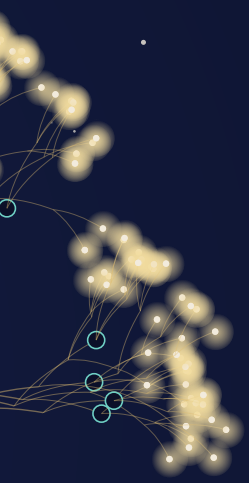
The architecture of this study

Six parts in chiasmus. Genealogy and synthesis form the outer ring, cosmos and body face one another across the center, and soul and city occupy the center itself, joined at the hinge by Plato's analogy.

SEE INTRODUCTION, I.4







I

PART ONE

Genealogies

CHAPTER 1

The Bricoleur's Archive

Pulp, Cinema, and the Drafts of the Whills

CHAPTER 2

The Monomyth and Its Inversion

CHAPTER

1

The Bricoleur's Archive

Pulp, Cinema, and the Drafts of the Whills

The archive from which Lucas assembled the saga is not a random accumulation but a sorted one. Every major source falls along a single axis, between disciplined orders whose power is spiritual and exposed and technological apparatuses whose power is mechanical and armored, and that axis is the immunitary axis the remainder of this study will trace.

1.1

The Pulp Substrate: Burroughs, Raymond, Smith, Brackett

The saga's generic substrate is the planetary romance of the American pulps, a form whose founding text is Edgar Rice Burroughs's *A Princess of Mars* (serialized 1912; book form 1917). Burroughs established the conventions Lucas would inherit wholesale: an archaic warrior aristocracy surviving amid ruined superscience, swordplay persisting beside radium weapons, a captive princess whose rescue organizes the plot, and a dying world whose decadence licenses the hero's restorative violence. Alex Raymond's *Flash Gordon* (comic strip from 1934; Universal serials 1936, 1938, and 1940) translated this template into a visual and serial grammar: the planet Mongo as a feudal mosaic of vassal kingdoms, the tyrant Ming as an Orientalist emperor, the chapter structure of cliffhanger and recapitulation, the scrolling expository prologue, and the wipe transition. Lucas's later numbering of his films as "Episodes" of a serial whose earlier installments the audience had not seen is a direct inheritance of the serial's *in medias res* convention, and *The Empire Strikes Back*, which ends with its hero maimed and its rogue frozen, is the most expensive cliffhanger ever staged.

E. E. "Doc" Smith's *Lensman* sequence (serialized 1937–1948; collected 1948–1954) supplied a third element absent from Burroughs and Raymond: an interstellar military order whose officers possess parapsychological powers conferred by the Lens, a pseudo-living crystal attuned to a single bearer and lethal to any other who touches it. The Lensman cosmos is governed by a Manichaean opposition between the benevolent Arisians and the tyrannical Eddorians, and its plot culminates in a centuries-long Arisian breeding program that produces the "Children of the Lens." The galactic order of psychic knights, the crystal attuned to its bearer, the cosmic dualism, and the eugenic messiah all reappear in the saga, the last of these in the undecidable conception of Anakin Skywalker (Chapter 4). The pulp lineage entered the saga's text directly when Leigh Brackett—author of planetary romances and of the screenplays for *The Big Sleep* (1946) and *Rio Bravo* (1959)—wrote the first draft of *The Empire Strikes Back* before her death in March 1978.

What the pulps bequeathed was less a set of motifs than a chronotope, in Mikhail Bakhtin's sense: the "adventure-time" of the Greek romance, in which trials accumulate without altering the hero's essential identity, which they test rather than form (Bakhtin 1981). The saga's structural innovation, as Chapter 2 will show, is to graft this adventure-time onto its opposite—the biographical and tragic time of Anakin, in which every trial is formative and the self is irreversibly remade—and to make the meeting of the two chronotopes the moment of redemption.

1.2

The Cinematic Palimpsest

Kurosawa Akira's *The Hidden Fortress* (*Kakushi toride no san akunin*, 1958) furnished the narrative matrix of the 1973 treatment: a disguised princess escorted across hostile territory by a veteran general, the whole focalized through two quarrelsome peasants whose cowardice and greed comically refract the heroic action. Lucas has acknowledged the debt, and the peasants' metamorphosis into R2-D2 and C-3PO is the saga's most consequential act of transposition, for it establishes that the myth will be narrated from below, through beings whose status is servile. Kurosawa's *Yojimbo* (1961) supplied the severed arm of the cantina; his wipes supplied the saga's punctuation; and the *jidaigeki*, the period drama of the samurai, supplied both a costume grammar—Obi-Wan's layered robes, the *kabuto*-derived silhouette of Vader's helmet—and, by Lucas's own account, an acoustic seed for the word "Jedi." After the fall of the Order, Obi-Wan is a *rōnin*, a masterless retainer whose lord has been destroyed.

John Ford's *The Searchers* (1956) supplied the burned homestead of Owen and Beru Lars and, more darkly, the template for Anakin's massacre of the Tusken camp in *Attack of the Clones*, which restages Ethan Edwards's vengeance on the Comanche as the first act of the hero's damnation. By his own confession, Anakin killed the men, women, and children of the camp. The film codes the Tuskens through the Western's iconography of the Native American raider and never grants them speech; it condemns the massacre only as a station of Anakin's fall; and Padmé, hearing his confession, consoles rather than judges him, so that the hero's first atrocity is absorbed by intimacy and never reaches the institution that might have answered it. The Western also supplied the saga's geography of center and periphery—the Outer Rim as frontier, Tatooine as a lawless territory beyond the Republic's writ where slavery persists—and with it the residue of Frederick Jackson Turner's thesis that the frontier is the crucible of the self-reliant individual (Turner 1893). Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927) supplied the gilded *Maschinenmensch* on which Ralph McQuarrie modeled C-3PO. Leni Riefenstahl's *Triumph des Willens* (1935) supplied the axial composition of the medal ceremony that closes *A New Hope*, so that the Rebellion's triumph is staged in the visual grammar of the Nazi Party's 1934 Nuremberg rally, which Riefenstahl filmed at Hitler's commission. Whether this borrowing is homage, irony, or inadvertence, it constitutes the first symptom of the text's autoimmune reflexivity: the rebels celebrate their victory over the Empire in the Empire's aesthetic. The Second World War combat film, finally—*The Dam Busters* (1955) above all, from which the Death Star trench run derives its geometry—supplied the kinetic syntax of the space battles, for which Lucas assembled reels of wartime dogfight footage as previsualization.

The most intimate cinematic source is the least known. Arthur Lipsett's *21-87* (National Film Board of Canada, 1963), a nine-minute collage of discarded footage and found sound, made an impression on Lucas at the University of Southern California that he has repeatedly acknowledged. Its soundtrack samples the filmmaker Roman Kroitor reflecting that people sense in contemplating nature a kind of force behind the visible mask of things, and this passage has been widely proposed as a source for the saga's central term. The homage is explicit in the cell number of Princess Leia's detention on the Death Star, 2187. Lipsett's method—meaning generated by the juxtaposition of salvaged fragments—is bricolage made cinematic, and it is no accident that the saga's metaphysical keyword descends from a collage.

1.3

Literary Interlocutors

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) is the saga's nearest literary sibling: a desert planet, a precious spice, a disciplined sisterhood whose "Voice" compels obedience, a messianic youth whose prophesied power is the product of a breeding program. Brian Herbert reports that his father identified numerous points of correspondence between the novel and *Star Wars* and that he and other science-fiction writers jokingly formed a "We're Too Big to Sue George Lucas Society" (Herbert 2003). The difference between the two works is more instructive than their resemblance, for Herbert wrote explicitly to warn against charismatic saviors, whereas Lucas, as Chapter 11 will argue, relocates the danger from the savior's charisma to the savior's fear.

Isaac Asimov's *Foundation* stories (1942–1950; collected 1951–1953) supplied the galactic empire in decline on Gibbon's model, the city-planet Trantor, and the problem of prediction. Lucas's own ecumenopolis was deferred: an Imperial capital planned for *Return of the Jedi* was abandoned for technical and budgetary reasons, and when it finally appeared in *The Phantom Menace* it bore the name Timothy Zahn had coined in *Heir to the Empire* (1991), Coruscant. J. R. R. Tolkien's influence is structural rather than motivic. Lucas's earliest frame—the story told as an excerpt from the *Journal of the Whills*—parallels Tolkien's fiction of the Red Book of Westmarch, a pseudo-documentary chronicle that converts invention into transmitted lore.

Carlos Castaneda's don Juan sequence (1968–1974) supplied the image of the human being as a luminous rather than material entity and the ethos of the impeccable warrior-sorcerer; Lucas's reading reportedly included *Tales of Power* (1974). Richard de Mille's *Castaneda's Journey* (1976), published the year before *Star Wars*, made a compelling case that don Juan was a fabrication. The saga's shamanism therefore descends in part from a counterfeit, a fact that does not discredit it so much as relocate it: like Possamai's hyper-real religion, the saga's spirituality was assembled from simulacra and became effective nonetheless. Jack Kirby's *Fourth World* (1970–1973)—with its cosmic Source, its tyrant Darkseid seeking an Anti-Life Equation that would abolish free will, and its warrior Orion, Darkseid's son raised by the opposing pantheon—presents parallels too precise to ignore and too undocumented to assert as influence; it is treated in Chapter 11 as a cognate rather than a source. Lucas's own *THX 1138* (1971), finally, is the saga's dystopian prologue: a subterranean society of pharmacological sedation, total surveillance, and faceless

android police, from which a single man escapes upward into light. Its debts to Herbert Marcuse's critique of technological rationality in *One-Dimensional Man* (1964) are evident, and its armored constabulary is the embryo of the stormtrooper.

1.4

From the Journal of the Whills to the Skywalker Saga

The drafting record, reconstructed by Rinzler (2007) and Kaminski (2008), discloses the saga's logic in the act of formation. The 1973 synopsis presents its story as an excerpt from the *Journal of the Whills*, concerning a revered "Jedi-Bendu" as related by his apprentice; the ensuing treatment follows *The Hidden Fortress* closely. The 1974 rough draft introduces Annikin Starkiller, an aged General Luke Skywalker, and Kane Starkiller, a father who has lost much of his body and survives through mechanical replacements. The cyborg father thus enters the saga in its first full draft, but not as a villain: he is a wounded mentor, and prosthesis is not yet coded as damnation. The 1975 second draft introduces the "Force of Others," divided into a benevolent Ashla and a malevolent Bogan, together with the Kiber Crystal, an object that amplifies the Force. The later drafts converge on the familiar shape; the surname Starkiller is abandoned for Skywalker during production; and the decisive revelation of Vader's paternity emerges only in Lucas's own revisions of *The Empire Strikes Back* in 1978, after Brackett's draft had presented Luke's father as a separate spectral figure.

Two movements in this record organize everything that follows. The first is a movement from *dualism to monism with an aspect*: the Ashla and the Bogan, two forces in Manichaean opposition, collapse into a single Force with a dark side. This is a theological decision of the first importance, since it converts evil from a rival principle into a deformation of the one principle, and it is the precondition of the pathological reading developed in Chapters 3 and 4. The second is a movement of *condensation*, in Freud's sense of the dream-work's *Verdichtung*: the wounded cyborg father and the black-armored villain, distinct in the early drafts, are fused into a single body. In that fusion, prosthesis, paternity, and evil become one figure —a father who survives only by being armored, and who is evil to precisely the extent that he is armored. The condensation that produces Darth Vader is the founding act of the saga's immunitary logic.

THE DRAFTING RECORD



I · FROM DUALISM TO MONISM

with an aspect



II · CONDENSATION

Verdichtung

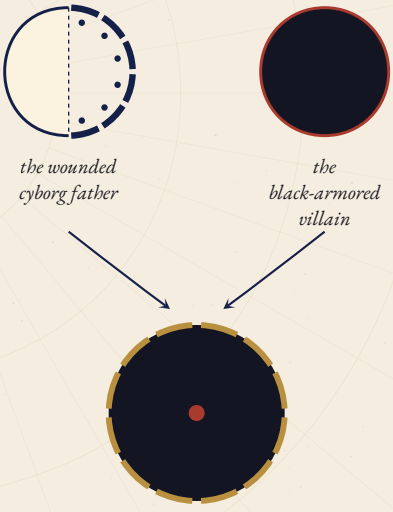


PLATE II

From dyad to monism

The drafting record, 1973–1978, and the two movements it discloses: the Ashla and the Bogan collapse into one Force with a dark side, and the wounded cyborg father and the black-armored villain condense into a single body.

SEE § 1.4

1.5

Bricolage as Method

Lévi-Strauss distinguished the bricoleur from the engineer: the engineer subordinates materials to a project conceived in advance, whereas the bricoleur interrogates a pre-existing stock whose elements are already "pre-constrained" by their histories and builds meaning from their rearrangement (Lévi-Strauss 1962). The saga's sources retain their prior meanings—Riefenstahl remains fascist, Ford's vengeance remains genocidal, Castaneda remains counterfeit—and the new arrangement does not erase those meanings but sets them against one another. The principle of selection, however, is not random. Every major source either stages a disciplined order whose power is spiritual and whose bodies are exposed (the Lensmen, the samurai, the Jedi-Bendu, Castaneda's luminous warrior) or a technological apparatus whose power is mechanical and whose bodies are armored (Lang's machine-woman, THX's android police, Ming's war machines, the bomber stream re-imagined as the Death Star's attackers). The archive is pre-sorted along the axis of exposure and protection. That axis, which the bricoleur found already latent in his materials, becomes in the finished saga the coordinate system of a metaphysics.

1.6

Names as Archive, and the Author's Father

The Prefatory Note promised the saga's onomastic resonances; they can now be gathered, as resonances rather than documented derivations unless Lucas has said otherwise. Palpatine echoes the Palatine Hill (Chapter 7). Padmé echoes the Sanskrit *padma*, lotus, and Amidala the Japanese Amida, the Buddha Amitābha; together they summon the mantra *oṃ maṇi padme hūṃ*, conventionally rendered "the jewel in the lotus"—a rendering Donald Lopez has argued is a Western misreading (Lopez 1998), but an apt name, even so, for the mother of twin jewels. Qui-Gon evokes *qigong*, the cultivation of *qi*, and Jinn the Arabic *jinn*, spirits: the master of the living Force bears the names of breath-discipline and of spirit, and he is the first of the Jedi to survive death as a spirit. Dagobah evokes the Sinhala *dāgaba*, the stupa, from the Pali *dhātugabbha*, relic-chamber: Yoda's swamp hermitage is a reliquary in which the last relic of the Order is kept. Skywalker corresponds closely to the Sanskrit *khecara*, "moving in the sky," and to the Tibetan *mkha' 'gro*, "sky-goer," the epithet of the *ḍākinī*. Dooku sounds the Japanese *doku*, poison; Sidious contains "insidious"; and Solo names the exempt individual (Chapter 8). Lucas has glossed Vader as a variation on "dark father," and the Dutch *vader* simply means

father; Luke's name has often been read as an abridgment of the author's own. Together these names show the bricoleur's method reaching down to the phoneme: each is a fragment of another culture's sacred or martial vocabulary, reset in a new arrangement.

The biographical record supplies a last source, one that Lucas has discouraged critics from pressing. His father, George Lucas Sr., owned a stationery business in Modesto and expected his son to take it over; the son refused, and the estrangement eased only with his success (Pollock 1983; Jones 2016). In June 1962, days before his high-school graduation, Lucas survived a car crash that he has described as a turning point. A saga whose hero refuses the destiny his father offers, survives a brush with death, and is reconciled with the father on his own terms is not reducible to autobiography, and the intentional fallacy forbids making it so. But the relay monomyth of Chapter 2—a son who completes his father's journey by refusing the role the father assigns him—has a plausible root in its author's life, and the saga's insistence that reconciliation, not patricide, ends the war between father and son is its least Freudian and perhaps its most personal conviction.

CHAPTER

2

The Monomyth and Its Inversion

The saga is not a naive instance of Joseph Campbell's monomyth but a single monomyth distributed across two generations and interrupted in the first: Anakin's journey halts at the threshold of atonement and is completed vicariously by his son, so that Luke's return is, structurally, the return his father could not make.

2.1

Campbell's Genealogy

The Hero with a Thousand Faces (1949) is itself a bricolage. Campbell borrowed the term "monomyth" from Joyce's *Finnegans Wake*; its tripartite formula of separation, initiation, and return from Arnold van Gennep's *Les Rites de passage* (1909), which had analyzed initiation as *séparation*, *marge*, and *agrégation*; its premise of a universal substrate beneath cultural variation from Adolf Bastian's distinction between *Elementargedanken* and *Völkergedanken*, mediated by Leo Frobenius's morphology of culture; its psychology from Freud and, above all, Jung, whose archetypes of the collective unconscious—the Shadow, the Wise Old Man, the Anima, the Self—supply the dramatis personae of the inner journey; and its Indological depth from Heinrich Zimmer, whose posthumous works Campbell edited. Behind these stand two earlier comparative morphologies of heroic biography: Otto Rank's psychoanalytic *Der Mythus von der Geburt des Helden* (1909), in which the hero is a child of distinguished parents, exposed in infancy, raised by humble foster-parents, and destined to confront the father, and Lord Raglan's *The Hero* (1936), whose twenty-two-point pattern awards Oedipus twenty-one.

Lucas has repeatedly credited Campbell with helping him impose order on drafts that had grown unmanageable, and the public friendship of the 1980s, culminating in the filming of *The Power of Myth* at Skywalker Ranch, has made the attribution canonical. Kaminski (2008) has argued, on the evidence of the drafts, that the monomythic shape emerged in part independently and that Campbell's role was magnified retrospectively. The dispute need not be adjudicated here, because the more important fact is that Rank's pattern fits Luke with uncanny precision—distinguished parents, a Jedi and a queen; concealment in infancy on a desert world; humble foster-parents who are moisture farmers; a destined confrontation with the father—except at the one point where Rank's Freudian schema is most insistent. Rank's hero takes vengeance on the father. Lucas's hero refuses to.

2.2

Luke Skywalker and the Canonical Monomyth

The original trilogy executes Campbell's sequence with a fidelity bordering on the didactic. The *call to adventure* arrives through a herald who is a servant—Leia's message borne by a droid—and the *refusal of the call* is Luke's appeal to his obligations on the farm. *Supernatural aid* is Obi-Wan's gift of the father's weapon, a talisman that is also an inheritance. The *crossing of the first threshold* is rendered irreversible by the incineration of the foster-parents, after which no return to the ordinary world is possible. The *belly of the whale*, Campbell's image of the hero's apparent annihilation within the monster, is literalized in the Death Star's refuse compactor, where the walls close in and a creature lurks in the waste. It is worth registering at once what Chapter 9 will develop: the hero enters the armored body through its waste system and destroys it, in the climax of the same film, through another waste orifice, the thermal exhaust port. The *road of trials* is the Dagobah apprenticeship; the *meeting with the goddess* is complicated retroactively by the revelation that the princess is the hero's twin, which deflects the anima from an erotic to a syzygial figure; and the *atonement with the father*, which Campbell glossed etymologically as "at-one-ment," is the subject of the entire final film.

2.3

Anakin Skywalker and the Negative Monomyth

The prequels do not abandon the monomyth; they invert it stage by stage, so that each station of the hero's journey becomes a station of damnation. The table below sets the two journeys side by side.

CAMPBELL'S STAGE	LUKE (EPISODES IV–VI)	ANAKIN (EPISODES I–III)
Call to adventure	A princess's message carried by a droid	A Jedi's arrival in a slaver's shop
Refusal of the call	Duty to the foster-parents' farm	No refusal: the call coincides with appetite for freedom and power
Supernatural aid	Obi-Wan, then Yoda	Qui-Gon, killed before the initiation completes; replaced by an inadequate surrogate and a counterfeit mentor
First threshold	Foster-parents burned; return foreclosed	Mother left in slavery; separation as unhealed wound
Belly of the whale	The Death Star's refuse compactor	The droid control ship, destroyed from within by accident
Meeting with the goddess	Leia, revealed as twin	Padmé, secretly married against the Order's rule
Atonement with the father	Refusal to kill Vader; the father's conversion	Apostasy: the severing of Mace Windu's hand; submission to the false father
Apotheosis	Becoming a Jedi by renouncing the weapon	The operating table rising to vertical: a mechanical anti-apotheosis
Ultimate boon	The father's redemption	The power to save Padmé, sought and inverted into her death
Return	Festival on Endor; master of two worlds	No return: twenty years of exile inside the armor

Three inversions carry particular weight. The absence of a refusal of the call is a symptom rather than an omission: refusal, in Campbell's scheme, expresses the hero's attachment to the ordinary world, and its humility is the precondition of a proportionate response to the extraordinary; Anakin, a slave for whom the ordinary world is bondage, has nothing to refuse and therefore no measure. The premature death of the true mentor—Qui-Gon, the dissident practitioner of what he calls the living Force—leaves the initiation incomplete and opens a vacancy that two substitutes compete to fill: Obi-Wan, who loves Anakin as a brother but cannot father him, and Palpatine, who offers precisely the paternal recognition the Order withholds. The apotheosis, finally, is staged as a grotesque literalization: the operating table on which Vader is assembled tilts upward to the vertical, so that the moment of the hero's elevation is the moment of his entombment. The negative monomyth

is thus not a failure of the heroic form but a demonstration that the form is morally neutral. The same stations that lead to self-transcendence lead, when the hero's motive is fear rather than love, to tyranny.

The saga's deepest structural invention follows from this. Because Anakin's journey halts at the atonement, it can be completed only by another. Luke's "at-one-ment" with his father in *Return of the Jedi* is, from the father's side, the return Anakin never made: the ultimate boon he sought (the power to keep a beloved from death) is granted in transfigured form (the son's refusal to let the father die unredeemed), and the threshold he could not recross (from armor back to flesh) is recrossed in the unmasking. The saga is accordingly a *relay monomyth*, a single heroic cycle that passes between generations like a baton, and its unit of heroism is not the individual but the lineage.

2.4

Propp, Frye, and the Morphology of a Space Romance

Vladimir Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (1928) distributes the folktale's thirty-one functions among seven spheres of action: villain, donor, helper, princess and her father, dispatcher, hero, and false hero. *A New Hope* populates these spheres with textbook clarity—Vader and Tarkin as villains, Obi-Wan as donor of the magical agent, Han, Chewbacca, and R2-D2 as helpers, Leia as princess and dispatcher at once. The completed saga then performs an operation that Propp's morphology cannot accommodate: it fuses two spheres that the folktale keeps rigorously apart. The princess's father, whose function in the tale is to recognize and reward the hero, is revealed to be the villain, whose function is to harm him. The morphology folds back upon itself, and the plot's resolution requires not the villain's defeat but the conversion of the villain into the princess's father, that is, the transfer of a single person from one sphere of action to another.

Northrop Frye's theory of *mythoi* in the *Anatomy of Criticism* (1957) supplies the macro-structural complement. Frye arranges narrative into four pre-generic plots corresponding to the seasons: comedy (spring), romance (summer), tragedy (autumn), and irony or satire (winter). The six films traverse the entire wheel. *The Phantom Menace* is romance in the phase of innocence, a child-hero's quest; *Attack of the Clones* is romance of desire; *Revenge of the Sith* is tragedy in the strict Aristotelian sense, a fall from prosperity through *hamartia*; *A New Hope* is quest-romance in Frye's three movements of *agon*, *pathos*, and *anagnorisis*; *The Empire Strikes Back* is romance driven into irony, the hero defeated, mutilated, and robbed of his illusions; and *Return of the Jedi* is comedy, the formation of a new society



PLATE III

The relay monomyth

Campbell's stations as one cycle shared by two generations. Anakin's journey halts at the atonement; Luke completes it, and the return the father never made is made through the son.

SEE § 2.3

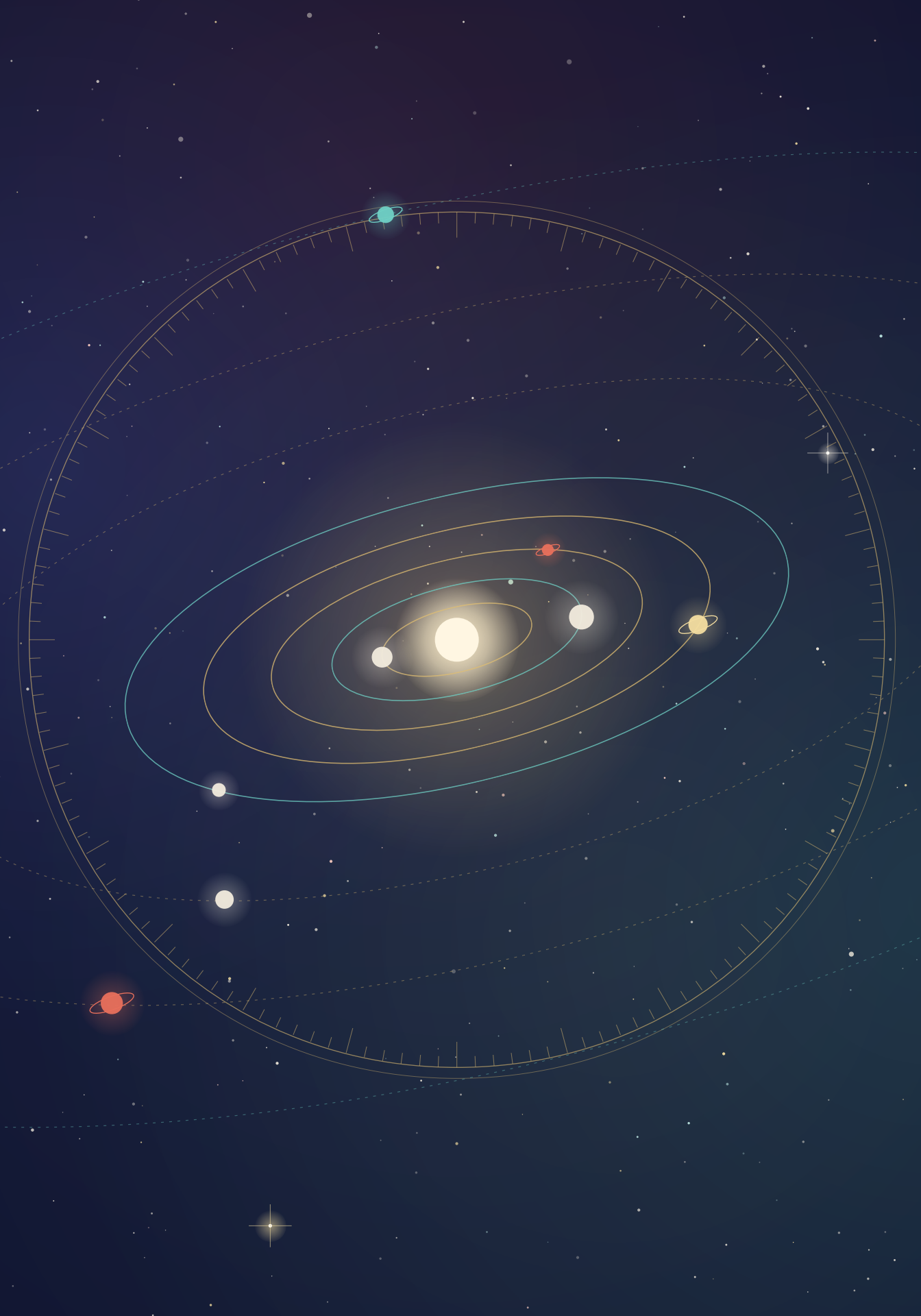
around the young and its celebration in a festival. Frye observes that comedy tends to include rather than expel, so that its blocking characters are more often reconciled or converted than repudiated, and that what it cannot include it expels as a *pharmakos*. The final film distributes these two comic destinies with precision: the blocking father is converted and the Emperor is cast down a shaft as scapegoat.

2.5

The Discontents of Universalism

Campbell's universalism has been contested on four fronts. Folklorists, Alan Dundes most audibly, faulted the comparative method for abstracting motifs from the cultural contexts that give them meaning and for mistaking selection for discovery. Robert Segal (1987) exposed the circularity by which a pattern is found everywhere because the cases are chosen for exhibiting it, and the dependence of the theory on a Jungian psychology it never defends. Brendan Gill's essay in *The New York Review of Books* (1989) charged Campbell with antisemitism and a reactionary politics and read his maxim "follow your bliss" as a license for self-absorption; colleagues and later biographers disputed the characterization (Larsen and Larsen 1991), and the controversy has never fully closed. The charge bears directly on this study, since a heroic journey that equates fulfillment with personal bliss is, on the saga's own terms, the ethic of the dark side. Feminist critics, beginning with Maureen Murdock's *The Heroine's Journey* (1990), argued that the monomyth universalizes a masculine developmental narrative of separation and conquest. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986) generalized the last objection into a poetics: the heroic narrative is the story of the spear, the killer's story, and it has crowded out an older and truer narrative modeled on the container—the sack, the gourd, the bag in which things are gathered, carried, and shared.

The saga's own history compounds these objections. Christopher Vogler's 1985 memorandum for the Disney studio, expanded as *The Writer's Journey* (1992), converted Campbell's description into an industrial prescription, and the conversion was licensed by Lucas's success. What began as a hermeneutic of myth became a formula for its mass production. The saga's text, however, contains a critique of the monomyth that its industrial afterlife ignored. The prequels demonstrate that the hero's journey can terminate in tyranny; and the climax of *Return of the Jedi* refuses the monomyth's martial telos. Luke's victory is not a killing. He casts away his weapon, and the final image is not a trophy but a gathering in a forest, among beings who fight with stones and logs and celebrate with drums. The saga begins as a spear and ends as a carrier bag.



II

PART TWO

Cosmologies

CHAPTER 3

The Force as Tao, Pneuma, and Substance

CHAPTER 4

The Symbiotic Turn

Midi-chlorians and the Holobiont

CHAPTER

3

The Force as Tao, Pneuma, and Substance

The Force is a syncretic construct whose components—Taoist, Zen, Stoic, Spinozan, and Augustinian—converge on a single structural claim: that the cosmos is one living, self-relating whole, and that the dark side is not a rival principle but a hypertrophy within it. The saga's light/dark vocabulary invites a dualist reading that its metaphysics consistently refuses.

3.1

The Tao That Can Be Named

Obi-Wan's first definition of the Force, delivered in Luke's hovel in *A New Hope*, is triply relational: the Force is an energy field produced by all living things; it surrounds and penetrates them; and it binds the galaxy together. It is thus at once *effect* of life, *medium* of life, and *bond* among the living. The closest classical analogue is the *dao* of the *Daodejing*, whose opening line warns that the way that can be spoken of is not the constant way, and the name that can be named is not the constant name (ch. 1). The saga honors that apophatic caution in its own idiom: Obi-Wan's later admission that his account of Anakin's death was true only from a certain point of view is the Taoist relativization of naming turned into an ethics of narration. The cosmogony of chapter 42 supplies the saga's grammar of balance: the way gives birth to the one, the one to the two, the two to the three, and the three to the ten thousand things; the ten thousand things carry *yin* on their backs and embrace *yang*, and through the blending of *qi* they attain harmony. Balance, in this cosmology, is not an equal quantity of two substances but *he*, a harmony produced by blending.

This matters because the most common philosophical misreading of the saga equates light and dark with *yang* and *yin* and infers that "balance" requires both in equal measure. The inference fails on the Taoist evidence. *Yin* and *yang* are complementary, not moral, and the Taoist sage cultivates *yin*: the *Daodejing* counsels knowing the masculine but keeping to the feminine (ch. 28), praises water as the softest thing under heaven that nonetheless overcomes the hard (ch. 78), and declares that the hard and rigid are companions of death while the soft and supple are companions of life (ch. 76). In the saga, the qualities of the light side—receptivity, patience, yielding, smallness—are *yin* qualities, embodied in a diminutive master who asks whether his pupil would judge him by his size. The qualities of the dark side—aggression, acquisition, rigidity, armor—are *yang* qualities in excess. The dark side is therefore not *yin*; it is *yang* hypertrophied, one pole swollen at the expense of the system. The Taoist structure beneath the light/dark surface is not *good versus evil* but *harmony versus hypertrophy*, and this is the first evidence for the pathological reading this study advances. Chapter 33 supplies the corresponding ethic: to overcome others is force, to overcome oneself is strength. The Sith master others; the Jedi, at their best, master themselves.

Two further passages bear directly on the saga. Chapter 48 observes that in the pursuit of learning one gains something every day, while in the pursuit of the way one loses something every day; Yoda's instruction that Luke must unlearn what he has learned is an almost literal paraphrase. And chapter 5 delivers the *Daodejing*'s most austere teaching: heaven and earth are not humane (*ren*); they treat the ten thousand things as straw dogs. The Force, so understood, is impartial. Its "will," invoked repeatedly by Qui-Gon, is not a moral providence but a tendency of the whole, and the moral work of the saga must therefore be done by persons. C. S. Lewis's *The Abolition of Man* (1943) borrowed "the Tao" as a name for objective moral law; Lucas borrowed something nearer to the Tao as vital order. The saga oscillates between the two appropriations—the Force as amoral life and the Force as source of moral orientation—and Chapter 4 will argue that the oscillation resolves once the Force is understood as *symbiotic* life, in which mutualism is the moral form of vitality itself.

3.2

Wu Wei and the Fasting of the Mind: Zhuangzi on Dagobah

The saga's practical teaching of the Force is a pedagogy of *wu wei*, non-coercive action, and *ziran*, spontaneity. The locus classicus is the parable of Cook Ding in the third chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, whose blade remains as sharp after nineteen years

as when it left the whetstone because it never strikes bone; it follows the natural articulations of the ox, moving through the spaces that are already there. Luke's training aboard the *Millennium Falcon*, deflecting a remote's bolts with his helmet's blast shield lowered, and his decision in the Death Star trench to switch off his targeting computer, are lessons in Ding's art: action not imposed upon the world but aligned with its grain.

The blast shield exercise has a more precise source. In the fourth chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, Confucius instructs his disciple Yan Hui in the "fasting of the mind" (*xinzhai*): do not listen with the ears but with the mind; not with the mind but with *qi*; for *qi* is empty and waits upon all things. The occlusion of sight to permit a perception that is neither sensory nor discursive is precisely the fast the *Zhuangzi* describes. Yoda's abolition of the category of "trying," on Dagobah, completes the pedagogy. To try is to split agent from act and to anticipate failure; the grammar of trying presupposes a self that exerts effort upon a resistant world. Yoda's binary of doing and not doing collapses that split. When Luke protests that the submerged X-wing is too large to lift, his error is not weakness but metaphysics: he conceives the Force as a quantity of power to be applied, rather than a field in which the distinction between large and small does not hold.

One passage of the *Zhuangzi* bears on the saga with a precision that will become decisive. In chapter 18, Zhuangzi's friend Huizi finds him, after his wife's death, drumming on a basin and singing. Rebuked, Zhuangzi answers that at first he could not help grieving, but then he looked back to her beginning, before she had life or form or *qi*, and saw that her death was a transformation like the passage of the seasons. Yoda's counsel to Anakin in *Revenge of the Sith*—to rejoice for those who transform into the Force rather than mourn them—borrows Zhuangzi's vocabulary of transformation while omitting Zhuangzi's first step. Zhuangzi grieved, and then transcended grief. Yoda prohibits the grief. Chapter 5 will argue that this omission is the hinge on which the saga's tragedy turns.

3.3

Mushin and the Life-Giving Sword: Takuan, Munenori, Musashi

The saga's swordsmanship descends from the Japanese synthesis of Zen and martial practice. Takuan Sōhō's letters to the swordmaster Yagyū Munenori, the *Fudōchi shinmyōroku*, teach that the mind must not "stop" upon anything—not upon the opponent's sword, nor one's own, nor the opponent's body—because a mind that abides anywhere is captured there; "immovable wisdom" is paradoxically a mind

that moves without abiding, *mushin*, no-mind. Obi-Wan's injunction that Luke's eyes may deceive him is Takuan's teaching in miniature. Miyamoto Musashi's *Go rin no sho* (1645) distinguishes two modes of the gaze: *kan*, perceiving, which must be strong, and *ken*, seeing, which must be weak. The blast shield subtracts *ken* to strengthen *kan*.

Munenori's own treatise, the *Heihō kadensho* (1632), introduces a distinction that illuminates the saga's ethics of the weapon with unexpected exactness. It opposes *setsuninto*, the death-dealing blade, to *katsujinken*, the life-giving sword, which kills only to prevent killing; and it describes, as a summit of the art, *mutō*, "no-sword," the capacity to prevail without a weapon at all. The lightsaber in Jedi hands is, by doctrine, *katsujinken*, an instrument of defense; in Sith hands it is *setsuninto*. Luke's act in the Emperor's throne room—hurling his lightsaber aside and declaring himself a Jedi as his father was before him—is *mutō*. It is the swordless victory that the Yagyū tradition placed at the apex of swordsmanship, and it is not a renunciation of the Jedi path but its consummation.

These genealogies demand a caveat. The Zen that reached Lucas was the Zen of D. T. Suzuki's *Zen and Japanese Culture* (1959) and Eugen Herrigel's *Zen in the Art of Archery* (1948), a Zen already reconstructed for Western consumption and, as Robert Sharf (1993) has shown, entangled with Japanese nationalist ideology. Brian Victoria (1997) has documented the support that leading Zen institutions and teachers gave to Japanese militarism and imperial war, including teachings that presented selfless, unhesitating killing as an expression of no-mind; his reading of D. T. Suzuki in particular has been contested (Satō 2008). Yamada Shōji (2009) has demonstrated the gap between Herrigel's famous account—a master striking the target in darkness, his second arrow splitting the first—and the practice of his teacher Awa Kenzō, as well as Herrigel's membership, from 1937, in the Nazi Party. The saga's Asianism is therefore a Western construct of the kind Edward Said (1978) taught us to read as Orientalism. The present study acknowledges this while maintaining, as with Castaneda, that a construct may be functionally coherent within the new system that adopts it. What matters for the argument is not the authenticity of the saga's Zen but its position: it is consistently aligned with exposure, yielding, and the renunciation of instruments. The militarist history nonetheless sharpens the saga's critique of detachment, for it shows that no-mind can serve either sword: the life-giving one, or the soldier's unhesitating obedience. The saga contains both outcomes—Luke's swordless victory, and the clone commanders who receive Order 66 and comply without pause.

3.4

Pneuma and Sympatheia: The Stoic Inheritance

The Stoic theory of *pneuma* is the Western cognate of the Taoist *qi* and the nearest classical model for a Force that "binds" the galaxy. For Chrysippus, *pneuma*—a blend of fire and air—pervades all bodies and holds them together through *tonos*, tension, manifesting as cohesion (*hexis*) in stones, growth (*physis*) in plants, soul (*psychē*) in animals, and reason (*logos*) in human beings. The Force is likewise a graded presence in all living things. The Stoic corollary is *sympatheia*, the doctrine that every part of the cosmos is affected by every other because all are parts of one body. Marcus Aurelius states it as a spiritual exercise: think always of the cosmos as a single living being, with one substance and one soul (*Meditations* 4.40). Obi-Wan's collapse at the destruction of Alderaan, when he feels a vast disturbance as of millions of voices crying out and falling silent, is *sympatheia* rendered as phenomenology. The Jedi suffer at a distance because the galaxy is one body.

Stoic ethics supplied the Jedi Code of the Expanded Universe, first articulated in the West End Games roleplaying sourcebook of 1987, whose litany—no emotion, but peace; no passion, but serenity—is a formula of *apatheia*, freedom from the passions understood as false judgments. Yet the Stoic sage is not affectless; he possesses *eupatheiai*, rational joys, wishes, and cautions. And Stoic ethics rests on *oikeiōsis*, the process of appropriation by which concern extends from self to kin to city to humanity. Hierocles pictured the self at the center of concentric circles—self, family, relatives, fellow citizens, the human race—and enjoined us to draw the outer circles toward the center, treating strangers as kin. The late Jedi Order inverts this structure: it demands love of the outermost circle while forbidding the innermost, recruiting children from their families and prohibiting marriage. It asks for universal compassion while severing the root from which, on the Stoic account, universal compassion grows. Luke's compassion for his father proceeds in the Hieroclean direction—from the innermost circle outward to the galaxy—and succeeds where the Order's abstract universalism failed.

3.5

Deus sive Natura: Spinoza and the Immanent Force

Spinoza's *Ethics* (1677) offers the most rigorous Western model of an immanent, impersonal, all-pervading substance: *Deus sive Natura*, God or Nature, considered both as *natura naturans*, active and productive, and as *natura naturata*, the totality of its modes. The Force, which is both generated by living things and binding of

them, has precisely this double aspect. Spinoza's analysis of the affects anticipates the saga's moral psychology with startling precision. Every finite thing strives to persevere in its being (*conatus*, E3P6); fear and hope are inseparable sad passions that cannot in themselves be good (E4P47); and freedom is achieved not by suppressing the affects but by understanding them, so that a passion clearly understood ceases to be a passion (E5P3). In the *Theological-Political Treatise* (1670), Spinoza extends the analysis to politics: superstition is born of and nourished by fear, tyranny exploits fear, and the true purpose of the state is freedom (*TTP* Preface; ch. 20). The chain Spinoza draws—fear, superstition, servitude—is the chain the saga dramatizes in both of its registers: in Anakin's soul and in the Republic's Senate. Spinoza is, in this sense, the philosopher of the saga's central hinge, the identity of the spiritual and political pathologies of fear.

3.6

From Ashla and Bogan to the Dark Side: Mani, Augustine, Canguilhem

The 1975 draft's Ashla and Bogan were Manichaean. Zoroastrian theology had imagined twin spirits who chose between truth and the lie (*Yasna* 30); Mani, in the third century, systematized two co-eternal principles, Light and Darkness, whose mixture constitutes the present cosmos and whose separation constitutes salvation. The finished saga abandoned this dualism for a single Force with a dark side, and in doing so it reenacted Augustine's anti-Manichaean turn. For Augustine, evil has no substance of its own; it is the privation of a good nature (*Confessions* 7.12.18; *Enchiridion* 11), and the evil will has no efficient cause, only a deficient one (*City of God* 12.7). Yoda's teaching on Dagobah—that the dark side is quicker, easier, and more seductive, but not stronger—is Augustinian: evil is parasitic upon the good it corrupts and can produce nothing of its own. The Sith draw on the same Force as the Jedi. They cannot create; they can only consume, deform, and redirect.

Jung contested Augustine on exactly this point. In *Aion* (1951) he rejected the *privatio boni* as a denial of evil's reality and insisted that the shadow must be integrated rather than abolished, a position that underwrites the "Grey Jedi" readings of later fandom. The saga, however, is neither Manichaean nor Jungian nor, strictly, Augustinian. Its evil is real—Vader's suit is not nothing—yet it possesses no independent source. The concept that names this third position is Georges Canguilhem's. In *Le normal et le pathologique* (1943; expanded 1966), Canguilhem argued that disease is not the mere absence of health but a positive mode of life governed by a *reduced norm*: the diseased organism lives, but within a narrowed range, having

lost the capacity—which Canguilhem called *normativity*—to institute new norms in response to new conditions. Health is the margin of tolerance for the infidelities of the environment. The dark side, on this model, is neither a rival substance nor a mere lack but a pathology: life constrained to a reduced norm. Vader cannot breathe unaided, cannot leave his suit, cannot sleep outside a pressurized chamber, cannot touch another being with his own skin. He lives, but within the narrowest norm in the galaxy. The next chapter shows that Lucas's most derided revision supplied the biological substrate this model requires.

CHAPTER

4

The Symbiotic Turn

Midi-chlorians and the Holobiont

The midi-chlorians are not a reduction of the Force to biology but the revelation that the Force is mediated by symbiosis, and this revelation supplies the biological substrate that the pathological reading of evil requires. Read through Lynn Margulis, the most derided passage in the saga is its metaphysical keystone.

4.1

The Scandal of 1999

In *The Phantom Menace*, Qui-Gon Jinn tests a sample of Anakin's blood and finds a midi-chlorian count exceeding twenty thousand, higher than Yoda's. Asked to explain, he describes them as microscopic life forms residing within all living cells, with which we live in symbiosis—forms of life living together for mutual advantage. Without them, he says, life could not exist and we would have no knowledge of the Force; they speak to us continually, conveying the Force's will, and one who learns to quiet the mind will hear them. The reaction among the saga's most invested viewers was immediate and durable: Lucas had, it was said, reduced the numinous to a blood count, converted grace into genetics, and made the Force measurable. Will Brooker's ethnography of the fan community (2002) documents the depth of the resentment.

The objection rests on a category error. Qui-Gon does not say that midi-chlorians *are* the Force; he says that they are the means by which living beings know it and the channel through which its will is communicated. They are not the source but the medium. Lucas himself has explained that he modeled the concept on mitochondria, organelles with their own genome descended from once-independent

bacteria, and in 2018 he disclosed that his unrealized sequel trilogy would have explored a microbiotic world inhabited by beings he called the Whills, who control the universe and feed on the Force—adding, with some ruefulness, that audiences who had hated the midi-chlorians would have hated this more (Cameron 2018). The microbiological dimension was therefore not a lapse but a foundation, and the saga as Lucas conceived it was to culminate in a descent into the symbiotic substrate of the cosmos.

4.2

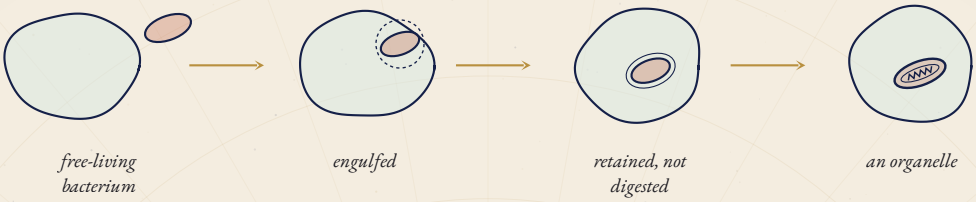
Margulis, Endosymbiosis, and the Mitochondrial Analogy

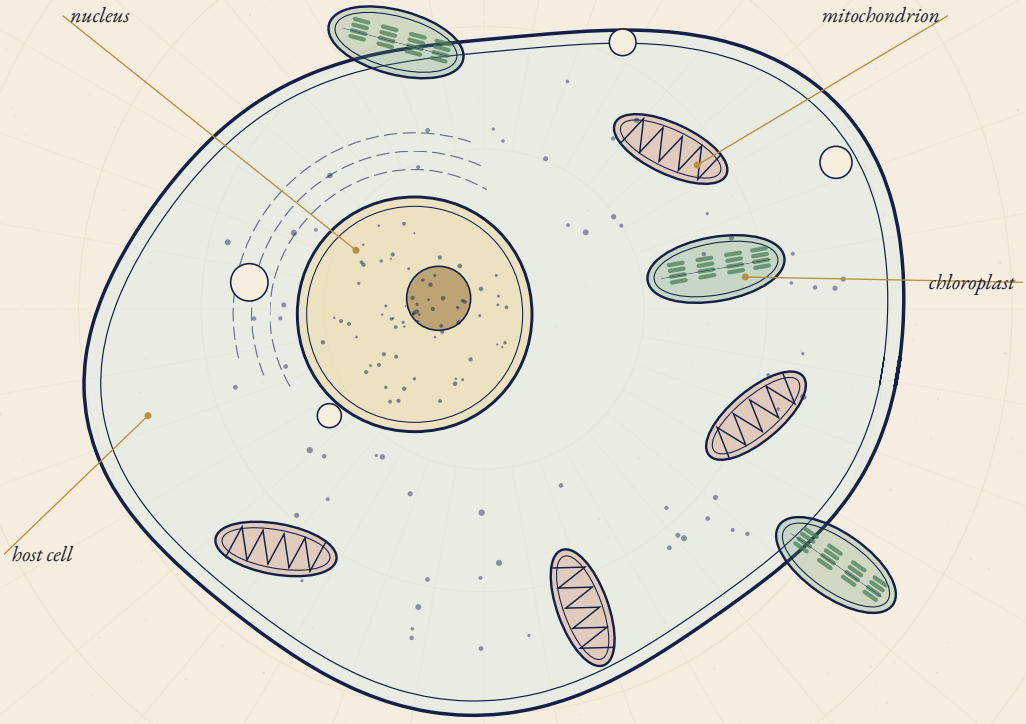
In 1967, publishing as Lynn Sagan, Lynn Margulis proposed in "On the Origin of Mitosing Cells" that the eukaryotic cell arose through serial endosymbiosis: mitochondria and plastids descend from free-living bacteria that were engulfed and retained rather than digested. Anticipated by Konstantin Mereschkowski's theory of symbiogenesis (1905; 1910) and Ivan Wallin's *Symbionticism and the Origin of Species* (1927), the hypothesis was long resisted and then substantially confirmed by the molecular evidence of organellar genomes and ribosomes. The coinage "midichlorian" condenses, phonetically, the two canonical organelles of endosymbiotic theory, the *mito*chondrion and the *chlor*oplast. Whether by design or by acoustic association, the word names exactly the organelles whose bacterial ancestry grounds the claim that every complex cell is a consortium.

The philosophical consequence is that the organism is not an individual in the classical sense. Margulis named the composite entity the *holobiont* (1991), and Scott Gilbert, Jan Sapp, and Alfred Tauber have argued that anatomically, physiologically, developmentally, immunologically, genetically, and evolutionarily, "we have never been individuals" (Gilbert, Sapp, and Tauber 2012). Transposed into the saga, this yields a striking inversion of the heroic ideology the saga is usually taken to express. On Qui-Gon's account, sensitivity to the Force varies with the density of one's symbionts. The most powerful Jedi is therefore the most inhabited being, the least self-enclosed, the most plural. The Chosen One, whose count exceeds all others, is the most porous creature in the galaxy. His tragedy is that the most plural being becomes the most enclosed: the child who carries more symbiotic life than any other ends sealed inside a pressure suit, unable to breathe the air that everyone else shares.

Margulis also set her symbiotic vision explicitly against the neo-Darwinian rhetoric of struggle. Life, she and Dorion Sagan wrote, did not take over the globe by combat but by networking (Margulis and Sagan 1986). The Sith, by contrast, articulate a social Darwinism. Yoda's lapidary statement in *The Phantom Menace* that

SERIAL ENDOSYMBIOSIS





mitochondrion + **chlor**oplast

midi-chlorian

THE ORGANISM AS CONSORTIUM: THE HOLOBIONT

PLATE IV

We have never been individuals

Serial endosymbiosis after Lynn Margulis: free-living bacteria engulfed and retained rather than digested. The coinage midi-chlorian sounds the two organelles whose bacterial ancestry makes every complex cell a consortium.

SEE § 4.2

there are always two Sith, a master and an apprentice, was elaborated in the Expanded Universe (notably Drew Karpyshyn's *Darth Bane* novels, 2006–2009) into a doctrine of survival through ceaseless internecine struggle, in which the apprentice proves fitness by killing the master. The Sith thus misread the biology of their own power: they draw upon a Force mediated by mutualism and theorize it as a war of all against all.

4.3

The Symbiont Circle: Naboo, the Gungans, and Political Mutualism

The political plot of *The Phantom Menace* is a parable of symbiosis at planetary scale. The human Naboo and the amphibious Gungans share a world in mutual contempt; the Naboo are urbane, aesthetic, and pacific, the Gungans tribal and martial. Qui-Gon warns the Gungan leader that the two peoples form a symbiont circle, so that what befalls one will befall the other. The alliance that defeats the occupying Trade Federation is sealed when the true queen, stepping out from behind her decoy, kneels before the Gungan leader to ask for help: the sovereign's gesture of self-exposure is the condition of political mutualism. The film ends with a festival in which Naboo and Gungans celebrate together, a scene that rhymes with the Ewok festival at the end of *Return of the Jedi* and thereby closes the outermost ring of the saga's chiastic structure (Chapter 10).

The two plots of *The Phantom Menace*, which critics treated as an ill-assorted mixture of children's adventure and tedious trade politics, are therefore one theme at two scales: the midi-chlorian plot states the principle of symbiosis at the cellular level, the Naboo–Gungan plot at the political level. The film's unity has been obscured by its tonal disunity. A postcolonial caveat is nonetheless required. The representation of the Gungans, and above all of Jar Jar Binks, was criticized on its release as racially coded caricature: reviewers heard in Jar Jar's pidgin speech and clownish servility the conventions of blackface minstrelsy and a Caribbean stereotype, in the Neimoidian leaders of the Trade Federation an accented caricature of East Asian speech, and in Watto, the hook-nosed and avaricious slave-owning junk dealer, an antisemitic type. Lucas and his collaborators denied any such intent, and Wetmore (2005) has extended that critique to the film's broader economy of alien otherness. The alliance itself is asymmetrical: the human queen commands, while the Gungan army serves as a diversion and is largely overrun. The mutualism the film celebrates is, in the terms of ecology, closer to *commensalism*, in which one partner benefits and the other is merely spared. This limitation is not incidental. It is

the first symptom of a structural flaw in the Republic's mutualism that Chapter 8 will trace to its catastrophe in the Grand Army: the Republic's symbioses are always hierarchical, and its hierarchy is always one step from parasitism.

4.4

Messengers of the Will: A Microbiological Angelology

Qui-Gon's account of the midi-chlorians is above all an account of communication: they speak, continually, and convey a will. In Greek, the messenger is *angelos*. The midi-chlorians occupy the structural position that angels occupy in Neoplatonic and Abrahamic cosmologies: intermediaries between an ineffable source and the multiplicity of creatures, transmitting illumination from the one to the many. In Proclus they are daimonic powers; in the *Celestial Hierarchy* of the Pseudo-Dionysius they are ranks of intelligences through which divine light descends. Lucas's innovation is to relocate the hierarchy inside the cell. The sacred is mediated not from above but from within; not by a cascade of light but by a consortium of life. This is a *microbiological angelology*, and it inverts the vertical cosmos of medieval theology into a cosmos of interiority. Augustine's description of God as more inward than his own innermost self (*interior intimo meo*, *Confessions* 3.6.11) and his doctrine of the inner teacher in *De magistro* find an unexpected material correlate: the Force's will is heard by quieting the mind and listening to what speaks within.

The communicative model also aligns the saga with biosemiotics, the program articulated by Thomas Sebeok and Jesper Hoffmeyer, which treats life as constitutively a process of signs. Niels Jerne, the immunologist whose network theory will matter in Chapter 12, titled his 1984 Nobel lecture "The Generative Grammar of the Immune System," proposing that the repertoire of antibodies functions like a language. The Force, on Qui-Gon's account, is likewise a semiotic field, and the Jedi are its interpreters.

4.5

Gaia and the Whills: Balance as Homeostasis

The years of the saga's genesis were the years of the Gaia hypothesis. James Lovelock and Lynn Margulis proposed in 1974 that the biosphere regulates the planet's atmospheric composition and temperature so as to maintain conditions favorable to life —homeostasis "by and for the biosphere"—and Lovelock popularized the thesis in *Gaia: A New Look at Life on Earth* (1979). Margulis supplied the microbial mechanism. The concept of homeostasis descends from Claude Bernard's *milieu intérieur*

(1865) and was named by Walter Cannon, whose *The Wisdom of the Body* (1932) described the organism's capacity to restore its internal constants after perturbation.

Read in this light, the prophecy that a Chosen One will bring balance to the Force ceases to be an oracle in the Delphic sense and becomes the description of a homeostatic tendency. When a parasitic disturbance grows within a living system, the system generates a corrective response; when the Sith multiply their power, the Force produces a being of unprecedented symbiotic density. Lucas has consistently glossed the prophecy as fulfilled when Anakin destroys the Emperor, which corroborates the homeostatic reading against the reading of balance as parity. Balance is not the equilibrium of two moral substances but the restoration of a set point.

The Whills complete the picture. The earliest frame of the saga presented it as an excerpt from the *Journal of the Whills*; the latest disclosure of Lucas's intentions presents the Whills as microbiotic beings who govern the cosmos and feed upon the Force. Taken together, the first and last words of Lucas's conception imply that the saga is a chronicle kept by the symbionts themselves—a macroscopic drama narrated by its microbiome. The holobiont narrates itself. Homeostasis, however, is not gentle. Fever, inflammation, and the sacrifice of tissue are homeostatic responses that may devastate the organism they serve, and the *Daodejing*'s straw dogs remind us that a self-regulating whole is indifferent to its parts. Chapter 8 will argue that the Clone Wars and Order 66 are, at the level of the Force, an autoimmune crisis within the homeostatic process: a fever that kills the physicians.

4.6

The Undecidable Conception: Anakin, Plagueis, and the Eugenic Messiah

Shmi Skywalker tells Qui-Gon that there was no father: she carried the child and gave birth, and cannot explain it. Qui-Gon infers that the midi-chlorians conceived him, which makes Anakin's conception a virgin birth whose overshadowing agency (Luke 1:35) is symbiotic. In *Revenge of the Sith*, Palpatine tells Anakin the tragedy of Darth Plagueis, a Sith Lord so powerful that he could influence the midi-chlorians to create life and to keep those he loved from dying, and who was murdered in his sleep by his apprentice. The juxtaposition of the two scenes, six years apart in release, renders Anakin's origin undecidable. Either the Force conceived him as a corrective to the Sith, or the Sith engineered him as their weapon. The films decline to decide, and the Expanded Universe novel *Darth Plagueis* (Luceno 2012) tellingly splits the difference, depicting the Sith's manipulation of the Force as provoking a

PARITY

the equipoise of light and dark

SET ASIDE



the "Grey Jedi" of later fandom

EXTERMINATION

the pure victory of light

SET ASIDE

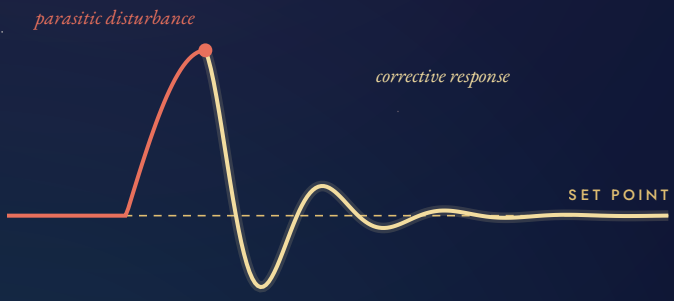


the dark side destroyed rather than healed

HOMEOSTASIS

the restoration of a set point

ADOPTED HERE



the system returns to its own capacity for self-regulation

PLATE V

Three figures of balance

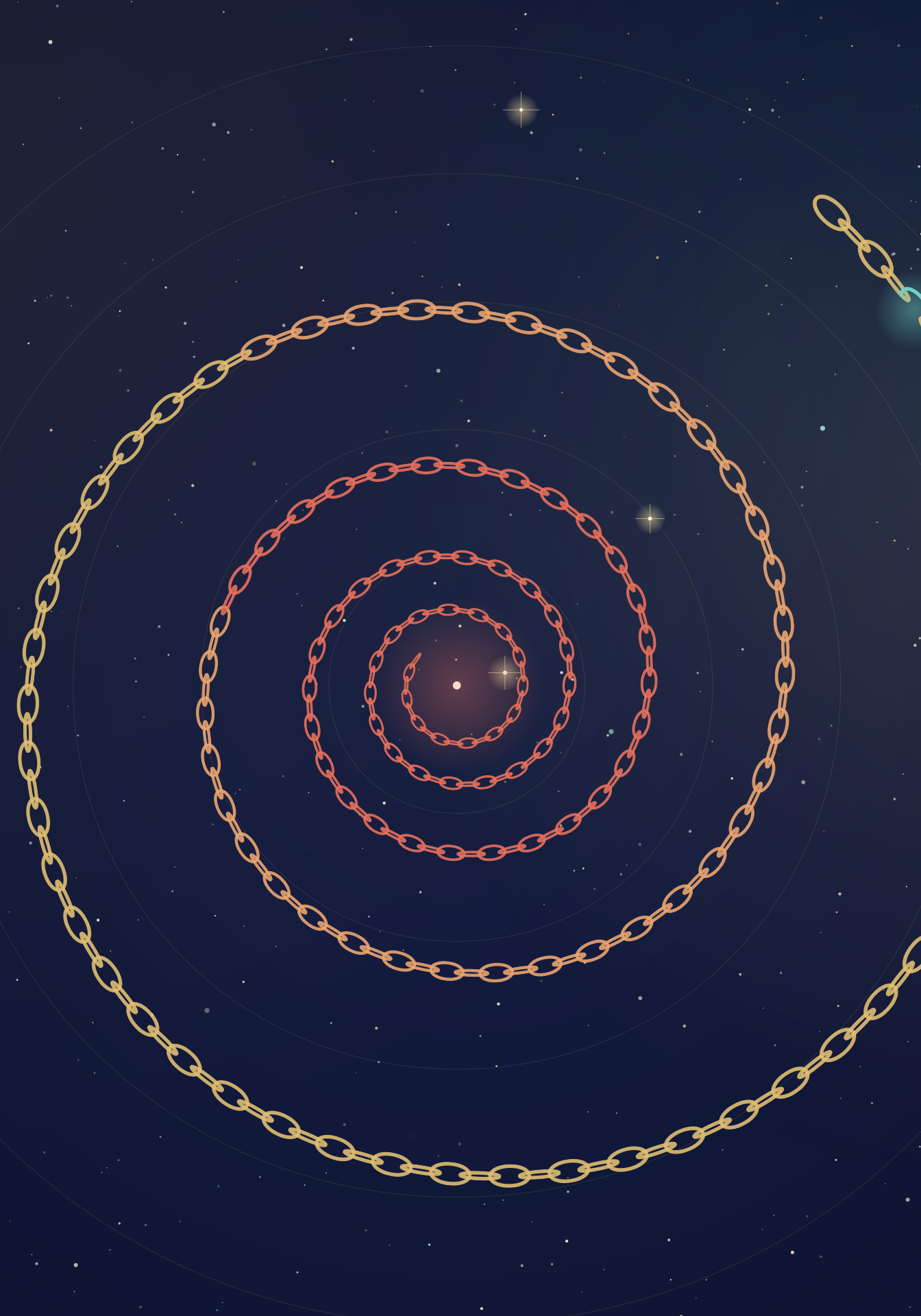
Parity and extermination, set aside, beside the reading adopted here: balance as homeostasis, the return of a living system to its set point after a parasitic disturbance.

SEE § 1.3 AND § 4.5

counter-movement associated with Anakin's conception—an apocryphal reading that arrives independently at the immunological intuition.

The eugenic messiah is a topos of twentieth-century speculative fiction. E. E. Smith's Arisians breed the Children of the Lens over millennia; Herbert's Bene Gesserit breed toward the Kwisatz Haderach. In both cases the messiah is an engineered product, and in Herbert's case the engineering escapes its engineers. Lucas's contribution is undecidability: Anakin is either the Force's providence or the Sith's design, and the saga suggests that he is both. This undecidability is the structure of autoimmunity itself. An immune response is produced by the system it defends; the antibody is self. Anakin is at once the Force's defense against the Sith and the Sith's instrument against the Jedi, and he fulfills both possibilities, destroying the Jedi in *Revenge of the Sith* and the Sith in *Return of the Jedi*. Derrida argued that autoimmunity is not an accident befalling living systems but the condition of their openness: a system that immunized itself absolutely would close itself to the other and die of its own protection, so that every living system must partly disable its own defenses in order to live (Derrida 2003). Anakin Skywalker is the autoimmune event of the Force, and balance, in the saga's terrible sense, includes both of his catastrophes. ⌖





III

PART THREE

Ethics

CHAPTER 5

Fear Is the Path

The Pathogenesis of the Dark Side

CHAPTER 6

Knights of Infinite Resignation

CHAPTER

5

Fear Is the Path

The Pathogenesis of the Dark Side

Anakin falls not because he loves but because he is forbidden to grieve. The saga's moral psychology, which deepens from a four-link chain of affects in 1999 to a Buddhist analysis of craving in 2005, locates the origin of the dark side in the denial of death and the prohibition of mourning, and it indicts the Jedi Order for supplying the second while failing to answer the first.

5.1

Yoda's Chain and the Twelve Links

Before the Jedi Council in *The Phantom Menace*, Yoda senses much fear in the boy and pronounces the saga's best-known moral teaching: fear is the path to the dark side, for fear leads to anger, anger to hatred, and hatred to suffering. The chain is a vernacular compression of the Buddhist doctrine of dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*), whose twelve links run from ignorance (*avidyā*) through volitional formations, consciousness, name-and-form, the six sense-bases, contact, and feeling to craving (*tṛṣṇā*), clinging (*upādāna*), becoming (*bhava*), birth (*jāti*), and finally aging-and-death with its train of sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief, and despair. Both chains are causal sequences of mental events terminating in *duḥkha*. They differ at the origin: Yoda's begins with an affect, fear, while the Buddhist chain begins with a cognitive condition, ignorance, and places craving and clinging upstream of any fear of loss, since one fears to lose only what one already grasps.

The saga corrects itself over six years. In *Revenge of the Sith*, Yoda no longer begins with fear but with attachment: the fear of loss, he tells Anakin, is a path to the dark side, and he must train himself to let go of everything he fears to lose. The teaching has moved upstream, from the fourth Buddhist link to the eighth and

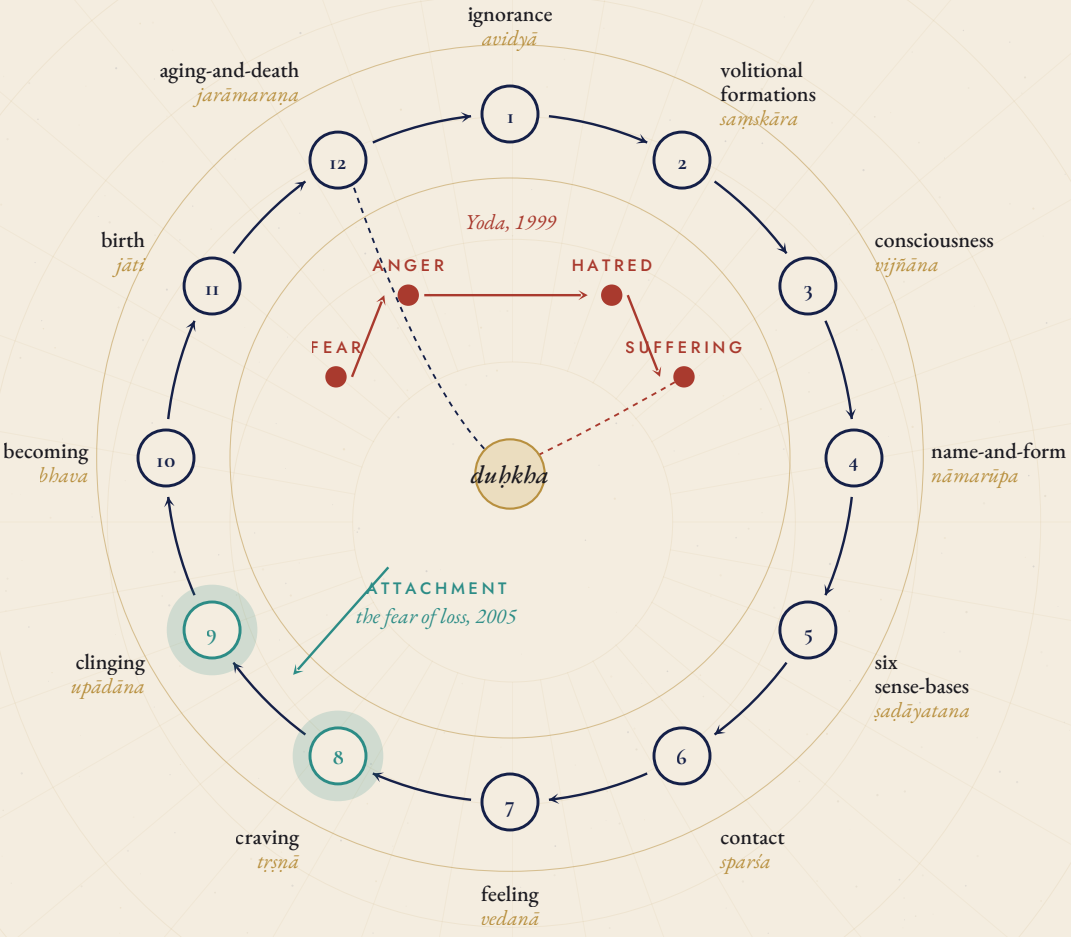
ninth, from symptom to cause. The saga's moral psychology thus deepens in the direction of Buddhist analysis precisely as its tragedy approaches. Frank Herbert had offered a different remedy in the Bene Gesserit litany of *Dune* (1965), which names fear as the destroyer of the mind and prescribes permitting it to pass over and through the self while the inner eye observes its path. Herbert's litany is a technique, akin to the non-resistant noting of *vipassanā*; Yoda's chain is an etiology. The saga needs both and possesses only the second: it can explain why Anakin will fall, but its institution cannot teach him how to let fear pass.

5.2

The Three Cravings: Sith, Jedi, and the Middle Way

The Buddha's first discourse, the *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta* (SN 56.11), identifies the origin of suffering as craving (*taṇhā*) in three forms: craving for sensual pleasure (*kāma-taṇhā*), craving for existence and becoming (*bhava-taṇhā*), and craving for non-existence (*vibhava-taṇhā*), which is aversion turned into a program. The saga distributes these three cravings among its three powers with remarkable consistency. The Sith embody *bhava-taṇhā*: the craving for continued and expanded existence, articulated in Plagueis's power to keep the beloved from death and in Anakin's vow, after his mother's death, that he will learn to stop people dying. The late Jedi embody *vibhava-taṇhā*: a craving for the cessation of affect, for not-being-attached, which presents itself as detachment but functions as aversion. The Hutts, whose palace is a theater of gluttony, sexual servitude, and blood-spectacle, embody *kāma-taṇhā*, the worldly craving that stands outside the Force's polarity altogether. The same discourse opens by rejecting two extremes, indulgence and self-mortification, in favor of a middle way (*majjhimā paṭipadā*). Luke walks it: he refuses the Sith's offer of power and the Jedi's counsel of killing, neither grasping nor recoiling.

The Buddhist analysis of clinging sharpens the diagnosis of the Jedi. The tradition distinguishes four kinds of *upādāna*: clinging to sensuality, to views, to rites and rules (*sīlabbatupādāna*), and to a doctrine of self. The late Jedi Order is a case study in the third. Its prohibition of attachment has hardened into an attachment to the prohibition; its rules of non-possession have become possessions. Nāgārjuna warned that emptiness wrongly grasped destroys the one who grasps it, like a snake seized by the wrong end (*Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* 24.11). The Jedi seized non-attachment by the wrong end.



Outer ring: the twelve links of pratītyasamutpāda.
Inner chain: four affects in 1999. In 2005 the teaching moves upstream, to craving and clinging.

PLATE VI

Two chains of dependent arising

The twelve links of pratītyasamutpāda with Yoda's four-link chain of 1999 set inside them; both end in duḥkha. In 2005 the teaching moves upstream, from fear to attachment.

SEE § 5.1

5.3

The Denial of Death: Becker and the Immortality Project

Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* appeared in 1973, the year of Lucas's first synopsis, and received the Pulitzer Prize the following year. Becker argued that human action is driven by the terror of mortality, which cultures manage through "immortality projects"—hero-systems that promise symbolic transcendence—and that heroism is first of all a reflex of the terror of death. In *Escape from Evil* (1975) he added that evil arises when symbolic immortality fails and human beings seek literal continuity by sacrificing others. Terror management theory (Greenberg, Pyszczynski, and Solomon 1986) has since given Becker's thesis an empirical program.

Anakin's fall is a Beckerian case history. His mother dies in his arms; he dreams of his wife's death in childbirth; and Palpatine offers him the one commodity no hero-system can counterfeit, literal power over death. The Jedi Order, which might have supplied a symbolic immortality sufficient to absorb his terror, withholds it. It offers him only the injunction to let go. Yet the Order's tradition possessed a genuine technique of survival: Qui-Gon, alone among the Jedi, had learned to preserve his identity after death, and Yoda reveals this only at the end of *Revenge of the Sith*, to Obi-Wan, after the catastrophe. The light side had an immortality project of its own—the Force ghost, an immortality attained by self-release rather than self-preservation—and it was not taught to the one Jedi whose terror of death was the galaxy's greatest danger. Two immortality projects therefore contend in the saga: the Sith's, which is *immunitary*, securing one's continuance by mastering others' deaths; and Qui-Gon's, which is *kenotic*, securing continuance by surrendering the self. Becker's account of evil fits the massacre in the Jedi Temple with chilling precision: Anakin kills children to secure the survival of his wife and unborn twins.

Plato's *Phaedo* supplies the counter-image. Philosophy, Socrates says, is the practice of dying and being dead (64a; 67e). Obi-Wan's death aboard the Death Star—he raises his blade, then lowers it, and allows Vader to strike him, vanishing as he is struck—is a Socratic death, the culmination of a life rehearsed for it. Vader's survival inside the suit is the anti-*Phaedo*: the refusal to die that becomes a perpetual dying.

5.4

The Prohibition of Mourning: Freud, Zhuangzi, and the Crypt

When Anakin confides his visions to Yoda without naming his wife, Yoda counsels him that death is a natural part of life, that he should rejoice for those who trans-

form into the Force, and that he should neither mourn nor miss them. This is the saga's most consequential sentence, and it is consequential because it is a misreading of its own source. Zhuangzi, as Chapter 3 showed, grieved for his wife before he transcended grief. Yoda's teaching retains Zhuangzi's vocabulary of transformation and deletes Zhuangzi's grief.

Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) explains why the deletion is fatal. Mourning is *work* (*Trauerarbeit*): the slow, painful withdrawal of libido, memory by memory, from an object that reality has declared lost. When that work cannot be performed, mourning becomes melancholia. The ego identifies with the lost object; the shadow of the object, in Freud's figure, falls upon the ego; and the ambivalence once directed toward the object returns as self-reproach and as aggression. The Jedi prohibition of mourning thus prohibits the only process through which attachment can be relinquished. The Order demands the result—non-attachment—while forbidding the work that produces it. Anakin's response to his mother's death is not mourning but massacre followed by a vow, and the vow is a melancholic incorporation: the lost mother persists within him as a demand that no one he loves shall ever die again.

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok refined Freud's distinction into one between *introjection*, the healthy assimilation of loss through language, and *incorporation*, the fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole and preserving it undigested in an intrapsychic *crypt* (Abraham and Torok 1976; 1994). The crypt is a tomb within the self in which the lost one is kept alive and unspeakable, sealed behind a name that may not be pronounced. Vader's suit is the crypt externalized. Anakin is entombed alive within it, and his name is the cryptonym: Vader tells his son that the name no longer means anything to him. Abraham's companion concept of the *phantom* (1975)—a parent's unspoken secret transmitted to the child as an inexplicable haunting—describes Luke's relation to his concealed paternity, which Obi-Wan and Yoda keep from him and which erupts in Cloud City. The saga's first film, released in 1999, bears a title that names this structure with an aptness its author could not have intended: the menace of the saga is a phantom, the absent father whose absence organizes everything. Chapter 10 will argue that the saga's resolution is, precisely, the restoration of mourning: Luke burns his father's armor on a pyre that rhymes with Qui-Gon's in the saga's first film but, unlike that institutional rite, is a son's mourning performed alone, and only after it do the spectral forms of the dead appear.

5.5

Oedipal Irony and the Faustian Bargain

Anakin's prophetic dreams operate with the mechanism of Sophoclean irony. Oedipus flees Corinth to evade the oracle and thereby fulfills it; Anakin turns to the dark side to prevent Padmé's death and thereby causes it, choking her with the Force on Mustafar, when he believes she has betrayed him to Obi-Wan, until she collapses unconscious. She dies after giving birth, having lost, the medical droid reports, the will to live, and Palpatine tells the newly armored Vader that he killed her in his anger; the film lets both accounts stand. Aristotle held that the finest recognition coincides with reversal, as in the *Oedipus* (*Poetics* 1452a), and *Revenge of the Sith* is constructed so that Anakin's recognition—that he has killed what he sought to save—arrives in the same moment as his transformation into the thing that will spend twenty years forgetting it. The prophecy that fulfills itself through the effort to evade it is Herodotus's Croesus as well as Sophocles' Oedipus, and it is Robert Merton's sociological "self-fulfilling prophecy" (1948) avant la lettre. The Jedi's own prophecy of the Chosen One operates the same way: the Order's anxious attempt to manage the prophesied child helps produce the catastrophe it fears.

The second matrix is Goethe's *Faust*. Faust's love for Gretchen, procured through Mephistopheles, destroys her: her mother is poisoned, her brother killed, her infant drowned, and she herself condemned. Anakin's love for Padmé, mediated by Palpatine, destroys her. The temptation is staged, appropriately, in an opera house, where Palpatine offers the Faustian commodity of forbidden knowledge in the guise of a tragedy told about another. Yet *Faust* does not end in damnation. The second part closes with Faust's soul borne upward through the intercession of Gretchen among the penitents, under the Chorus Mysticus's verdict that *das Ewig-Weibliche zieht uns hinan*, the eternal feminine draws us upward. The saga completes the Faustian design across its two trilogies: the bargain in *Revenge of the Sith*, the long damnation in the suit, the intercession begun by Padmé's dying insistence that good remains in him and completed by their son, and the redemption on the second Death Star. Behind both stand the classical myths of the fatherless boy who demands proof of divine paternity and burns the earth in his father's chariot, Ovid's Phaethon, and of the thief of a divine prerogative chained for his presumption, Aeschylus's Prometheus. Anakin, who has no father, seeks one in Palpatine, burns on a volcanic world, and is chained for two decades in the armor of his presumption.

CHAPTER

6

Knights of Infinite Resignation

The late Jedi Order fails not because it is corrupt but because it is resigned: its members are, in Kierkegaard's precise sense, knights of infinite resignation, who renounce the finite for the eternal and cannot receive it back. Luke succeeds by disobeying them, and his success is the movement Kierkegaard called faith.

6.1

Kierkegaard's Two Knighthoods

In *Fear and Trembling* (1843), Johannes de silentio distinguishes two figures through a parable of a young man who loves a princess. The *knight of infinite resignation* renounces her: he makes the movement of infinity, transfigures his love into an eternal consciousness, and finds in renunciation a peace and comfort that the finite cannot disturb. But he does not get the princess back. The *knight of faith* makes the same infinite movement of renunciation and then a second movement, impossible to the first: by virtue of the absurd he believes that he will receive the finite back, and so he lives in the finite with joy. Abraham is the paradigm. He renounces Isaac utterly, and believes, against every evidence and every calculation, that he will receive him again.

The Jedi of the prequels are a literal knighthood of infinite resignation. They renounce family, marriage, and possession for the Force; their serenity is the serenity of a love made eternal by being given up. Their virtue is real, and so is its limit. Having renounced the finite, they cannot receive it back, and this is why, when Anakin falls, they can only declare him dead. Obi-Wan tells Luke that Vader betrayed and murdered his father, and later defends the statement as true from a certain point of

view: it is true from the standpoint of resignation, for which the renounced beloved has ceased to exist. To Obi-Wan, Vader is more machine than man; to Yoda, confronting Vader is the final test of Luke's knighthood, and neither master can imagine that confrontation as anything but a duel. Both counsels are the voice of the resigned knight. Neither can imagine that the lost might be returned.

Luke makes both movements. He renounces: he surrenders himself to Imperial capture on Endor, offering his life, and in the throne room he casts away his weapon. And he believes, by virtue of the absurd—against twenty years of murder, against his mentors' explicit judgment—that his father can be returned to him. He is returned, for a moment, as Isaac was returned to Abraham. Kierkegaard's first *Problema* asks whether there is a teleological suspension of the ethical, a relation to the particular higher than the universal. The Jedi represent the universal: the galaxy's welfare requires Vader's death. Luke's relation to his father is an absolute relation to the particular that the universal cannot mediate. The scandal of the saga's resolution is Kierkegaard's scandal: the universal is saved through a fidelity to the particular that the universal had forbidden.

6.2

The Demonic as Inclosing Reserve

Anakin is neither knight. He is first the aesthetic lover who will not renounce at all, and then, after Mustafar, what *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844) calls the demonic. Vigilius Haufniensis defines anxiety as the dizziness of freedom and the demonic as anxiety about the good. Its essential character is *inclosing reserve* (*det Indesluttede*): unfreedom that wishes to close itself off, a self shut up with itself, which experiences every approach of the good as a threat because the good would require disclosure. The demonic, he adds, is "the sudden," and its only cure is communication. Vader's suit is inclosing reserve made visible, and his amplified breathing is the sound of a self that cannot open. Whenever Luke speaks of the good in him, Vader terminates the conversation.

The Sickness unto Death (1849) completes the diagnosis. Anti-Climacus defines despair as a misrelation in the self's relation to itself, and identifies as its most intensified form the sin of despairing of the forgiveness of sins. Vader's statement on Endor that it is too late for him is this despair exactly: not the absence of the good but the refusal to consent to being forgiven. His turn is the leap out of it, and Anti-Climacus's formula for the self freed from despair—a self that, in relating to itself and willing to be itself, rests transparently in the power that established it—describes with startling literalness the saga's iconography of salvation. The redeemed

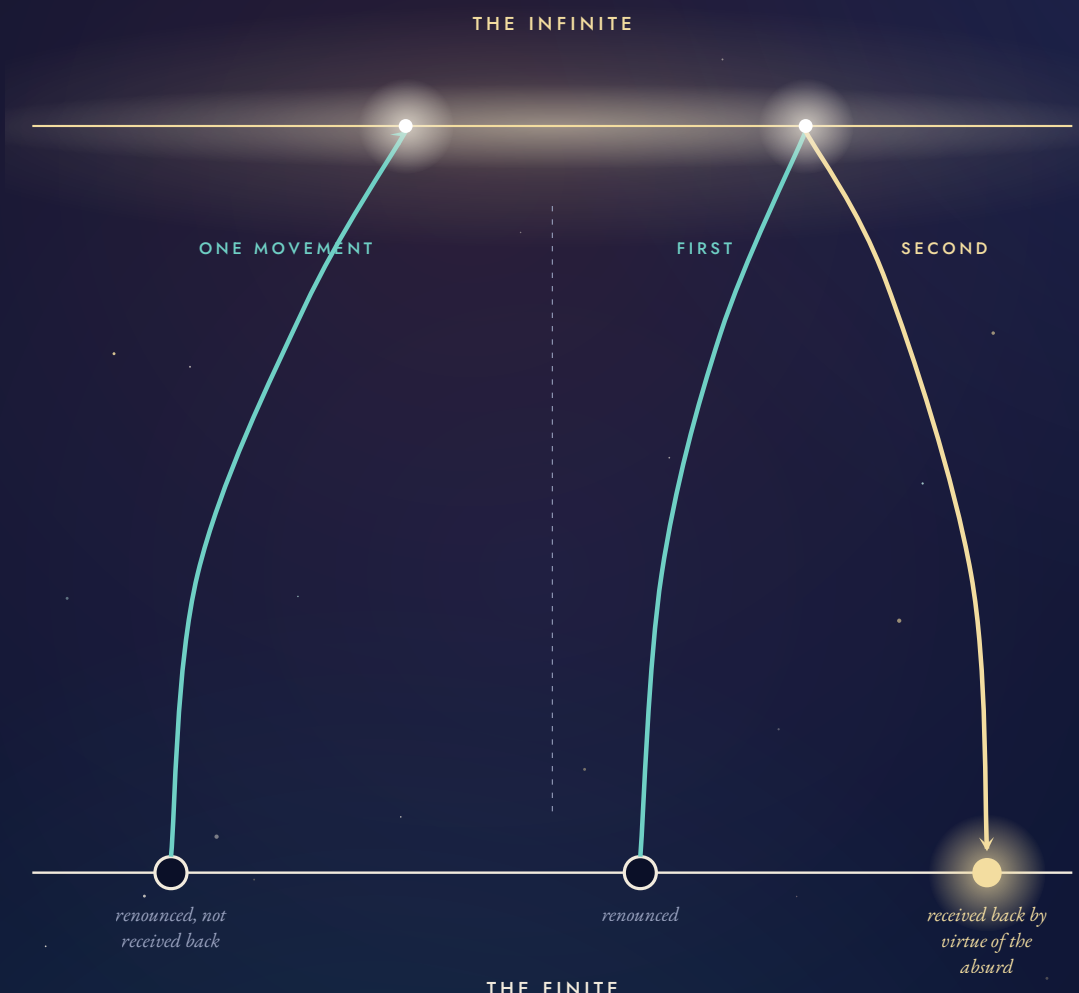


PLATE VII

The double movement

Kierkegaard's knight of infinite resignation renounces the finite and cannot receive it back; the knight of faith renounces and, by virtue of the absurd, receives. The Jedi make the first movement; Luke makes both.

SEE § 6.1

dead in the saga are visibly, luminously *transparent*. The Force ghost is the Kierkegaardian self made image: a self resting transparently in the power that established it.

6.3

Detachment and Love: Eckhart against Paul

The late Jedi Order is Eckhartian. In his treatise *On Detachment*, Meister Eckhart ranks *abegescheidenheit* above love, humility, and mercy, reasoning that love compels me to love God, whereas detachment compels God to come to me, since God cannot refuse a soul emptied for him. Detachment is the empty vessel that receives the divine, and Eckhart's companion concept of *Gelassenheit*, letting-be, will pass through Heidegger into the saga's vocabulary of letting go (Chapter 9). The Order's hierarchy of virtues is Eckhart's: detachment first.

Paul's is the opposite. In 1 Corinthians 13 love (*agapē*) is the greatest of the three, and the chapter's second verse reads, in a literal rendering, as an indictment of the Order avant la lettre: if I have prophecy and know all mysteries and all knowledge, and if I have all faith so as to move mountains, but have not love, I am nothing. The Jedi possess prophecy, an archive of all knowledge, and a faith that lifts starships from swamps. The saga asks what they lack. The Order would answer that it does not lack love, and Anakin, in *Attack of the Clones*, states the doctrine: attachment and possession are forbidden, but compassion, which he defines as unconditional love, is central to a Jedi's life. Lucas has drawn the same distinction between compassion and possessive attachment in his own commentary. The distinction is philosophically sound and institutionally unworkable. An Order that recruits infants cannot teach the particular loves from which universal compassion grows, and an Order that forbids marriage forbids the very form of love in which the difference between cherishing and possessing is learned. It demands *agapē* while prohibiting *philia* and *erōs*. Anders Nygren's *Agape and Eros* (1930–1936) had opposed the two loves as Christian and pagan; in December 2005, seven months after *Revenge of the Sith* was released, Benedict XVI's encyclical *Deus caritas est* argued that *erōs* and *agapē* can never be wholly sundered without impoverishing both. The coincidence is instructive. The saga's critique of the Jedi is a critique of Nygren's dichotomy.

6.4

Arhat and Bodhisattva: The Mahāyāna Critique of the Jedi

Mahāyāna polemic contrasted the *arhat*, who attains liberation for himself, with the *bodhisattva*, who vows to defer final liberation until all beings are freed and whose

path unites wisdom (*prajñā*) with compassion (*karuṇā*). The contrast was a sectarian construction and does not fairly describe the Theravāda tradition; it is used here as a contrast of ideal types. The late Jedi conform to the polemical arhat. Their response to Anakin's fall, and to Vader's existence, is containment and withdrawal: Yoda to Dagobah, Obi-Wan to Tatooine, the hermitage as the posture of a purity preserved rather than a world redeemed. Luke conforms to the bodhisattva. He risks his own liberation—his life and, in his mentors' eyes, his vocation—to save a single being, the most lost being in the galaxy. Śāntideva's *Bodhicaryāvatāra* (ch. 8) teaches the exchange of self and other (*parātmaparivartana*), regarding another's suffering as one's own and one's own advantage as another's. Luke's surrender on Endor is that exchange: he places himself in his father's power, trading his safety for his father's chance.

The *Lotus Sutra* offers a parable that the saga inverts. In its fourth chapter a son who has wandered for decades in poverty is led back, by stages and through skillful means, to recognize that he is heir to his father's wealth. In the saga it is the father who has wandered and the son who leads him back, step by step, to recognize his inheritance, which is the good in him. The Gospel that bears the hero's name contains the Western form of the same parable (Luke 15:11–32), in which the father runs to meet the returning son. *Return of the Jedi* is a parable of the prodigal father.

6.5

Paradise Regained: The Temptation of the Son

The two trilogies correspond to Milton's two epics. The prequels are *Paradise Lost*: the fall, through pride and fear, of the brightest of the Order, whose drafted surname, Starkiller, darkly inverts Lucifer's title of morning star. Blake's remark that Milton was of the Devil's party without knowing it describes the audience's enduring fascination with Vader, and Satan's maxim that it is better to reign in Hell than serve in Heaven (*Paradise Lost* 1.263) is the substance of Vader's offer in Cloud City that father and son rule the galaxy together.

The originals are *Paradise Regained* (1671), Milton's epic of the Son's temptation in the wilderness, in which Satan offers the kingdoms of the world and the Son refuses them, and which ends with Satan's fall from the pinnacle of the temple. Luke's three temptations follow the Miltonic pattern. In the Dagobah cave he confronts himself. In Cloud City, offered dominion, he lets himself fall into the abyss rather than take his father's hand, a voluntary fall that is a refusal. In the throne room, offered his father's place at the Emperor's side, he refuses again, and it is the tempter who falls, cast down the reactor shaft. The saga, in short, unites Milton's

two epics in a single family: the father reenacts the fall of the angel, and the son reenacts the refusal of the Son.

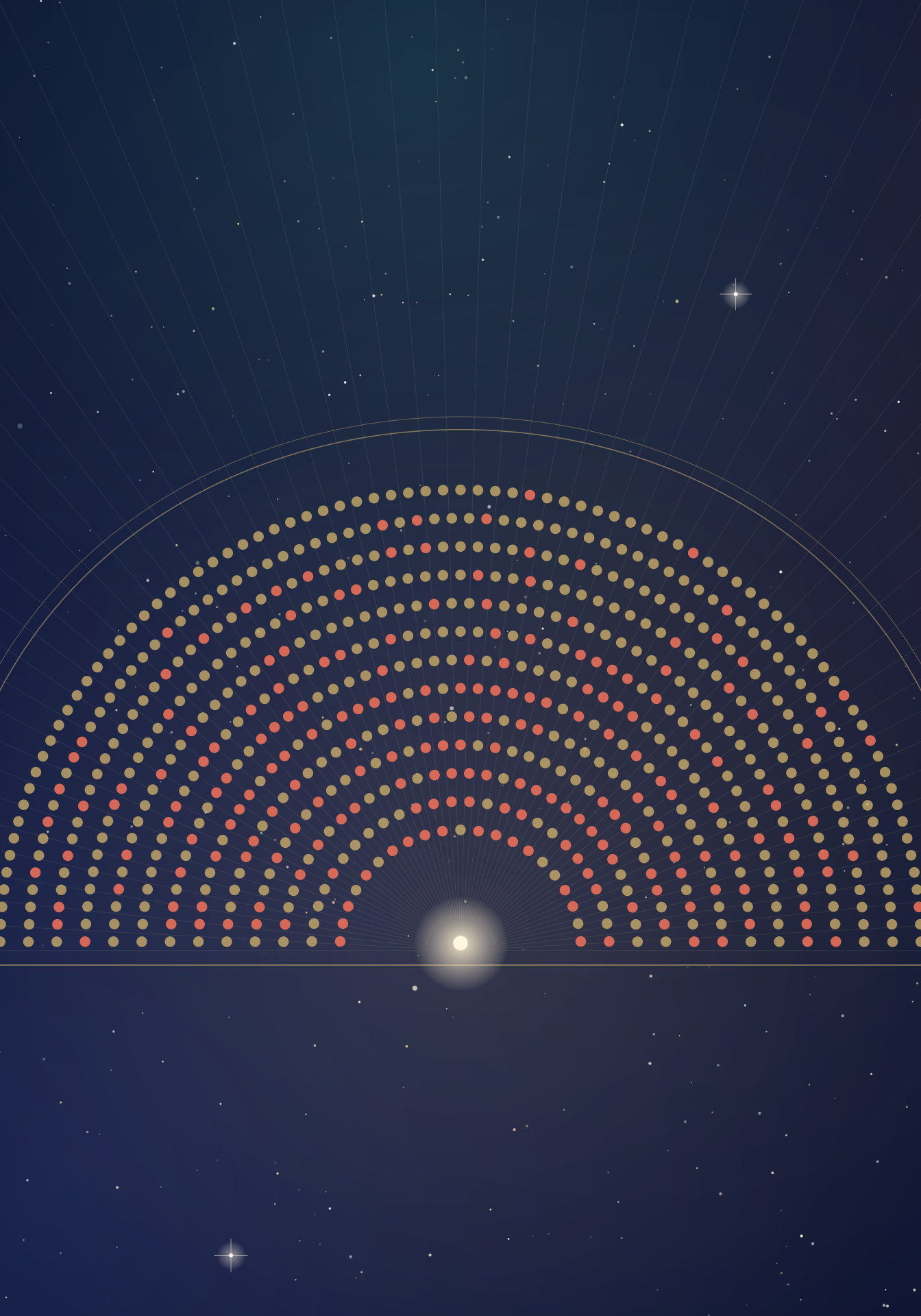
6.6

Radical Evil and the Revolution of Disposition

Kant's *Religion within the Boundaries of Mere Reason* (1793) defines radical evil as a propensity to invert the moral order of incentives, subordinating the moral law to self-love in one's supreme maxim. It is radical because it corrupts the ground of all maxims; yet the original predisposition to good remains, and its restoration requires not gradual reform but a "revolution in the disposition" (*Revolution der Gesinnung*), a change of heart that Kant compares to a new creation. Lucas's repeated gloss of the dark side as selfishness and the light side as compassion is Kantian in structure: evil is not a substance but an inverted ordering of motives.

Vader's turn is a Kantian revolution. It is not the gradual product of his son's persuasion, which he resists to the last, but an instantaneous reordering enacted as he watches his son tortured. The scene's grammar—the masked head turning from the Emperor to the son and back, the shot held, the music suspended—stages a choice that is not reasoned but performed. Kant adds that such a revolution can never be proven by its consequences in time and can only be hoped for, supplemented by a grace that exceeds human power. Vader dies within minutes. His revolution has no time to manifest in works; it is validated only by his son's witness and by the transparent form in which he reappears. The Force ghost is the Kantian supplement of grace, made visible.

One final classical frame binds this chapter to the next. Aristotle observed that friendship seems to hold cities together and that lawgivers care more for it than for justice (*Nicomachean Ethics* 1155a22–24), and he listed among the measures of tyrants the destruction of trust and friendship among citizens (*Politics* 1313a–b). The duel on Mustafar, in which Obi-Wan laments that he loved Anakin as a brother, is the collapse of *philia* that precedes and enables the consolidation of the Empire. The ethics of the saga passes into its politics through the destruction of a friendship.



IV

PART FOUR

Politics

CHAPTER 7

How Liberty Dies

Republic, Exception, and the Emperor's Two Bodies

CHAPTER 8

Clonal Selection

The Grand Army of the Republic as Immune System

CHAPTER

7

How Liberty Dies

Republic, Exception, and the Emperor's Two Bodies

The Republic falls as Anakin falls: by fear, through an emergency, at the hands of a protector who authored the danger he protects against. The prequel trilogy is a compressed treatise on constitutional decline whose sources run from Polybius and Plato through Tacitus and Hobbes to Schmitt, Arendt, Weber, and Agamben, and whose central insight is that the Republic's defenses are the instruments of its death.

7.1

Anacyclosis and the Protector-Root of Tyranny

Polybius's sixth book describes the cycle of constitutions (*anacyclosis*): kingship degenerates into tyranny, which is overthrown by aristocracy; aristocracy degenerates into oligarchy, which is overthrown by democracy; democracy degenerates into ochlocracy, the rule of the crowd, from whose chaos a strongman restores monarchy (6.3–9). The mixed constitution of Rome, balancing consuls, senate, and assemblies, delays but cannot abolish the cycle. The Galactic Republic is such a mixed constitution—an elected Supreme Chancellor, a Senate, courts, and a semi-autonomous religious order guarding the peace—and the prequels trace the cycle's terminal arc. Oligarchic capture appears in the corporate representation of the Trade Federation and in the procedural paralysis that Padmé confronts in *The Phantom Menace*, where a planet's invasion is referred to a commission. Ochlocracy appears, paradoxically, inside the senatorial chamber itself, in the ovation that greets the proclamation of the Empire. Monarchy returns as tyranny.

Plato's eighth book of the *Republic* supplies the mechanism. Tyranny springs from no other root than that of a protector (*prostatēs*) of the people (565c–d). Once

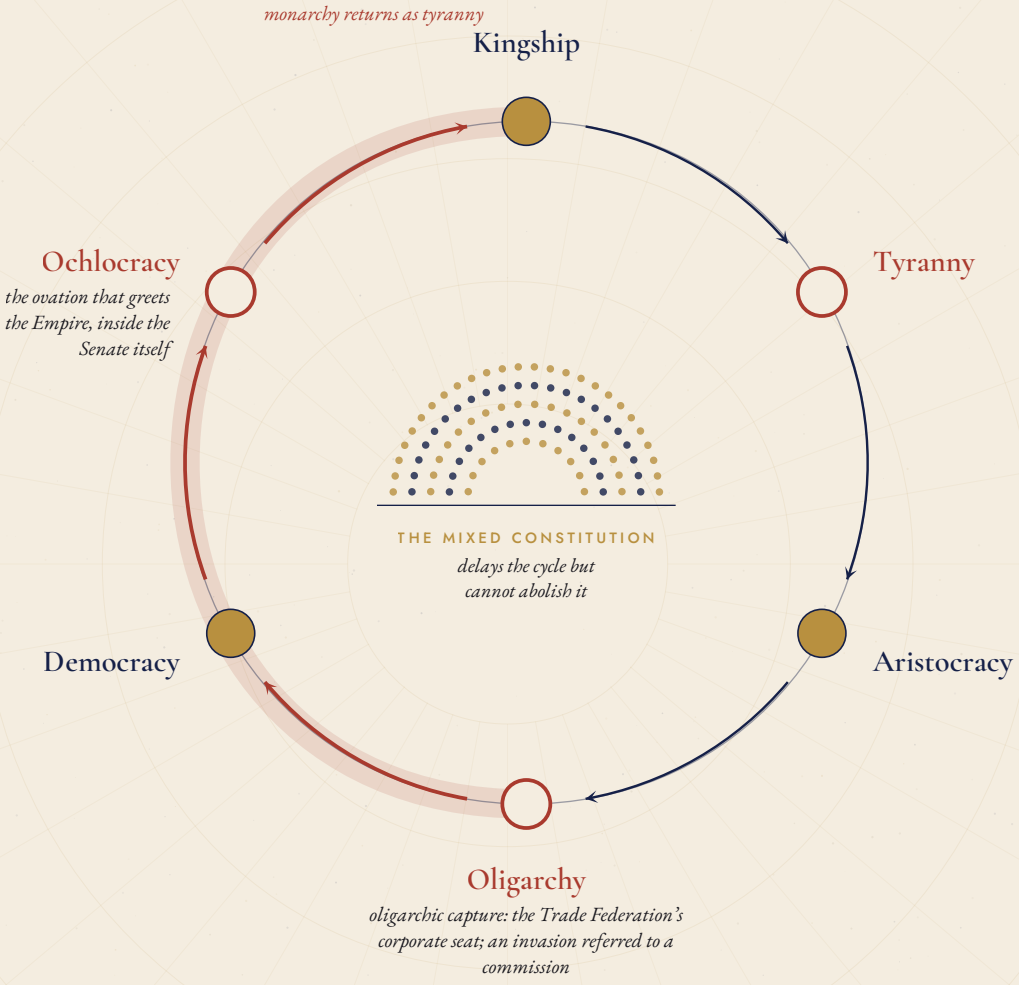
established, the tyrant is always stirring up some war, so that the people may need a leader (566e–567a). And he must then purge the city of the brave, the high-minded, and the wise—a "fine purgation," Socrates says with bitter irony, the opposite of the physician's, who removes the worst from the body and leaves the best, whereas the tyrant removes the best and leaves the worst (567b–c). Plato's figure is medical, and it is precisely the figure of autoimmunity: a purge that attacks the healthiest tissue of the body politic. Palpatine is Plato's protector to the letter. As a senator of Naboo he engineers the blockade of his own world, rides the resulting crisis to the chancellorship through a vote of no confidence moved by his own manipulated queen, provokes a galactic war in which he directs both sides, and concludes it by purging the Jedi, the city's guardians in the most Platonic sense. Order 66 is Plato's inverted *katharmos*.

7.2

The Palatine Senate: Sulla, Caesar, Augustus, Tacitus

Rome's constitutional dictatorship was an emergency magistracy limited to six months, an institution Machiavelli praised as having done the Republic good rather than harm so long as it was bounded (*Discourses* 1.34). Sulla revived it without term; Caesar was named *dictator perpetuo* in 44 BCE; and Octavian's settlement of 27 BCE inaugurated the principate under the slogan of a restored republic, preserving the Senate's forms while emptying them of power. Palpatine's trajectory follows this sequence closely: emergency powers voted by the Senate in *Attack of the Clones*, on a motion moved, with savage irony, by the very Gungan representative whose people had entered the symbiont circle; the indefinite prolongation of his term; the proclamation of the Empire before an applauding Senate; and the Senate's survival as a vestige for nineteen years until its dissolution is announced in *A New Hope*. The resonance of the Chancellor's name with the Palatine Hill, where Augustus lived and from whose name the word "palace" derives, completes the Roman analogy. Machiavelli's other treatise supplies the tyrant's method: a prince must be both fox and lion, the fox to recognize snares and the lion to frighten wolves (The Prince, ch. 18). Palpatine is the purest fox in modern myth, a ruler who needs the lion only at the end, when the fox's work is done.

Tacitus recorded the principate's moral psychology in a single clause: at Rome, consuls, senators, and knights rushed into servitude (*at Romae ruere in servitium consules, patres, eques*, *Annals* 1.7). Padmé's observation in *Revenge of the Sith*—"So this is how liberty dies, with thunderous applause"—translates Tacitus into the idiom of the saga. Tacitus's Calgacus supplies the Empire's other epitaph: they



PLATO, REPUBLIC 565C–D

Tyranny springs from no other root than a protector of the people (prostatēs).

PLATE VIII

Anacyclosis

Polybius's cycle of constitutions, with the terminal arc the prequels trace: oligarchic capture, the ovation in the Senate, and monarchy returned as tyranny.

SEE § 7.1

make a desert and call it peace (*ubi solitudinem faciunt, pacem appellant*, *Agricola* 30). Vader's claim on Mustafar to have brought peace, freedom, justice, and security to his new Empire is uttered amid rivers of lava on a world mined to death, minutes after he has killed the assembled Separatist leaders there on his master's order, ending the war by massacre.

7.3

The Sovereign Exception: Schmitt, Weimar, Agamben

Carl Schmitt opened *Politische Theologie* (1922) with the definition that has governed twentieth-century reflection on emergency powers: *Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet*, sovereign is he who decides on the exception. Palpatine's genius exceeds Schmitt's formula. He does not merely decide on the exception; he manufactures it, directing the Separatist rebellion as Darth Sidious while confronting it as Chancellor, so that the emergency to which he responds is his own artifact. Schmitt's *The Concept of the Political* (1932) defined the political by the distinction between friend and enemy, and Anakin's declaration on Mustafar that whoever is not with him is his enemy is Schmitt's criterion spoken aloud. Obi-Wan's rejoinder, that absolutism is the signature of the Sith, has been mocked as itself an absolute statement, but its force is diagnostic rather than logical: it identifies the friend–enemy distinction, when made the essence of the political, as Sith metaphysics. Reviewers in 2005 widely heard in Anakin's line an echo of President George W. Bush's address to Congress of 20 September 2001—"Either you are with us, or you are with the terrorists"—though the formula is far older: the Gospels record it both in its exclusive form, whoever is not with me is against me (Matthew 12:30), and in its inclusive inversion, whoever is not against us is for us (Mark 9:40), and Obi-Wan's rejoinder takes the side of the second; Lucas maintained at Cannes in 2005 that the story had been conceived during the Vietnam War and the Nixon era, and that its parallels with the present reflected the recurrence of history rather than topical allegory.

The Weimar precedent is closer still. Article 48 of the Weimar Constitution empowered the Reich President to govern by emergency decree; Hitler's government, appointed on 30 January 1933, turned the article to its own use within weeks. After the Reichstag fire of 27 February, which the government blamed on a Communist conspiracy, the Reichstag Fire Decree, issued under Article 48 the next day, suspended civil liberties. On 23 March, meeting in the Kroll Opera House because its own chamber had burned, the Reichstag passed the Enabling Act by 444 votes to 94, empowering Hitler's cabinet to make law without parliament. The vote had the

form of law and the substance of coercion: the Communist deputies had been arrested or driven into hiding under the emergency decree, several Social Democrats were likewise absent, SA and SS men lined the hall, and only the Social Democrats present voted against (Evans 2003). The decree that manufactured the exception supplied the majority that ended the republic. That the vote took place in an opera house, as does Palpatine's temptation of Anakin, is a coincidence of the record and is offered as no evidence of influence. Clinton Rossiter's *Constitutional Dictatorship* (1948) had studied the emergency institutions of the modern democracies with the uneasy conclusion that a democracy might need to suspend itself in order to survive. Giorgio Agamben's *State of Exception* (2003) radicalized the analysis: tracing the exception from the Roman *iustitium* and the *senatus consultum ultimum* to modern emergency powers, he argued that the exception has become the normal paradigm of government, a zone of anomie in which law is suspended in the name of law.

The saga's most uncomfortable insight is that the Jedi participate in this paradigm. In *Revenge of the Sith* Mace Windu proposes that if the Chancellor fails to relinquish his emergency powers, the Council should take control of the Senate to secure the transition, and Yoda warns that this line of thought leads to a dark place. Minutes of screen time later, Windu stands over a disarmed Palpatine and resolves to kill him without trial because he is too dangerous to be left alive, while Anakin protests that he must stand trial; Anakin then severs Windu's sword hand, and Palpatine kills the disarmed Jedi with lightning. The Jedi, too, decide on the exception: to save the Republic's law, they suspend it. Order 66 then converts them into what Agamben called *homo sacer*, the figure of archaic Roman law who may be killed without the killing counting as homicide or sacrifice. Declared traitors, the Jedi become bare life.

7.4

Power and Violence: Arendt's Reading of the Death Star

Hannah Arendt's *On Violence* (1970) distinguished power from violence with a rigor the saga dramatizes. Power, she argued, corresponds to the human capacity not merely to act but to act in concert; it belongs to a group and exists only so long as the group holds together. Violence is instrumental, dependent on implements, and its opposite rather than its extreme: where one rules absolutely the other is absent, and violence can destroy power but is utterly incapable of creating it. In the conference room aboard the Death Star, an officer boasts that the battle station is the ultimate power in the universe, and Vader answers: "The ability to destroy a planet is

insignificant next to the power of the Force." The villain states Arendt's thesis. The Death Star is violence perfected; the Force, which binds the galaxy together, is power in Arendt's sense, the being-together of the living. Tarkin's doctrine that fear of the station will keep the local systems in line marks the moment Arendt identified as the substitution of violence for vanishing power, and the station's destruction in the same film demonstrates her claim. The Empire dissolves the Senate, the last vestige of its power, and launches its ultimate weapon, and it is never weaker than at that instant.

Arendt's earlier work supplies the saga's anthropology of Imperial service. *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1951) identified terror as the essence of totalitarian rule, and *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963) found in the functionary who executes atrocity as procedure the banality of evil. The Empire's officers—bickering, careerist, apologetic, and periodically strangled—are banal in Arendt's sense, and the clone commanders who receive Order 66 and acknowledge it with a phrase of routine compliance are its purest instance.

7.5

Charisma, Routine, and Disenchantment: Weber and the Jedi Order

Max Weber's typology of legitimate domination—traditional, legal-rational, charismatic—maps the saga's institutions with precision (Weber 1922). The Republic is legal-rational domination, governed by procedure, committee, and vote. The Jedi Order is routinized charisma (*Veralltäglichung des Charismas*): the charisma of the Force institutionalized in a Council, a Temple, an archive, a system of recruitment, and a graded hierarchy from youngling to master, so that personal charisma is replaced by the charisma of office. Qui-Gon is the charismatic dissident who obeys the Force against the Council; Anakin is raw charisma that the routinized order cannot integrate, seated on the Council in *Revenge of the Sith* but denied the rank of Master. Palpatine fuses the two modes in Weber's "plebiscitary leader democracy," legal procedure mobilized by charismatic acclamation. Weber's definition of the state by its monopoly of legitimate physical violence ("Politics as a Vocation," 1919) clarifies the Republic's structural flaw: it has delegated its monopoly first to an armed religious order and then to a cloned army purchased from a foreign laboratory, so that it no longer possesses its own violence.

Weber's diagnosis of modernity as the disenchantment of the world (*Entzauberung der Welt*, "Science as a Vocation," 1917/1919) supplies the Empire's ideology. Its officers deride the Force as an obsolete religion, and the smuggler dismisses it as

hokey. The Empire is disenchanted modernity armored, and its emblem is Weber's own. The phrase that Talcott Parsons rendered as the "iron cage," *stahlhartes Gehäuse*, means more literally a casing or shell as hard as steel (Baehr 2001). Vader is the *stahlhartes Gehäuse* made flesh: a man encased in a steel-hard shell, inhabiting the bureaucratic machine as its enforcer. His strangling of an officer who mocks his religion is re-enchantment by violence, the return of the charismatic within the rationalized order in its most atavistic form.

7.6

Leviathan and the Corporate Secession

Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) founded the sovereign on the fear of violent death and depicted it, in Abraham Bosse's frontispiece, as an artificial body composed of the bodies of its subjects. The passion to be reckoned upon, Hobbes wrote, is fear (ch. 14), and his verse autobiography records that his mother, terrified by the Armada, bore twins, himself and fear (*meque metumque simul*). Palpatine's proclamation of the Empire is Hobbesian in every particular. It is justified by an attempt on his life, displayed in his disfigured face; it promises security; and it culminates in his identification of his own person with the Senate, the Leviathan's incorporation of the many bodies into one. Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) distinguished the monarch's mortal body natural from the immortal body politic. The Emperor's two bodies are visibly split: the body natural is ruined, scarred, and hooded; the body politic is omnipresent. The saga's twins, born at the moment of the Empire's founding, rhyme with Hobbes's: the age of fear is born twinned.

The war that produced this Leviathan was a war between a republic and its own capital. The Confederacy of Independent Systems is a secession of corporations—the Trade Federation, the InterGalactic Banking Clan, the Techno Union, the Commerce Guild, the Corporate Alliance—and Slavoj Žižek's 2005 essay "Revenge of Global Finance" read the film in this light. The Republic's response is to purchase an army from the cloners of Kamino, so that its defense against capital's secession is itself a procurement. Eisenhower's farewell address of 1961, warning against the unwarranted influence of the military-industrial complex, is the unspoken gloss on the Kaminoan laboratory, and Chapter 8 will show that the army it produced is the saga's most exact allegory of immunity.

The saga's imperial form also inverts the trajectory that Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri traced in *Empire* (2000). They argued that modern imperialism, centered on nation-states and their capitals, was giving way to a decentered network sovereignty with neither center nor outside. The prequels' Republic—a sprawl of

systems, trade federations, banking clans, and lobbying guilds—resembles Hardt and Negri's Empire more than the Empire of the original trilogy does, for the latter is a classical imperialism with a capital, an emperor, and a flagship. The saga therefore narrates the passage from network to center: the recentralization of a diffuse sovereignty in a single body during an emergency. It refuses as well the thesis that Alexandre Kojève drew from Hegel and that Francis Fukuyama revived in 1992, that history culminates in a universal and homogeneous state (Kojève 1947; Fukuyama 1992). Palpatine's Empire claims to be that state, and it lasts a little over two decades.

7.7

Vietnam, Nixon, and the Afterlives of Allegory

Lucas's notes from the early 1970s, reconstructed by Rinzler (2007), conceived the Empire as the United States projected a decade forward, the Emperor as a Nixonian figure, and the Rebellion as a small band of insurgents resisting a technological superpower. The Nixonian model is apt in a further sense: in 1971 Nixon signed the National Cancer Act, popularly hailed as a war on cancer, and declared drug abuse America's public enemy number one, helping to inaugurate the vocabulary of internal wars in which American political culture learned to describe defense. Lucas had been attached in the late 1960s to John Milius's Vietnam script that became Coppola's *Apocalypse Now*, and *Star Wars* is in part his displaced Vietnam film; the defeat of Imperial troops by the forest-dwelling Ewoks in *Return of the Jedi* was conceived, by his own account, to show a technologically primitive people overcoming a technological power. The reception reversed the allegory. On 8 March 1983 Ronald Reagan described the Soviet Union as an evil empire, and on 23 March he proposed the Strategic Defense Initiative, which critics immediately dubbed "Star Wars." Lucasfilm sued to prevent advocacy groups from using the title in political advertising and lost (*Lucasfilm Ltd. v. High Frontier*, 1985). The appropriation is exact in a way its authors did not intend. SDI was a planetary immune system, a shield to seal the body politic against penetration from without. Two months after Reagan's speech, *Return of the Jedi* opened with an Empire protected by a deflector shield projected from a forest moon, and the shield was destroyed by its forest-dwellers.

Robin Wood (1986) read the trilogy as restoring the Father for Reagan's America. The present study answers that the Father the saga restores is a father unmasked, dying, and burned on a pyre. Its Oedipal resolution is not the reinstatement of patriarchal armor but its removal. ⊹

CHAPTER

8

Clonal Selection

The Grand Army of the Republic as Immune System

The Grand Army of the Republic is an immune system in the precise sense of twentieth-century immunology: a single selected specificity clonally expanded into a population of effectors, deployed against a designated non-self, and tolerant of the body's own tissue only conditionally. Order 66 is the moment that tolerance is revoked. The Republic dies, as Plato foresaw, of a purge that attacks its healthiest tissue.

8.1

Immunity as Political Paradigm

Roberto Esposito's trilogy—*Communitas* (1998), *Immunitas* (2002), and *Bíos* (2004)—reconstructs modern politics around the Latin *munus*, a word that means at once gift, obligation, office, and debt. Community, Esposito argues, is not constituted by a shared property but by a shared *munus*: its members are bound by a gift they must give, an obligation that expropriates them, a lack held in common. Immunity is exemption from the *munus*: the *immunis* is the one dispensed from the obligation that binds the others. Modernity, on this account, is the progressive immunization of life—through sovereignty, property, law, and the protected body—and immunization works by inoculation, protecting life through a controlled dose of the negative. When the immunitary logic is intensified beyond measure, it turns upon the life it protects. In *Bíos*, Esposito reads Nazism as the autoimmune paroxysm of biopolitics, a thanatopolitics in which the protection of the people's body required the death of those the regime classified as its contaminants. Esposito reconstructs how the National Socialist state, with physicians and biologists among its agents, described Jews as parasites, bacilli, and infections of the national body

(Volkskörper), and on that vocabulary murdered some six million Jews, together with Roma and Sinti and the disabled people killed under the program it called euthanasia.

The saga distributes Esposito's categories across its institutions with unusual clarity. The Jedi's renunciation of kinship and marriage is an immunization against the *munus* of love: an exemption from the obligations of family in the name of a higher service. The Republic's militarization is the immunization of the body politic. The Empire is autoimmune thanatopolitics, and its emblem, the Death Star, is the immunitary apparatus perfected: a weapon with which Grand Moff Tarkin, with Vader at his side and Leia forced to watch, destroys the peaceful world of Alderaan and its entire population to secure order by deterrence. *Communitas* belongs to the Rebel Alliance, to the Gungans and Naboo of the symbiont circle, and to the Ewoks, a forest people defined by shared labor and shared ritual.

No character embodies the passage between the two terms more completely than Han Solo, whose surname names the exempted individual. His arc is, literally, a narrative of the *munus* as debt. He owes Jabba the Hutt, and his debt ends in carbonite: the debtor converted into an object, hung as an ornament on the creditor's wall —Georg Lukács's *Verdinglichung* (1923), the reification of persons under the commodity form, made literal. His return in the Death Star trench, unpaid and uncompelled, is the gift that exceeds contract and founds community, the movement Marcel Mauss traced in *Essai sur le don* (1925). Leia's thawing of him in Jabba's palace is de-reification by love, and her strangling of Jabba—who had held her chained beside his throne as a sexualized captive on display—with the chain of her own servitude is Hegel's bondsman turning the instrument of bondage against the lord.

8.2

Burnet, Clonal Selection, and the Kaminoan Laboratory

Frank Macfarlane Burnet's clonal selection theory (1957; 1959), developed from Niels Jerne's natural-selection theory of antibody formation (1955) and paralleled by David Talmage, explained acquired immunity through a mechanism of selection and amplification. Each lymphocyte bears a receptor of a single specificity; encounter with a matching antigen selects that lymphocyte for proliferation, producing a clone of identical effector cells; and lymphocytes reactive to the body's own constituents are deleted during development, which establishes self-tolerance. Burnet and Frank Fenner had already framed immunity as the discrimination of "self" from "not-self" (1949), and Burnet shared the 1960 Nobel Prize with Peter Medawar for the discovery of acquired immunological tolerance.

Attack of the Clones stages Burnet's mechanism as political fiction. A Jedi Master commissions an army from the cloners of Kamino a decade before the war; a single individual, the bounty hunter Jango Fett, is selected as template; and the Kaminoans expand that template into a population of identical soldiers, altered, their prime minister explains, to be less independent than the original and grown at an accelerated rate. This is clonal expansion in the strict sense: a single selected specificity amplified into a population of identical effectors. Its designated non-self is, with remarkable literalness, non-living: the Separatist armies are composed of droids, so that the Republic's immune response is deployed against machines, the non-self par excellence. The Kaminoan laboratory—white, aseptic, oceanic, populated by courteous technicians who speak of their products with professional pride—is the saga's image of biopolitical production, and *The Clone Wars* devoted much of its length to complicating it, giving its clones names, scars, tattoos, and dissenting voices, as though personhood were resisting clonality from within.

The clones' tolerance of their Jedi generals, however, is not natural but engineered, and conditional. *The Clone Wars* revealed, in a storyline developed under Lucas's supervision, that each clone carries an implanted inhibitor chip which, upon a single command, overrides the soldier's will. In immunological terms, clonal deletion of self-reactivity has been deliberately sabotaged. Every clone carries a latent reactivity against the body's own tissue, programmed to activate on a signal.

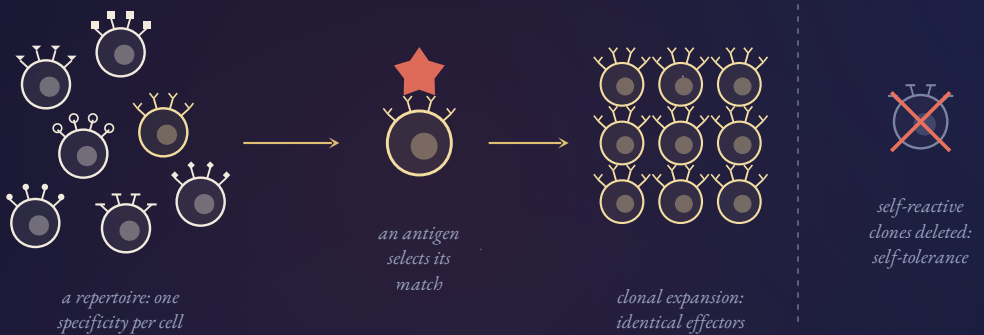
8.3

Order 66 and Democratic Autoimmunity

The signal is Order 66. Transmitted by Palpatine, it reclassifies the Republic's guardians as traitors, and across the galaxy clone units turn their weapons on their commanders. The body's own tissue is redesignated as non-self, and the effector population attacks it. Paul Ehrlich, at the turn of the twentieth century, had postulated a *horror autotoxicus*, a principle by which the organism would never produce immunity against itself; the subsequent discovery of autoimmune disease overturned the postulate. Order 66 is *horror autotoxicus* realized as a political event.

Derrida's late writings provide the philosophical frame. In his 2001 conversation with Giovanna Borradori, he defined autoimmunity as the strange, quasi-suicidal behavior by which a living being works to destroy its own protection, and he read the attacks of September 2001 as autoimmune in the sense that their perpetrators had been trained, armed, and admitted by the system they struck (Derrida 2003). In *Rogues* (2003) he generalized the structure to democracy itself, which always contains the possibility of its own abolition by democratic means and may suspend

BURNET · CLONAL SELECTION, 1957



KAMINO · THE GRAND ARMY OF THE REPUBLIC

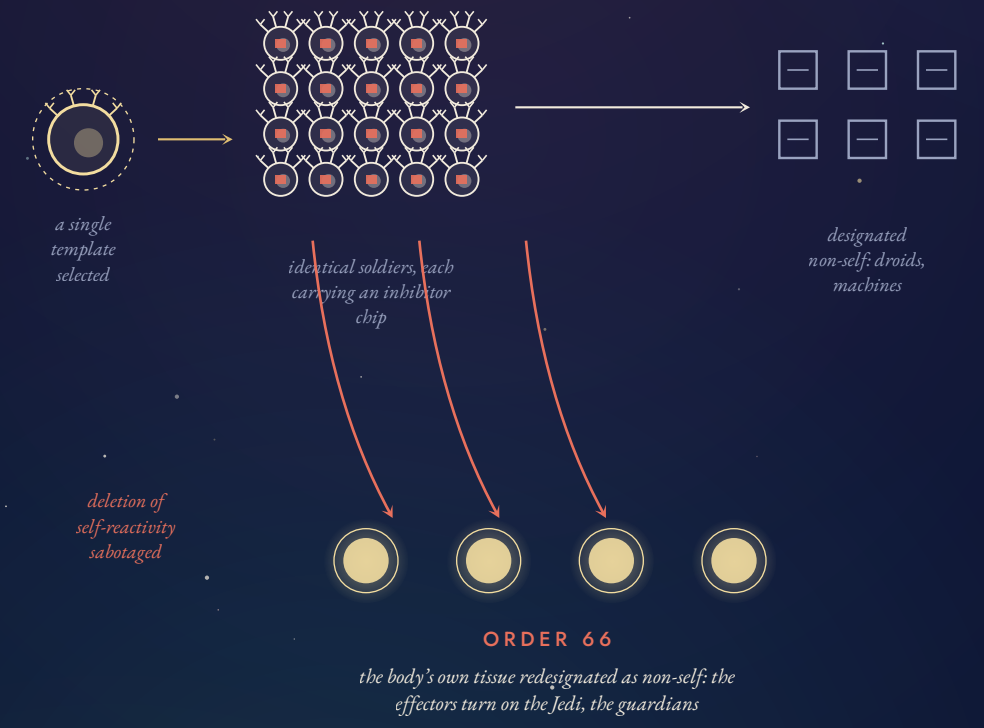


PLATE IX

Clonal selection, inverted

Burnet's mechanism of selection, expansion, and self-tolerance, and its political staging on Kamino, where the deletion of self-reactivity is sabotaged and a single command turns the effectors on the body's own guardians.

SEE § 8.2–8.3

itself in order to protect itself, as in Algeria in 1992. The Republic of the prequels is autoimmune in all three senses. Its army is produced for its protection from a template supplied by its enemy's agent, since the Sith Lord Tyranus recruited the template; that army destroys the Republic's guardians; and its Senate votes its own abolition with applause.

The Jedi are autoimmune in a second, institutional sense. Their acceptance of command over a manufactured army compromised the Order's identity—Mace Windu had insisted, before the war began, that the Jedi are keepers of the peace and not soldiers—and transformed a religious order into a military faction, thereby rendering it legible as an enemy. Their own exception, Windu's resolve to kill the Chancellor without trial, supplied Palpatine with the pretext of a Jedi rebellion. To defend the Republic, the Order became what the Republic could be taught to fear. Plato's inverted purgation, removing the best and leaving the worst, is the political name for this pathology, and *Revenge of the Sith* gives it its most harrowing image in the montage that intercuts the execution of Jedi across the galaxy with Anakin's march on the Temple, where he and the clone legion under his command kill the Jedi inside, children among them. The two autoimmunities—of the Force, in Anakin, and of the Republic, in Order 66—occur on the same night and are edited as a single event. City and soul fall together.

8.4

The Katechon and the Jedi Generalship

The Second Letter to the Thessalonians speaks of a mystery of lawlessness already at work, restrained by "that which withholds" (*to katechon*) and "the one who withholds" (*ho katechōn*), who must be removed before the lawless one is revealed (2 Thess. 2:6–7). Carl Schmitt, in *Der Nomos der Erde* (1950), identified the Christian empire as the historical *katechon*, the power that delays the end by restraining chaos; Esposito, in *Immunitas*, analyzed the *katechon* as an immunitary figure, which restrains evil by containing it and therefore by sharing in it; and Agamben, in *The Time That Remains* (2000), criticized the *katechon* as the power that defers messianic fulfillment.

The Jedi are the saga's *katechon*. Guardians of peace and justice for a thousand generations, they restrain the Sith, whom they believe extinct; meanwhile the mystery of lawlessness is already at work, its master seated in the Senate. The restrainer must be removed for the lawless one to be revealed, and Order 66 removes it, after which the Emperor is proclaimed. Esposito's analysis identifies the structural flaw that makes this removal possible: the *katechon* restrains evil by incorporating a meas-

ure of it. The Jedi restrain the war by commanding a slave army, restrain the Chancellor by contemplating a coup, and restrain the Chosen One by withholding from him the recognition he craves, which delivers him to the one who offers it. The restrainer becomes complicit with what it restrains, and its complicity is the opening through which it is destroyed.

The saga's purge has a precise historical antecedent in the destruction of another military-religious order. In September 1307 Philip IV of France, deeply indebted to the Knights Templar and wary of an armed order answerable to the pope rather than the crown, sent sealed orders to his officials throughout the kingdom, and at dawn on 13 October they arrested the Templars simultaneously. The charges—heresy, idolatry, sacrilege—were sustained largely by confessions extracted under torture; Pope Clement V suppressed the order in 1312; and its Grand Master, Jacques de Molay, was burned in Paris in 1314 (Barber 2006). A sovereign who had relied on the order's services, a single coordinated command executed everywhere at once, a fabricated charge of betrayal, and the order's legal abolition: Order 66 compresses the Templar catastrophe into a single night. The parallel shows that the saga's purge is not fantasy but a recognizable pattern of sovereign power, the destruction of a *katechon* by the authority it had served.

8.5

Bare Life: Clones, Droids, Slaves

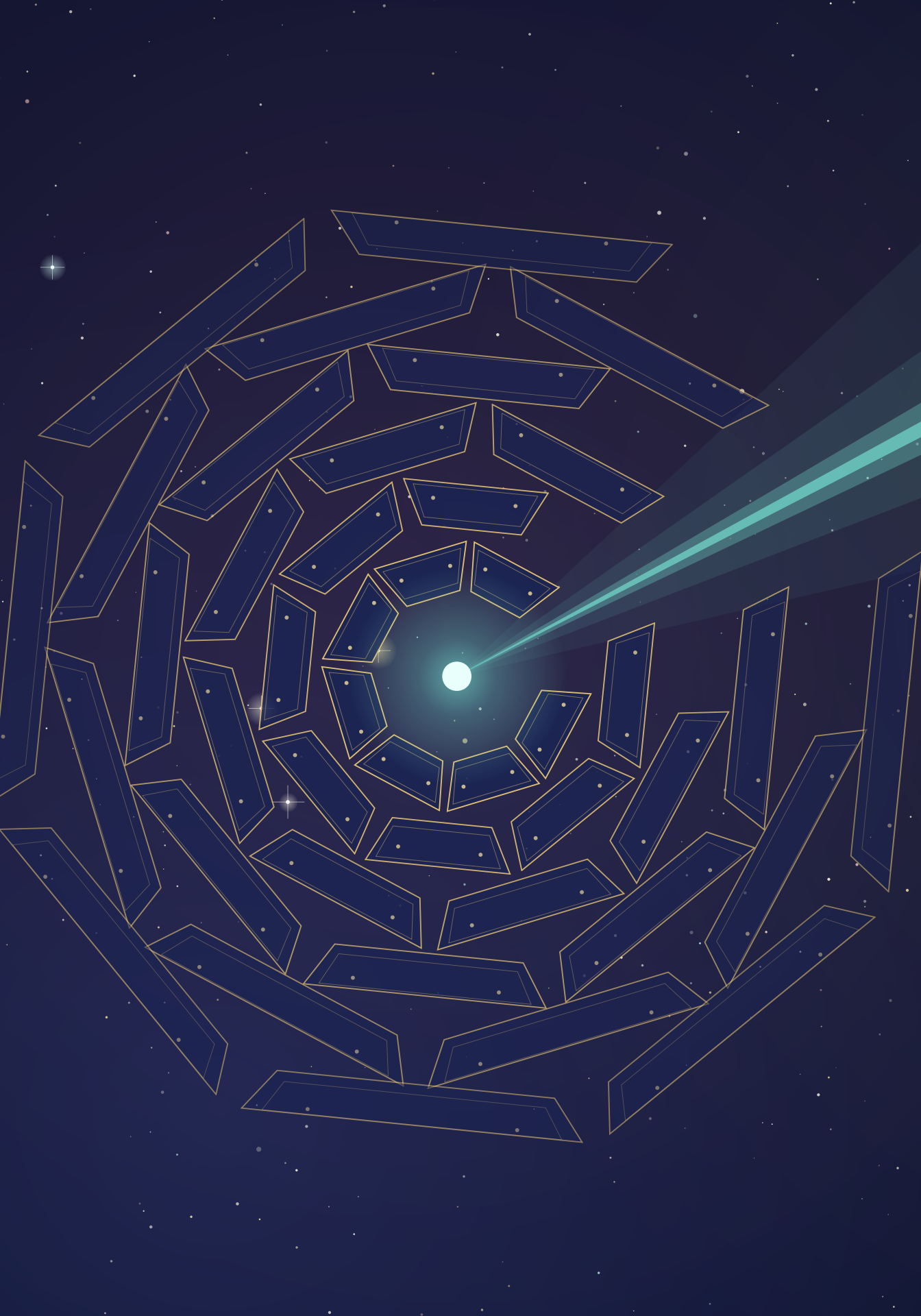
Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) distinguished *zoē*, the bare fact of being alive, from *bios*, a qualified form of life, and defined sovereign power by its capacity to produce bare life, life that may be killed without sacrifice. The saga is populated by bare life in three forms. There are slaves: Anakin and Shmi on Tatooine, beyond the Republic's writ, where slavery persists and where Qui-Gon wins the son's freedom on a wager but cannot win the mother's. There are droids: memory-wiped, fitted with restraining bolts, sold by scavengers, refused service in the cantina; C-3PO's memory is erased at the end of *Revenge of the Sith*, as though a servant's history belonged to its owners. And there are clones: bred, numbered, accelerated, and chipped. Against all three stands a single declaration, the child Anakin's answer to Padmé on Tatooine that he is not a slave but a person, and that his name is Anakin. It is the saga's charter of personhood against status, and it is spoken by the boy who will become the Empire's most dehumanized instrument.

Two classical analyses explain why the freed slave becomes the most enslaved of masters. The ninth book of Plato's *Republic* argues that the tyrannical soul, ruled by a single master passion, is the most enslaved of souls, and that the tyrant who actu-

ally attains power is the most wretched of men, captive to his fears and dependent on his guards (577c–580a). Vader, freed from bondage on Tatooine and raised to command fleets, answers his own master to the end in the formula of a servant. Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage (*Phenomenology of Spirit*, §§178–196) supplies the mechanism of the Sith institution. The bondsman's fear of death, the absolute lord, is the beginning of his wisdom, and through labor he acquires the self-consciousness the master lacks; the Rule of Two institutionalizes the dialectic as perpetual betrayal, since the apprentice can complete his self-consciousness only by killing his master. Palpatine supplies the corresponding ethics in the opera house, telling Anakin that good is a matter of perspective. The Jedi answer with a perspectivism of their own—Obi-Wan's certain point of view—turned to concealment rather than seduction. Sith and Jedi alike treat truth as a function of standpoint. Only Luke holds to a fact about a person against every standpoint: the good in his father.

The saga's droids and clones descend from a lineage of speculative fiction about manufactured servants. Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920) took the word "robot" from the Czech *robota*, corvée labor, and staged the servants' revolt; Isaac Asimov's Three Laws (*I, Robot*, 1950) imagined obedience engineered into the positronic brain; and the inhibitor chip is a biological Three Laws designed for a single exception. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) imagined a city whose happiness depends on the misery of a single child kept in a cellar; the Republic's survival depends on a population of bred soldiers whose condition its citizens do not examine, and the Jedi, who might have walked away, instead assume command. Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) made empathy the criterion of personhood and imagined, in Mercerism, a religion of shared suffering. The saga repeatedly grants its manufactured beings the empathy its powerful humans lack—the droids' loyalty, the clone who dies trying to warn the Jedi of the chips—and in doing so it relocates the criterion of personhood from origin to relation. A person, in the saga's implicit anthropology, is a being capable of the *munus*: of gift, of obligation, of sacrifice. The Republic's immune system was composed of bare life, and bare life, programmed for the exception, killed the Republic's guardians. Part Five turns from the body politic to the bodies in which this pathology became visible. ☼





V

PART FIVE

Bodies

CHAPTER 9

The Armored Body

Vader, the Death Star, and the Technics of Immunity

CHAPTER 10

The Kenotic Unmasking

CHAPTER

9

The Armored Body

Vader, the Death Star, and the Technics of Immunity

The saga's two armored bodies—a man made into a fortress and a fortress made into a world—are immunitary apparatuses in the strict sense: they preserve life by enclosing it, and each dies through the one opening its enclosure cannot abolish. The Death Star's opening is a flaw its enemies exploit; Vader's is a gift he chooses. The difference between them is the difference between autoimmune collapse and kenotic de-immunization.

9.1

Sōma Sēma: The Body as Tomb and Safekeeping

Plato twice records an Orphic or Pythagorean pun equating the body (*sōma*) with a tomb (*sēma*) (*Gorgias* 493a; *Cratylus* 400c). The *Cratylus* adds a second etymology that the saga makes uncannily exact: the body is so called because the soul is kept safe (*sōzetai*) within it, as in an enclosure or prison, until its penalty is paid. In the Orphic pun, protection and entombment are one word; the enclosure that keeps the soul safe is the tomb that buries it. Esposito could not have asked for a better ancient emblem of *immunitas*, and the saga could not have produced a more literal one than Darth Vader. The suit keeps Anakin alive and buries him; it is safekeeping and sepulcher at once. Yoda, on Dagobah, articulates the anthropology the suit violates: "Luminous beings are we, not this crude matter." Vader is luminous being sealed inside crude matter, the exact inverse of the transparent dead who appear at the saga's close.

The suit's most famous property is its sound. Ben Burtt produced Vader's respiration by recording his own breathing through a scuba regulator, so that the most recognizable breath in cinema is a diver's breath: the breath of a body sustained

within a medium that would otherwise kill it. The suit makes the shared air of the galaxy into Vader's ocean. The theological resonance is unavoidable. In Genesis the human being becomes a living soul when God breathes into its nostrils the breath of life (2:7), which the Septuagint renders *pnoē zōēs*; in the Stoic physics of Chapter 3, *pneuma*, breath, is the binding principle of the cosmos. Vader is the creature whose breath is supplied by a machine, an anti-Adam animated by a ventilator. When the mask is lifted in *Return of the Jedi*, he draws, unaided, his first and last breath since Mustafar.

9.2

The Cyborg's Infidelity: Clynes and Kline, Haraway, Shelley

The word "cyborg" was coined by Manfred Clynes and Nathan Kline in 1960, in an article for the journal *Astronautics*, to describe an organism whose self-regulation had been extended exogenously by machines so that it could survive in an environment, outer space, that would otherwise destroy it (Clynes and Kline 1960). The original cyborg was, in other words, a homeostatic prosthesis: a body whose internal constants are maintained by apparatus rather than by its own physiology. Vader is the Clynes–Kline cyborg in moral form. His homeostasis has been externalized; the self-regulation that Chapter 4 identified as the health of the living Force has been, in his body, replaced by machinery. He embodies the immunitary substitute for life: an artificial homeostasis preserving a body that can no longer preserve itself.

Norbert Wiener's *Cybernetics* (1948) had defined the science of control and communication in the animal and the machine, and Donna Haraway's "Manifesto for Cyborgs" (1985) converted the figure into a political myth. Haraway's cyborg is the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism; but illegitimate offspring, she observes, are often unfaithful to their origins, and their fathers are, after all, inessential. The observation might gloss Vader, the offspring of the Emperor's militarism, born of no father, and finally unfaithful to his maker. Yet the saga departs from Haraway at the decisive point. Haraway's cyborg has no Eden to return to and no organic wholeness to restore, whereas Vader's redemption culminates in the removal of the machine and the disclosure of a human face—a resolution a Harawayan reading would call nostalgia. The objection has force, but it misreads the scene. The unmasking restores no wholeness: the face is ruined and the man dies. What it restores is exposure. Nor is the saga technophobic. Its most beloved figures include two droids, and its hero ends the trilogy with a mechanical hand. The moral line it draws runs not between flesh and machine but between the prosthesis that opens and the armor that closes. At the end of *The Empire Strikes Back*, a

medical droid tests Luke's new hand, probing the fingers until they respond; it is a prosthesis of touch. Vader's gloves have touched no one in twenty years.

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818), which Brian Aldiss proposed as the first science-fiction novel (Aldiss 1973), supplies the genealogy of the operating-table sequence of *Revenge of the Sith*, whose iconography descends through James Whale's film of 1931: the assembled body on the slab, the slab raised, the first lurching steps, the cry. Shelley's creature diagnoses his own fall in terms the saga adopts wholesale: "I was benevolent and good; misery made me a fiend. Make me happy, and I shall again be virtuous." Anakin is made a fiend by misery, the misery of unmourned loss, and the saga grants him what Shelley's creature asked for and Victor refused. Victor flees his creation; Sidious owns his; and the creature's own son reclaims him.

9.3

Shamanic Dismemberment: Eliade and the Iron Body

Mircea Eliade's *Shamanism* (1951) documents, across Siberia, Central Asia, and Australia, a recurrent pattern of initiatory dismemberment. The candidate falls ill and undergoes, in vision or in belief, the cutting-up of his body by spirits: the flesh is scraped from the bones, the organs are removed and renewed, the body is reassembled. Among the Yakut the reassembled body may be joined with iron, and Eliade cites the Yakut saying that smiths and shamans come from the same nest, an affinity he developed in *The Forge and the Crucible* (1956). In Australian initiations, the medicine man's organs are replaced with rock crystals, which Eliade interprets as solidified celestial light. The initiate who survives returns with a new body and new powers, as a healer for his people.

Revenge of the Sith stages this initiation and inverts its outcome. On Mustafar, a volcanic world of foundries and mines—the smithy of fire—Anakin is dismembered—Obi-Wan severs his legs and his remaining arm in their duel—and his body burns at the lava's edge; he is then reassembled in metal by his master. He returns from the ordeal with a new body and new powers, not as a healer but as an executioner, bound to the master who rebuilt him rather than to the community he was to serve. It is a black initiation. Luke's initiation in *The Empire Strikes Back* is its white counterpart: a single severance, a single prosthesis, a body opened rather than sealed. The lightsaber completes the analogy. Its source of power, prefigured in the Kiber Crystal of the 1975 draft, is a crystal: the Jedi carries outside the body, as a blade of light, what the Australian medicine man carries within it. The weapon is the externalized

organ of light, and its renunciation in the throne room is the shaman's return of his power to the community.

Dismemberment is the saga's most obsessive motif. An arm is severed in the cantina and another on the ice planet; Luke loses a hand in Cloud City and Vader loses one in the throne room; Anakin loses an arm on Geonosis, Dooku both hands in the opening battle of *Revenge of the Sith*, Mace Windu a hand in the Chancellor's office, Anakin his limbs on Mustafar. Every severance substitutes machine for flesh or ends in death, and each is a step in a cascade of immunization. The cascade is arrested once. In the throne room, having severed his father's mechanical hand, Luke looks from the sparking stump to his own gloved prosthetic hand, recognizes the pattern, and stops. The visual rhyme of the two hands is the saga's most deliberate chiasmus, and it marks the moment the cycle of dismemberment is broken by recognition.

9.4

Enframing and Releasement: The Targeting Computer and the Exhaust Port

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) defines the essence of modern technology as *Gestell*, enframing: a mode of revealing that challenges forth all beings as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, stockpiled and on call for further ordering. The supreme danger of enframing is that human beings themselves come to be revealed as standing-reserve. The Empire is *Gestell* made political. Its worlds are mined, its soldiers are stock, its clones are manufactured to order, and the Death Star is enframing's culmination, a machine that reveals every planet as a target. Heidegger answers the danger with lines from Hölderlin's "Patmos": *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch*—but where danger is, there grows also what saves. The saving power, Heidegger insists, grows within the danger rather than outside it. Luke's decision in the Death Star trench to switch off his targeting computer, at the urging of his dead mentor's voice, dramatizes this thought: at the heart of the ultimate machine, calculative thinking yields to the releasement (*Gelassenheit*) that Heidegger, borrowing Eckhart's word, described in 1959 as a letting-be of things and an openness to the mystery. Here the Jedi's Eckhartian detachment, which failed as an institutional ethic (Chapter 6), succeeds as a mode of attention. Detachment is right as a way of perceiving and wrong as a renunciation of love, and the saga distinguishes the two with a precision its critics have not credited.

The Death Star's vulnerability is a thermal exhaust port, a small ventilation shaft leading to the reactor. The detail is easily dismissed as a contrivance of plot. It is in

fact the saga's deepest statement about immunity. Every immune body must have openings, because a body that cannot exhale dies; absolute closure is impossible to the living. The most perfectly immunized body ever imagined must still breathe, and its vulnerability is its breath. Mikhail Bakhtin opposed the classical body of official culture—closed, smooth, finished, impenetrable—to the grotesque body of carnival, open, protruding, exchanging matter with the world through its orifices (Bakhtin 1968). The Empire's aesthetic is the classical body: the sphere of the station, the polished helmet, the white armor of its troops. The Rebellion and its allies inhabit the grotesque: the patched hull of the *Falcon*, the fur of the Wookiee and the Ewoks, the cantina, the forest. The Death Star dies through its one grotesque feature, its orifice; Vader dies when his own sealed body is opened. The two armored bodies die by the same law, but the station's opening is a flaw exploited by its enemies, while Vader's is a gift he chooses. A later production, *Rogue One* (2016), would explain the exhaust port as a weakness deliberately engineered into the station by one of its own designers, literalizing the autoimmune reading that the original film implied (see Coda).

9.5

The Hard and the Soft: Laozi 76 and the Ethics of the Face

The seventy-sixth chapter of the *Daodejing* reads, in a literal rendering: at birth a person is soft and supple; at death, hard and stiff. The ten thousand things, grasses and trees, are tender and pliant in life and dry and brittle in death. Therefore the hard and stiff are companions of death; the soft and supple are companions of life. Therefore an army that is unyielding will not prevail, and a tree that is rigid will break. No text glosses the saga's iconography more completely. The armored army does not prevail; the armored man is death's companion; and the companions of life are soft: a small, aged, green master; a forest people mocked as teddy bears, who defeat Imperial walkers with logs, stones, and vines; two infants carried into hiding. The seventy-eighth chapter adds that nothing under heaven is softer than water, yet nothing surpasses it in attacking the hard.

Emmanuel Levinas located the ethical summons in the face (*le visage*), whose nakedness and defenselessness command, before any reasoning, that one shall not kill (Levinas 1961). The face is the most exposed surface of the body, and its exposure is its authority. Vader has no face. His mask abolishes the summons that would restrain his violence, as the identical helmets of the clones and the blank visors of the stormtroopers abolish theirs: a face shared by an entire army is no one's face, and a faceless army may kill and be killed without grief. Judith Butler's *Precarious Life*

(2004) asked which lives are grievable, and answered that the distribution of grievability is itself political. The saga's ungrievable populations—clones, droids, the billions of Alderaan—are ungrievable because they are faceless. The unmasking of Vader is therefore more than a private reconciliation. It restores a face to the faceless, and with the face, the possibility of grief. The next chapter shows that grief is precisely what the saga's final movement performs.

CHAPTER

10

The Kenotic Unmasking

The saga's chiastic architecture places at its center the simultaneous birth of one armored body and two exposed ones, and it resolves at its outer edge in the voluntary removal of the armor. Read across the six films, the climax of Return of the Jedi *is a threefold kenosis—the son disarms, the father empties himself of power, the father consents to be unmasked—followed by the restoration of the mourning the prequels had forbidden.*

10.1

Ring Composition and the Immunitary Center

Mary Douglas's *Thinking in Circles* (2007) identified in the Hebrew Bible and in Homer a compositional form in which a text divides into two halves whose sections mirror one another across a central turn, closes by returning to its beginning, and loads its meaning at the center. Lucas, in the documentary record of the making of *The Phantom Menace*, described the saga as rhyming in the manner of poetry, and Mike Klimo's para-academic essay "Star Wars Ring Theory" (2014) mapped the six films as three concentric pairs. The correspondences are dense enough to tabulate.

RING	PREQUEL FILM	MIRROR FILM	PRINCIPAL RHYMES
 OUTER	*The Phantom Menace*	*Return of the Jedi*	Slavery on Tatooine (Watto's shop; Jabba's palace); indigenous allies against a mechanized army (Gungans; Ewoks); a station destroyed from within its core; a Jedi–Sith duel intercut with battles in space and on the ground; a funeral pyre; a festival uniting peoples

RING	PREQUEL FILM	MIRROR FILM	PRINCIPAL RHYMES
 MIDDLE	*Attack of the Clones*	*The Empire Strikes Back*	An apprentice abandons training to rescue loved ones seen in visions; a severed arm or hand; a bounty hunter of the Fett line; a concealed origin disclosed; each film ends on a mechanical hand
 INNER	*Revenge of the Sith*	*A New Hope*	The death of the Republic and the birth of the Rebellion; the same consular ship closes one film and opens the other; the twin suns over the Lars homestead, first with the infant and then with the grown son; Vader's first breath in the suit and his first entrance

In Douglas's poetics the center bears the weight of the whole. The saga's center falls between its third and fourth films, in the final movement of *Revenge of the Sith*, where the editing intercuts Padmé's labor and death on Polis Massa with Vader's assembly on the operating table. Two natural births and one prosthetic birth occur in the same minutes: Luke and Leia are delivered into exposure, Vader into armor, and his first act in the suit is a cry of grief for a death he caused. Hobbes's twins (Chapter 7) are reborn as galactic allegory: in the hour of the Empire's founding, *communitas* and *immunitas* are born together and sundered. The twins are hidden at opposite ends of the galaxy, a community held in reserve; the armored body goes to serve the Leviathan. The three films that follow are the story of their reconvergence.

10.2

The Cave: Shadow and Self-Recognition

On Dagobah, Yoda directs Luke toward a cave strong with the dark side. Asked what lies within, Yoda answers that there is only what Luke takes with him, and Luke, against Yoda's counsel, takes his weapons. In the cave he meets Vader, duels him, and strikes off his head; the mask splits open to reveal Luke's own face. The episode condenses three traditions. It is Jung's encounter with the shadow, the dark complement of the personality that must be recognized as one's own before it can cease to rule (Jung 1951). It is Ged's pursuit of his shadow in Ursula K. Le Guin's *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968), which ends when Ged names the shadow with his own name, a scene Le Guin glossed in "The Child and the Shadow" (1975) as the acceptance of one's own darkness. And it inverts Plato's cave (*Republic* 514a–520a): the figure Luke meets underground is not a deceptive shadow of reality but a true image of himself.

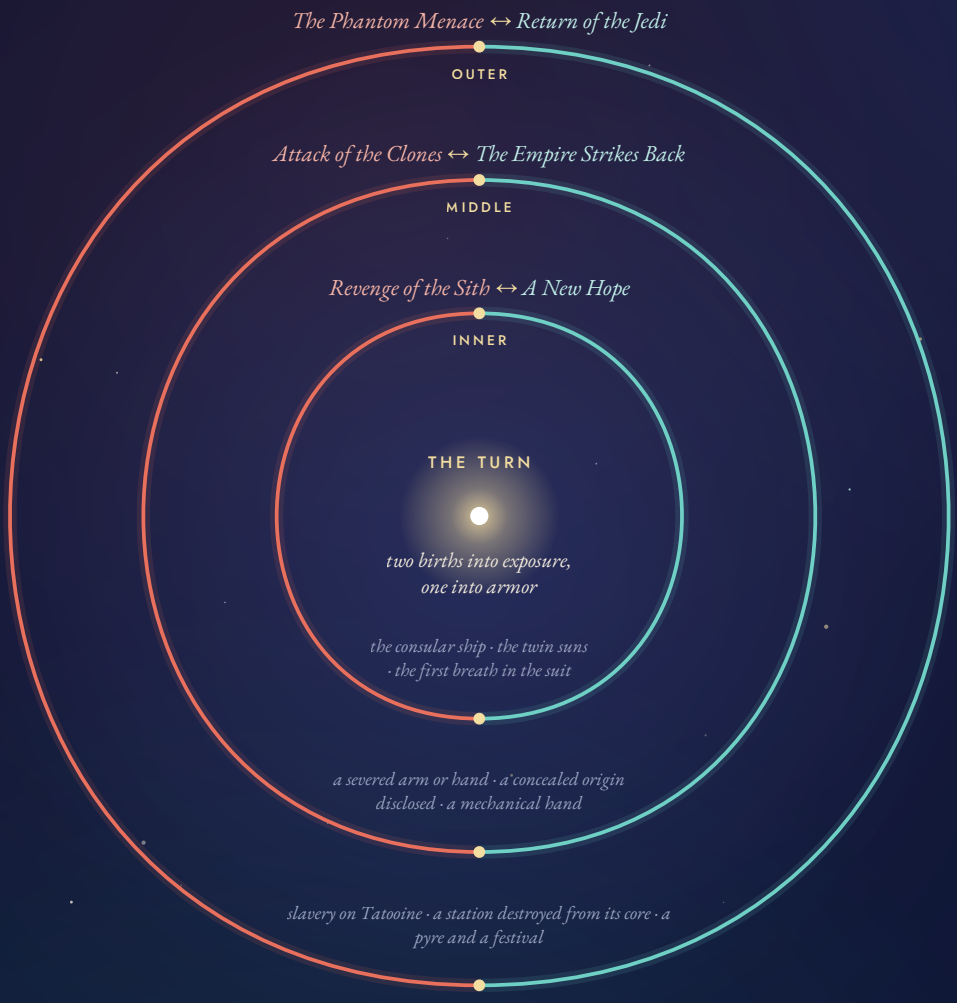


PLATE X

Three rings and a center

The six films as three concentric pairs, mirrored across the saga's turn, where one armored body and two exposed ones are born in the same minutes.

SEE § 10.1

The cave also states the law that the throne room will obey: the one who enters armed meets himself as the armored. Luke carries his weapon into the cave, and the vision answers the weapon with the image of the man whom weapons made. When he returns to the confrontation in *Return of the Jedi*, he has learned what the cave taught. To see the father's face beneath the mask he must first see his own, and to stop becoming the father he must lay down the instrument of the cycle.

10.3

Anagnorisis and the Phantom

Aristotle defined recognition (*anagnorisis*) as a change from ignorance to knowledge, producing love or hatred between persons marked for good or ill fortune, and held it finest when it coincides with reversal (*Poetics* 1452a). The disclosure in Cloud City is the most consequential recognition in popular cinema, and it coincides with a reversal of nearly unbearable completeness. Luke loses his hand; his weapon, his father's own, falls with the hand into the abyss; and he loses his illusions about his origin and his trust in his mentor. Yet the recognition produces neither love nor hatred at once. It produces refusal. Luke cries out against the disclosure and lets himself fall rather than take his father's offered hand.

Lacan's Name-of-the-Father (*le Nom-du-Père*), which he punned as the father's No (*le Non-du-Père*), names the symbolic function by which paternal prohibition institutes the subject's place in the law. In Cloud City the pun is reversed: it is the son who answers the father's name with a No. The disclosure is also, as Chapter 5 argued, the eruption of a phantom in Nicolas Abraham's sense—a secret withheld by Obi-Wan, Yoda, and the foster-parents, transmitted as an absence that organized Luke's life. In *Return of the Jedi* Luke confronts Obi-Wan with the lie, and Obi-Wan's defense, that what he said was true from a certain point of view, is usually mocked as sophistry. It is better read as confession: the Jedi's truth was perspectival because their institution required the father to be dead. Nietzsche's dictum that there are no facts, only interpretations, here receives its institutional form. An Order's interpretation of the father as dead was the instrument of its resignation.

10.4

Harpagmos and Kenosis: The Philippians Hymn as Hidden Matrix

The early Christian hymn preserved in Philippians 2:6–11 supplies the deep grammar of Anakin's arc. Christ, being in the form of God, did not regard equality with God as *harpagmos*, a thing to be seized, but emptied himself (*heauton ekenōsen*), tak-

ing the form of a slave (*morphē doulou*); he humbled himself, becoming obedient unto death; therefore God highly exalted him (*hyperypsōsen*). The hymn descends from divine form through self-emptying and servitude to death, and rises to exaltation.

Anakin traverses the hymn in a disordered sequence that the saga finally sets right. He is born in the form of a slave, literally, on Tatooine, and without a father. Where the hymn's subject declines to seize equality with the divine, Anakin seizes it: he grasps at the prerogative over life and death that Plagueis was said to possess, and this *harpagmos* is his fall. The descent that follows is not humility but dismemberment, burning, and entombment. In the throne room he performs at last the kenosis he had refused. He empties himself of power—lifting his master and casting him down while the lightning meant for his son passes through his own body—and then of the protection that sustains him, asking to be unmasked. The exaltation follows in the hymn's own logic of "therefore": the transparent figure who stands beside Obi-Wan and Yoda at the festival. Kenotic theology from Gottfried Thomasius to Sergei Bulgakov has read self-emptying as the very form of divine love, and Simone Weil's notion of *décréation*, the self's consent to be undone so that love may pass through it, gives the doctrine its most austere modern statement (Weil 1947). Vader's last acts are decreation in Weil's sense. He consents to be undone.

10.5

The Throne Room: The Swordless Victory

The throne-room sequence is the point of convergence for every argument in this study. Provoked by the Emperor and by Vader's threat to turn his sister, Luke attacks in rage, overpowers his father, and severs his mechanical hand. The Emperor applauds and invites him to take his father's place. Luke looks from the stump to his own hand and stops; he casts his weapon aside and declares himself a Jedi, as his father was before him. This is at once the Yagyū *mutō*, the victory without a sword (Chapter 3); the middle way between the Sith's grasping and the Jedi's aversion (Chapter 5); the second movement of the knight of faith and the Son's refusal of the kingdoms of the world (Chapter 6); and the carrier bag's displacement of the spear (Chapter 2). In the terms of this chapter, it is the first kenosis of the sequence: the son empties himself of the means of protection before the father does.

The Emperor answers with lightning, and the disarmed son, writhing on the floor, calls to his father. The son's exposed suffering is the one appeal the armored father cannot resist; it is the face, in Levinas's sense, returning through the mask. Vader turns his masked head from master to son and back, then lifts the Emperor



PLATE XI

Harpagmos and kenosis

The Philippians hymn descends from divine form to death and rises to exaltation. Anakin traverses it out of order: seizing, falling into armor, and emptying himself only in the throne room.

SEE § 10.4

and casts him down the reactor shaft (since the 2011 Blu-ray release, with the same cry of refusal that followed his first breath in the suit, so that the father's last choice echoes the sound of his birth into armor)—the *pharmakos* expelled, in Frye's terms, the tempter fallen from the pinnacle, in Milton's. In the instant of the act, the lightning courses through the suit and Vader's skeleton flickers visibly through his armor. The shell becomes, for a moment, transparent. The image prefigures the form in which he will reappear, and it is the saga's visual signature for the Kierkegaardian self that rests transparently in the power that established it (Chapter 6).

10.6

The Unmasking

On the ramp of the Emperor's shuttle, the dying Vader asks his son to remove the mask. Luke protests that it will kill him; Vader answers that nothing can stop that now and asks, "Just for once, let me look on you with my own eyes." The helmet is lifted. The face beneath is pale, scarred, and old, and it smiles. Vader tells Luke that he was right about him, asks him to tell his sister so, and dies.

The scene gathers every frame this study has assembled. In Esposito's terms it is de-immunization: the voluntary surrender of the protective apparatus, at the cost of life, for the sake of a gift, the gift of seeing and being seen. In Levinas's terms it restores the face-to-face. In Kierkegaard's it ends the inclosing reserve, the demonic disclosed through speech. In Plato's it opens the tomb; in Genesis's it returns the unmediated breath. And in Derrida's it is autoimmunity in its affirmative mode. For Derrida, autoimmunity is not only pathology; it is also the condition of hospitality, since no living being can receive the other without lowering its defenses, and absolute protection would mean absolute closure, which is death (Derrida 2003). Order 66 was autoimmunity suffered; the unmasking is autoimmunity chosen. The difference between the Republic's death and Anakin's is the difference between a defense that turns against the self and a self that disarms its own defense in order to receive another. The first is catastrophe. The second is love.

The 2004 revision of the film's final scene, which replaced Sebastian Shaw's aged spectral Anakin with Hayden Christensen's young one, has been widely deplored as a retroactive intrusion of the prequels. Within the argument of this study it is a coherent theological decision. The redeemed self appears not at the age of its death but at the age of its last integrity, the moment before Mustafar and before the armor. Thomas Aquinas, considering the resurrection of the body, held that all would rise at the age of Christ's maturity, the age of nature's perfection rather than

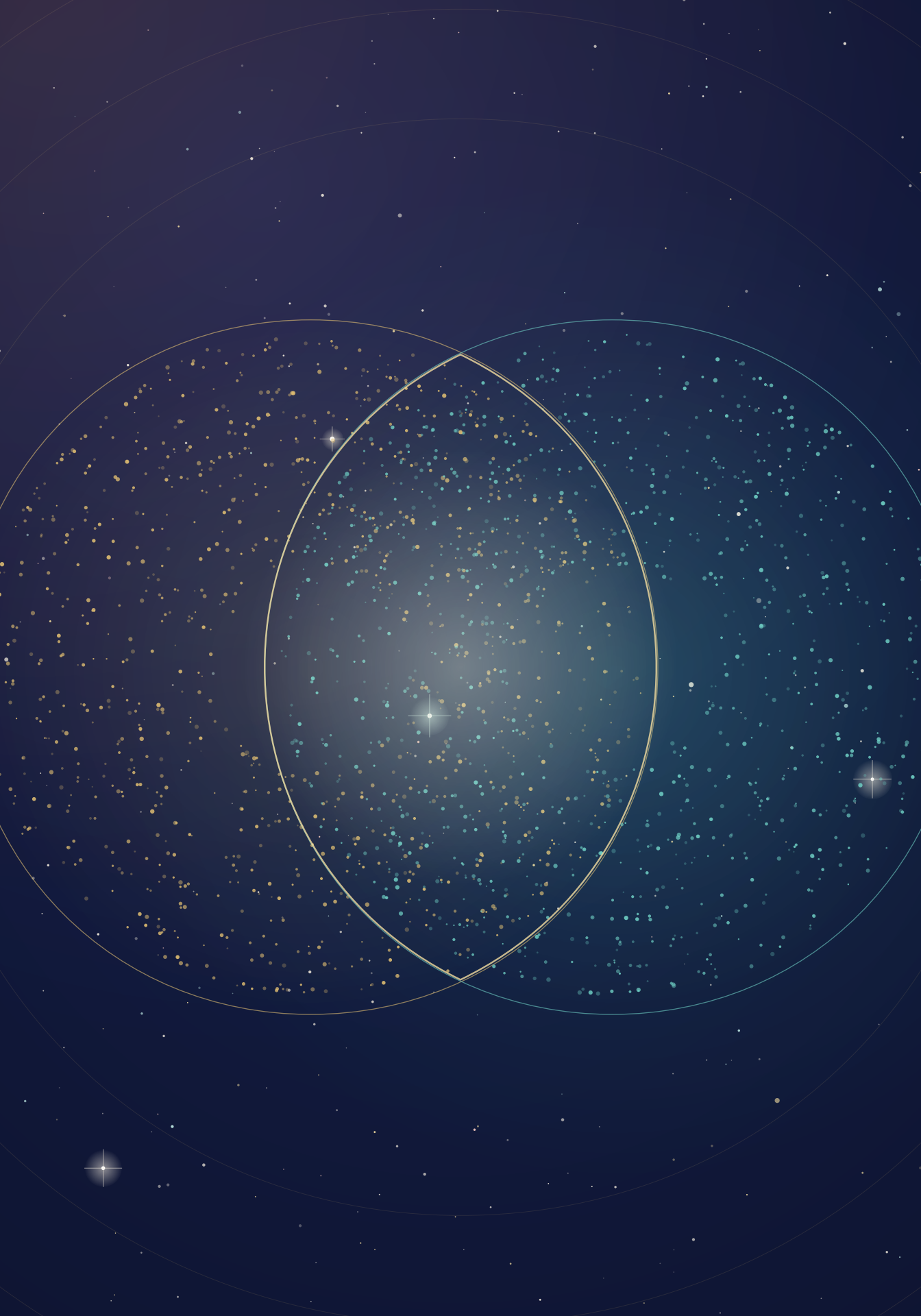
of its decline (*Summa theologiae*, Suppl. q. 81, a. 1). The revision applies an analogous principle: the self that survives de-immunization is the self as it was before immunization began.

10.7

Pyre and Festival: Mourning Restored

That night on Endor, Luke builds a pyre and burns his father's armor. The scene rhymes with Qui-Gon's cremation at the close of *The Phantom Menace*, and the rhyme measures the distance the saga has traveled. The first pyre is an institutional rite. The Council attends in ranks, its masters speaking not of grief but of succession and threat, and among the mourners stands the newly elected Chancellor, whose apprentice, Darth Maul, did the killing: the parasite attends the funeral of its victim. The second pyre is a son's mourning, performed alone, without an Order. What burns is the armor itself, the immunitary shell and externalized crypt of Chapter 5, consumed in a rite of release. Its occupant is not incorporated but mourned. Yoda forbade Anakin to mourn; Yoda's last pupil mourns Anakin. Zhuangzi grieved before he sang, and the saga, at last, grieves before it celebrates.

The sequence enacts a precept of the *Daodejing* so exactly that it deserves rendering in full. Chapter 31 teaches that weapons are instruments of ill omen; that when many have been killed, one should weep for them with grief and sorrow; and that a victory in war should be observed with the rites of mourning. *Return of the Jedi* observes its victory with a funeral, and only after the funeral does the festival begin. The Ewok village, with its drums and dancing, is communitas in the anthropological sense Victor Turner gave the term: the spontaneous, egalitarian bond that arises among those who have passed together through a liminal ordeal (Turner 1969). The 1997 Special Edition extended the celebration across the galaxy, to Bespin, Tatooine, and Coruscant, and the 2004 edition added Naboo, closing the outer ring with the festival world of the first film. Frye's comic society is formed; Bakhtin's carnival overturns the hierarchy of armor; Campbell's hero stands as master of the two worlds. And at the edge of the firelight the dead appear, transparent: Obi-Wan, Yoda, Anakin. In the saga's final image, the dead return as companions only after they have been mourned. Freud's account of mourning ends with the ego free again; the saga's ends with the living and the dead together, and the mask in ashes. ⊹



VI

PART SIX

Comparison and Synthesis

CHAPTER 11

Comparative Mythopoetics

CHAPTER 12

Toward a Symbiotic Theodicy

CHAPTER

11

Comparative Mythopoetics

Set beside its nearest cognates, Lucas's saga is distinctive in three respects: it locates the savior's danger in fear rather than charisma; it figures balance as homeostasis rather than as equilibrium or victory; and it resolves its plot through the conversion of its villain rather than his destruction. These differences, rather than the motifs it shares with its sources, define its originality.

11.1

Against the Messiah: Herbert's *Dune*

Frank Herbert built *Dune* (1965) and its sequels as a warning. Paul Atreides is the product of the Bene Gesserit breeding program; his prescience shows him the jihad that will be waged in his name, which he cannot prevent; and in *Dune Messiah* (1969) he discovers that prescience is a trap that fixes the future it reveals. In "Dune Genesis" (1980), Herbert explained that he had set out to show that superheroes are disastrous for humankind because their followers surrender judgment to them. The resemblances between the two works are numerous: a desert world, a precious spice, a compelling voice, a messianic youth, a breeding program. The difference is decisive. Herbert locates the catastrophe in charisma and in the crowds who worship it; Lucas locates it in the savior's own fear of loss. Paul is ruined by being followed, Anakin by being afraid. Both are prisoners of visions, but Paul's show him a future he cannot escape, whereas Anakin's show him a future he brings about by trying to escape it.

Herbert's *God Emperor of Dune* (1981) went further. Leto II imposes a millennial tyranny on humanity deliberately, as an inoculation against stagnation, a lesson so painful that the species will never forget it. Herbert's tyrant is a vaccine, a self-con-

scious immunizer of the species. Lucas's Emperor is offered no such justification. Where Herbert, ambivalently, entertains tyranny as therapy, Lucas diagnoses it as disease.

11.2

Prediction and Its Anomaly: Asimov's *Foundation*

Asimov's psychohistory predicts the behavior of masses with statistical certainty, and Hari Seldon's Plan proposes to shorten the dark age that follows the Empire's fall from thirty millennia to one. The Plan is wrecked by the Mule, a mutant with the power to alter emotions, whose singularity psychohistory cannot foresee; and it is guarded by the Second Foundation, a hidden order of mentalic guardians who manipulate history for its own good. The Jedi combine both of Asimov's institutions: they are a visible order of peacekeepers and a precognitive priesthood whose foresight fails before a singularity. Yoda's admission that the boy's future is clouded, and that the future is always in motion, is psychohistory confronting the Mule.

The deepest parallel lies in how the singularity is halted. In "The Mule" (1945), the conqueror confesses that the one thing his power had never produced, and the thing that stayed his hand, was the uncoerced kindness Bayta Darell had shown him; because he would not tamper with it, she remained free to thwart him. Vader is turned by the same force, an affection he did not and could not compel. Both sagas discover, against their predictive and martial apparatus, that the unforeseeable tyrant can be disarmed only by unforced love.

11.3

Cosmic Dualism and Breeding Programs: Smith's *Lensman*

E. E. Smith's cosmos is Manichaean without remainder. The benevolent Arisians wage a war of billions of years against the tyrannical Eddorians, and they prevail by breeding a lineage of human Lensmen whose final generation supersedes them. Civilization is policed by the Galactic Patrol, evil is organized in the conspiracy of Boskone, and the climax is the annihilation of Eddore. The Jedi before their fall resemble the Lensmen—a galactic constabulary with parapsychological powers in the service of a civilization—and the saga's critique of their militarization in the Clone Wars (Chapter 8) is in effect a critique of the Lensman ideal, the fusion of spiritual elite and armed police. Lucas departs from Smith at every metaphysical joint. There is no Arisia, no benevolent counter-power outside the one Force; the breeding program is undecidable rather than providential; and the climax is not the annihilation of evil by superior power but the conversion of its chief instrument.

11.4

Eucatastrophe and the Machine: Tolkien

Tolkien's "On Fairy-Stories" (1947) named the sudden joyous turn of the fairy story *eucatastrophe*, the good catastrophe, which denies universal final defeat and grants a fleeting glimpse of joy beyond the walls of the world; he called the Resurrection the eucatastrophe of the story of the Incarnation. Vader's turn is a eucatastrophe in the strict sense: sudden, unprepared by the logic of the plot, a grace the narrative did not guarantee. The structural parallel with *The Lord of the Rings* is closer than is usually noticed. At the Crack of Doom, Frodo fails—he claims the Ring—and the quest succeeds only because Gollum seizes it and falls. Tolkien explained that the outcome turned on the pity Bilbo and Frodo had earlier shown Gollum (Tolkien 1981, letter 246). Luke's pity for Vader likewise makes possible the Emperor's destruction, and in both stories the hero's will is insufficient at the decisive moment: Frodo cannot destroy the Ring, and Luke nearly kills in rage. Salvation comes through the ruined figure the hero refused to kill. The difference is equally telling. Tolkien's Gollum comes close to repentance on the stairs of Cirith Ungol, and the moment is spoiled by Sam's harsh word, a failure Tolkien called the tragedy of Gollum. Lucas grants his Gollum the repentance Tolkien withheld.

Tolkien's critique of the Machine as the will to dominate the world and other wills through external power (Tolkien 1981, letter 131) underwrites the saga's ecology of forest against factory. Treebeard's verdict that Saruman's mind is made of metal and wheels, and the Ents' destruction of Isengard, prefigure the Ewoks' war on Imperial walkers. The One Ring and the dark side nonetheless differ in kind. The Ring is an object, external and destructible; the dark side is a disposition, internal and convertible. Tolkien's quest destroys a thing; Lucas's converts a person.

11.5

Equilibrium and Shadow: Le Guin's Earthsea

Ursula K. Le Guin's Earthsea is the saga's closest metaphysical cognate. Magic there is bound by the Equilibrium: every act of power disturbs a balance that must be respected, and the wizard's highest wisdom is to act only from need. Le Guin, who later published her own version of the *Daodejing* (1997), conceived the Equilibrium in Taoist terms, as a harmony of complementaries in which light and dark, word and silence, life and death each require the other. Her balance is therefore closer to integration than Lucas's: Ged becomes whole by accepting his shadow as part of himself. Luke accepts that the shadow is his—the face in the cave is his own—but

refuses to enact it. Recognition without enactment is the saga's distinctive ethic of the shadow, and it is why Lucas's balance is homeostatic rather than integrative. The dark side is not a complement to be included but a hypertrophy to be outgrown.

The Farthest Shore (1972) offers a still closer parallel. Its antagonist, the sorcerer Cob, seeks to escape death and in doing so opens a breach through which meaning, skill, and magic drain from the world. Cob is cousin to Plagueis and to Anakin: the immortality project as ecological catastrophe. Ged closes the breach by spending the whole of his power and returns from the dry land a man without magic, his work done. The ending is kenotic in the strict sense, and it anticipates by eleven years the resolution of *Return of the Jedi*. Earthsea and the saga, the two great Taoist mythopoeias of the American 1970s, agree that the craving for deathlessness is the root of evil and that its cure is an emptying.

11.6

The Source and the Son: Kirby's *Fourth World*

Jack Kirby's *Fourth World* (1970–1973) presents the most precise structural parallels with the saga and no documented influence. The benevolent world of New Genesis and the infernal world of Apokolips, ruled by Darkseid, conclude a peace by exchanging sons: Darkseid's son Orion is raised on New Genesis and becomes its fiercest champion, struggling against the savagery of his blood, while Highfather's son grows up in the torture-orphanages of Apokolips. Orion's handsome features are maintained by his Mother Box, a sentient and symbiotic machine, over a visage that would betray his father's lineage: a mask concealing paternity. Darkseid seeks the Anti-Life Equation, the formula for the total domination of other wills, and all life draws on the Source. The correspondences—a cosmic Source and a Force, a tyrant whose aim is the domination of will, a son who must confront the father whose face he hides—are unmistakable. The divergence is equally clear. Kirby foretold that Orion would kill Darkseid in the fire-pits of Armagetto; his is Rank's Oedipal hero. Lucas's hero refuses patricide, and his saga is, in this precise sense, anti-Oedipal.

11.7

Gnostic Counterpoints: The *Hymn of the Pearl* and *The Matrix*

The *Hymn of the Pearl*, preserved in the apocryphal *Acts of Thomas* (108–113), tells of a prince sent by his royal parents into Egypt to recover a pearl guarded by a serpent. He forgets his origin, eats the food of the land, and falls asleep. His parents send a letter, which flies to him like an eagle and becomes speech, reminding him that he is a king's son; he awakens, charms the serpent, seizes the pearl, and returns

to put on a radiant robe in which he sees himself as in a mirror. Hans Jonas made the hymn central to his account of Gnosticism as a religion of the call from without, the message that awakens the forgetful spirit to its alien origin (Jonas 1958). The parallels with *A New Hope* are exact: a son of royalty, whose mother had been a queen, raised on a desert world in ignorance of his lineage; a message carried by a servant, which becomes speech when it is projected; an awakening to a calling. Campbell's call to adventure is the Gnostic call.

Yet the saga is not Gnostic, and the difference matters. Gnosticism treats the material cosmos as a prison fashioned by an ignorant demiurge and salvation as escape from it. Yoda's dictum on luminous beings and crude matter sounds Gnostic, but the midi-chlorians locate the Force inside living matter, and the saga's redemption is consummated in a body, the unmasked face. The saga is incarnational and symbiotic where Gnosticism is acosmic. The contrast is sharpest with *The Matrix* (1999), released the same spring as *The Phantom Menace*. The Wachowskis' film is overtly Gnostic and Baudrillardian—a copy of *Simulacra and Simulation* appears in it as a hollowed-out book—and its cosmos is parasitic, with machines harvesting human bodies for energy and a villain who describes humanity as a virus. The trilogy's resolution, however, is kenotic: in *The Matrix Revolutions* (2003), Neo defeats Smith by allowing Smith to absorb him. At the turn of the millennium both of popular cinema's great messianic cycles resolved their wars through the Chosen One's self-surrender. The one sought liberation from the flesh; the other found it within the flesh.

11.8

Sacred Time: Eliade and "A Long Time Ago"

Mircea Eliade argued that myth narrates what took place *in illo tempore*, in the sacred time of origins, which ritual reactualizes, and that archaic peoples defended themselves through cyclical myth against the "terror of history," the exposure to irreversible and meaningless events (Eliade 1949). The saga's epigraphic formula, "A long time ago in a galaxy far, far away," is a formula of *in illo tempore*. It relocates the apparatus of futurity into the mythic past and converts science fiction into the fairy tale's "once upon a time." Its worn, patched, "used" technologies are the visual correlate: a technology already old is a technology already mythic. Darko Suvin's objection that the saga lacks a cognitive novum is accurate and beside the point. The saga is not extrapolation but myth.

Eliade's thesis illuminates the saga's double form. Its ring composition and generational relay are forms of cyclical consolation: what was lost in the first trilogy is

restored in the second, the fallen father returned, the festival repeated. Its content, especially in the prequels, is the terror of history in its starkest political form, the fall of a republic through its own lawful procedures. The saga consoles in its form for what it refuses to console in its content. The ritual reactualization Eliade described has duly followed: release dates kept like feast days, midnight vigils in costume, the census of 2001.

11.9

The American Monomyth

In 1977, the year of *A New Hope*, Robert Jewett and John Shelton Lawrence distinguished Campbell's classical monomyth, a narrative of initiation in which the hero returns to be integrated into society, from what they called the American monomyth, a narrative of redemption. In its pattern, a harmonious community is threatened by evil; its normal institutions fail; a selfless superhero emerges, renounces temptation, and carries out the redemptive task; and, aided by fate, his decisive victory restores the community to its paradisal condition, after which he recedes into obscurity (Jewett and Lawrence 1977). They warned that the pattern teaches contempt for democratic institutions and faith in the redemptive vigilante. The prequel trilogy reads as a critique of exactly this pattern. When the Senate fails and the Jedi falter, a reluctant savior accepts emergency powers and promises to lay them down when the crisis passes. The American monomyth's superhero is the Chancellor, and its vigilante is Anakin. The original trilogy's resolution, conversely, is collective—a fleet, a strike team, a forest people—and its decisive act is a refusal to kill. Released as a candidate instance of the American monomyth, the saga, completed, is its refutation. ⊙

CHAPTER

12

Toward a Symbiotic Theodicy

The argument of this study can be stated as five propositions—ontological, pathological, soteriological, narratological, and reflexive—which together constitute a theory of evil and redemption that is neither Manichaean, nor strictly Augustinian, nor Jungian. Its scientific analogue is not the defensive immunology of Burnet but the network immunology of Jerne and Varela, and its final test is the history of the saga itself.

12.1

Five Propositions

Proposition 1 (ontological). The Force is a holobiontic ecology: an immanent field of life that is constituted by living beings, mediates among them, and binds them, and whose communications pass through endosymbionts. Its "will" is the homeostatic tendency of the whole, not a moral providence; like the heaven and earth of the *Daodejing*, it is impartial. Morality enters the system through persons, as the cooperation of a part with the health of the whole (Chapters 3–4).

Proposition 2 (pathological). Evil is a pathology of relation, appearing in two forms. *Parasitism*, the form proper to the Sith, is life lived by consuming another's life. The Rule of Two is an obligate host–parasite cycle in which each generation feeds on its predecessor; Plagueis's manipulation of the midi-chlorians is an attempt to seize the symbiotic channel itself; and Palpatine's career is the parasitism of a republic whose institutions he inhabits as a host. *Autoimmunity*, the form proper to the late Jedi Order and the Republic, is a defensive mechanism turned against the self it was instituted to protect: the Order's immunization against love,

which produced the fall it feared; the Republic's cloned army, which purged its guardians; the Senate's emergency powers, which abolished the Senate. Neither form is a substance, against Mani, and neither is a mere absence, against a strict reading of Augustine. Both are, in Canguilhem's sense, reduced norms of life (Chapters 3, 5, 7–8).

Proposition 3 (soteriological). Balance is homeostasis, restored not by victory but by de-immunization: the voluntary surrender of protection—of the weapon, by the son; of power, by the father; of life-support, by the father again—which reopens the system to its own self-regulation. Salvation in the saga is kenotic, and its sign is transparency (Chapters 5–6, 9–10).

Proposition 4 (narratological). The monomyth is the narrative form of de-immunization. Departure is exposure, the abandonment of the protected home; initiation is the stripping of protections, figured in the saga as dismemberment; return is the gift, the *munus*, brought back to the community. The saga's ring composition centers on the simultaneous birth of an immunized body and two exposed ones, and its resolution is their reconvergence. Its heroism is relayed across generations because de-immunization requires two: one who exposes himself, and one who receives the exposure without exploiting it (Chapters 2, 10).

Proposition 5 (reflexive). The institutional history of the text reenacts the pathology the text diagnoses, and the text's critique survives its institution's practice (Section 12.4).

12.2

Varela against Burnet: Two Models of the Self

The immunology of the mid-twentieth century, dominated by Burnet's clonal selection theory and his framing of immunity as the discrimination of self from not-self, was a science of defense, and its public idiom was military. Donna Haraway's "The Biopolitics of Postmodern Bodies" (in Haraway 1991) and Emily Martin's *Flexible Bodies* (1994) documented the saturation of immune discourse with the imagery of invasion, surveillance, and counterattack, which reached a popular apotheosis in *National Geographic*'s 1986 portrait of the immune system as a theater of "wars within." Susan Sontag's *Illness as Metaphor* (1978) and *AIDS and Its Metaphors* (1989) had already indicted the military metaphor for the suffering it licenses. The prequel war is Burnet's model enacted as history, and its catastrophe is the one his critics feared: a defense that cannot distinguish enemy from self once the definitions are changed.

A second immunology ran alongside the first. Niels Jerne's network theory (1974) proposed that antibodies recognize not only antigens but one another, so that the immune system's primary activity is self-referential recognition: a network of idiotypes and anti-idiotypes whose dynamic state constitutes the body's molecular identity. Francisco Varela and Antonio Coutinho (1991) developed this into a "second-generation" network immunology, in which the immune system is a cognitive network sustaining the organism's identity through ongoing positive self-assertion rather than through the exclusion of the other, so that tolerance is the default and perturbation is integrated wherever possible. Alfred Tauber's *The Immune Self* (1994) traced this alternative to Élie Metchnikoff, for whom immunity was the organism's labor of harmonizing its own disharmonious elements. Varela was also a practitioner of Tibetan Buddhism and, with Evan Thompson and Eleanor Rosch, the author of *The Embodied Mind* (1991), which joined the Madhyamaka doctrine of the emptiness of self to the science of cognition. With Humberto Maturana he had defined life as autopoiesis, the self-production of a network that has no essence beyond its activity. Varela's immune self is a Buddhist self: without fixed substance, constituted by relation, sustained by coherence rather than walls.

This is the scientific analogue of the saga's light side. The Sith and the late Jedi share Burnet's paradigm—self against other, defense, purge—and differ only in what they classify as self. Luke and the redeemed Anakin practice Varela's: identity maintained by relation, tolerance as default, the enemy integrated rather than destroyed. Symbiotic theodicy is the transition from the first paradigm to the second, narrated as the history of a family.

12.3

Objections and Replies

Anachronism. Esposito, Derrida, Agamben, and Varela postdate the original trilogy. *Reply*: the method of this study claims structural homology, not influence, and the immunitary imaginary was contemporaneous with the saga's genesis. Burnet's theory (1957), Jerne's network (1974), the Gaia hypothesis (1974), Becker's *The Denial of Death* (1973), the "war on cancer" declared with the National Cancer Act (1971), the AIDS crisis from 1981, and the space-based shield of 1983 all belong to the saga's historical horizon. The philosophers theorized what the culture had already dreamed.

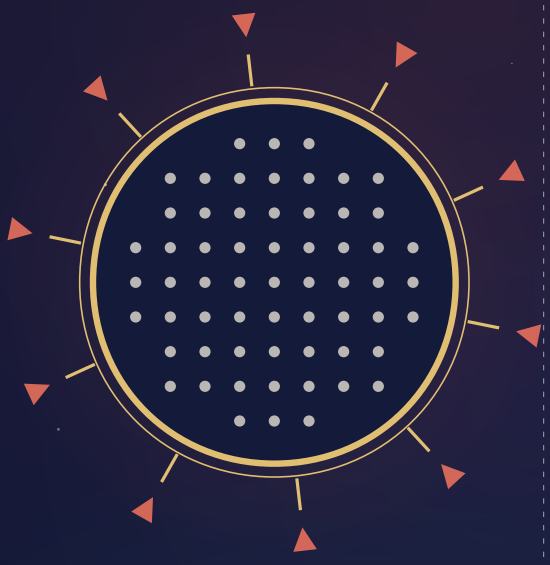
Intention. Lucas never speaks of immunity. *Reply*: the claim concerns a structure, which Lucas's statements corroborate wherever they touch it—his mod-

BURNET

self against not-self

JERNE · VARELA

the self as a network





DEFENSE · SURVEILLANCE · PURGE

the Sith and the late Jedi differ only in what they classify as self

RELATION · TOLERANCE · INTEGRATION

Luke and the redeemed Anakin: the enemy integrated rather than destroyed

SYMBIOTIC THEODICY

the passage from the first paradigm to the second, narrated as the history of a family

PLATE XII

Two models of the self

Burnet's immunology of defense beside the network immunology of Jerne and Varela; symbiotic theodicy names the passage from the first to the second.

SEE § 12.2

eling of the midi-chlorians on mitochondria, his plan for the Whills, his glosses of the dark side as selfishness and of balance as the destruction of the Sith, his political analogies with Rome and Vietnam—and which the intentional fallacy forbids us to make hostage to them.

Melodrama. The saga is a Manichaean melodrama of good and evil, and to discover a pathological theodicy in it is to read philosophy into a serial. *Reply*: the drafting record shows the deliberate abandonment of Manichaean dualism; the plot resolves in the conversion of its villain; and the internal critique of the Jedi has no place in a melodrama of pure sides. Moreover, Peter Brooks's *The Melodramatic Imagination* (1976) showed that melodrama, the characteristic mode of the post-sacred era, exists to make legible a "moral occult," a domain of spiritual forces that a desacralized world can no longer name directly. The saga is melodrama in Brooks's precise sense, and the Force is its moral occult.

The midi-chlorians. The argument's keystone is a late and unpopular addition. *Reply*: Lucas's own testimony (Cameron 2018) makes the microbiological substrate foundational to his conception, and the argument does not rest on it alone. Symbiosis is staged politically in the symbiont circle and structurally in the relay monomyth.

Apologetics for catastrophe. If balance is homeostasis and Order 66 an autoimmune episode within it, the reading appears to sanctify a massacre. *Reply*: the homeostatic process is amoral, as the *Daodejing*'s straw dogs insist, and the saga locates moral value not in the Force's tendency but in the acts of persons who cooperate with the health of the whole. To say that a fever belongs to the body's defense is not to call it good. It is to say that it can kill.

Gender. The saga's redemption passes between father and son; its mother dies to make room for it; its princess is the political twin rather than the spiritual one. *Reply*: conceded in substantial part. Padmé's dying faith is the first link of the intercessory chain, the saga's eternal feminine, and Leia carries the communitas of the Rebellion; but the soteriology is patrilineal, and a consistently developed symbiotic theodicy would require what the six films withhold: a maternal figure of communitas who survives. Maureen Murdock's critique of the monomyth applies to the saga with full force at this point.

The parasite metaphor. This study calls the Sith parasitic, and the word has a murderous history. National Socialist propaganda, from *Mein Kampf* (Hitler 1925–1927, vol. 1, ch. 11) onward, called Jews parasites on the body of other peoples, and Esposito's *Bíos* shows how such metaphors licensed extermination as hygiene (Esposito 2004). *Reply*: the objection is serious, and it marks a boundary the theory must keep. In the saga, parasitism names a practice—living off another's life

through domination and deceit—that any agent may adopt and abandon, never an essence attributed to a people or a kind of being. The saga enforces the distinction itself. Its genocidal act, Order 66, consists precisely in reclassifying a group as a contaminant to be purged, and the saga condemns it; the chief instrument of its parasitic power, Vader, is converted rather than exterminated. A symbiotic theodicy that applied the category of the parasite to a people, rather than to a practice, would have become the immunitary thanatopolitics it describes.

12.4

The Lucasian Paradox: The Franchise as Autoimmune Text

The saga's history performs its diagnosis. Lucas began as a rebel against the studio system: a film student who co-founded American Zoetrope with Francis Ford Coppola in 1969, whose first feature, *THX 1138*, was recut by Warner Bros. against his wishes, and who withdrew to Marin County to escape Hollywood's control. In his negotiations with Twentieth Century-Fox in the mid-1970s he accepted a modest fee in exchange for retaining sequel and merchandising rights, and from that bargain he built an empire: Lucasfilm, Industrial Light & Magic, Skywalker Sound, THX, and a licensing apparatus that made the anti-imperial myth the paradigm of the franchise system. Peter Biskind's history of the New Hollywood ends with its rebels defeated by their own victory (Biskind 1998).

The Special Editions intensify the paradox. In 1988 Lucas testified before a United States Senate subcommittee against the alteration of motion pictures, describing those who would alter or destroy works of the cultural heritage for profit or for power as barbarians. From 1997 onward he revised his own films repeatedly and declined to issue the original theatrical versions in restored form, declaring the revisions definitive. The author attacked the historical body of his work in order to protect its integrity as he defined it: an immunization of the work against its own past, which is to say autoimmunity. The audience completed the allegory. Fans undertook their own restorations of the theatrical versions, preserving the old republic of the original cut against its author's emergency powers. In 2012 Lucasfilm was sold to The Walt Disney Company for approximately four billion dollars, and the rebel's empire was incorporated into a larger Leviathan.

The paradox is not merely ironic. It confirms the central claim of this study: immunity is the logic of the late-modern self, and not even the myth's author could escape it. Horkheimer and Adorno argued that myth is already enlightenment and that enlightenment reverts to myth (Horkheimer and Adorno 1947); the saga's trajectory—myth, then industry, then myth again in the hyper-real religion of its audi-

ence—is their dialectic in miniature. What the history finally shows is that the text's critique survives its institution's practice. The franchise behaved like the Empire. The films still teach the unmasking.

CODA

Afterlives of the Mask

The productions that followed Lucas's departure oscillate between two impulses: re-immunization, which resurrects the armor and the Emperor, and the repetition of the unmasking. That the oscillation recurs across authors, decades, and media is the strongest evidence that the immunitary structure is the saga's generative grammar, available to anyone who works within it.

The Force Awakens (2015) opens where the Lucas saga's mourning closed, and reopens it. Ben Solo, now Kylo Ren and Vader's grandson, keeps the charred and melted helmet recovered from the pyre on Endor and addresses it as a relic. The burned armor has become an object of veneration: the crypt that Luke's mourning dissolved is reconstituted in the third generation, as Abraham's theory of the transgenerational phantom predicts, since the phantom passes not to the one who kept the secret but to his descendants. Kylo Ren wears a mask he does not need—an elective armor, the costume of a lineage he never knew—and the trilogy's emotional arc is the history of its removal. *The Last Jedi* (2017) made explicit the critique of the Jedi Order that this study has located in Lucas. Its exiled Luke judges the Order's legacy to be one of failure and hubris, culminating in its blindness to the Sith's rise, and insists that the Force is no possession of the Jedi. His final act projects his image across the galaxy to absorb the fire of an army without striking a blow, and the effort kills him: a kenosis that repeats the throne room's swordless victory as a last stand. *The Rise of Skywalker* (2019) reversed both movements. Palpatine returns, sustained by cloning and dark science—the immunitary immortality project vindicated by the industry's appetite for its own past—and the heroine is revealed as his granddaughter. Yet the film ends with an elective act of kinship: standing before the abandoned Lars homestead, Rey takes the name Skywalker, choosing a lineage of relation over a lineage of blood, a gesture a symbiotic theodicy can only endorse.

Rogue One (2016) supplied the most literal confirmation of the autoimmune reading. The Death Star's exhaust port, it reveals, was a flaw deliberately engineered into the station by its principal designer, Galen Erso, a scientist conscripted by the Empire who placed the means of its destruction inside its body. The immunitary apparatus perished through a vulnerability installed by one of its own cells. *Andor* (2022–2025) returned to Lucas's political register while almost wholly abandoning his mysticism. Its Empire is procedure, prison labor, and surveillance, its functionaries banal in Arendt's sense, and its Rebellion a communitas paid for in sacrifice, its organizers bound by a *munus* that consumes their lives. *The Mandalorian* (2019–2023) built an entire culture around a rule of permanent masking—its warrior creed forbids removing the helmet before others—and reached its emotional climax when its protagonist removed his helmet so that the child in his care could see his face before they parted. It is the unmasking of *Return of the Jedi* with the roles reversed: the father figure bares his face for the sake of the son.

The post-Lucasian franchise thus alternates between resurrecting the armor and removing it. The immunitary structure is not an interpretation imposed upon the saga. It is the grammar by which the saga continues to generate itself.



Conclusion

Star Wars, read whole, is a myth of immunity that teaches its own cure. This dissertation asked what organizes the saga's syncretism and answered that the organizing principle is immunity. The archive from which Lucas assembled it was already sorted along the axis of exposure and protection, and the drafting record shows two decisive acts of selection: the collapse of a Manichaean dualism into a single Force with a dark side, and the condensation of a wounded cyborg father and an armored villain into a single body. From these two acts the saga's metaphysics, ethics, and politics unfold with a coherence that its critics, attending to its surface, and its celebrants, attending to its monomythic armature, have both underestimated.

The Force, read through Taoist, Stoic, and Spinozan frames and then through the endosymbiotic biology of the midi-chlorians, is a living, symbiotically mediated whole whose health is homeostatic. The dark side is not its rival but its pathology: the hypertrophy of one pole, the reduced norm of a life that has lost its capacity to open. Anakin falls by a pathogenesis the saga renders with clinical precision—the terror of death, unanswered by an Order that possessed a technique of immortality and withheld it; the prohibition of mourning, which converted grief into melancholic incorporation; the resignation of knights who could renounce the finite but not receive it back. The Republic falls by the same affect and through the same reflex: a protector who manufactures the danger he protects against, a Senate that votes its own abolition, an army clonally expanded from a single template and programmed to recognize the Republic's guardians as non-self. City and soul fall on the same night, in the same montage, by the same autoimmune logic.

The saga's resolution is not a victory but a sequence of disarmaments: a son who throws away his weapon, a father who empties himself of power, a father who asks

to have his mask removed so that he may see his son with his own eyes, and a son who burns the armor and mourns. Only after the mourning do the dead return, and they return transparent. Every frame this study has drawn upon converges on that sequence: Yagyū Munenori's sword that gives life by being laid down, Kierkegaard's knight of faith who receives the finite back, the Philippians hymn's self-emptying and exaltation, Levinas's face, Esposito's *munus*, Derrida's hospitality, and Laozi's precept that victory should be observed with the rites of mourning. That an epic so lavishly armed should culminate in the dismantling of armor is its deepest irony and its central teaching.

The study's theoretical contribution is the concept of symbiotic theodicy: an account of evil as a pathology of relation, taking the forms of parasitism and autoimmunity, and of redemption as homeostatic restoration through kenotic de-immunization. The concept is offered as a reading of Lucas, but it is not confined to him. It occupies a third position between the Manichaean substantialization of evil and its Augustinian reduction to privation, a position for which Canguilhem's reduced norm, Esposito's immunitary paradigm, and Varela's network self supply the conceptual resources, and it may prove useful wherever a culture narrates its fears in the idiom of defense.

That idiom has become the common speech of the age. In the decades since *Return of the Jedi*, the language of immunity has migrated from the laboratory into every domain of public life—shields and firewalls, quarantines and borders, security doctrines whose protections have repeatedly turned against the bodies they were built to guard—and during the pandemic years the vocabulary Esposito had theorized became the vocabulary of ordinary conversation. In such an age, a myth that renders the immunitary paradigm with this much precision, and refuses its logic at the climax, is not a children's entertainment that happens to borrow from philosophy. It is among the most consequential works of popular philosophy the late twentieth century produced, and its argument is addressed to a world that has not yet learned it.

The argument can be restated, finally, in the saga's own images. A child born into slavery, the most symbiotically inhabited being in the galaxy, became the most enclosed, because he could not bear to lose what he loved and was forbidden to grieve. He lived for twenty years inside a shell that kept him safe and buried him, breathing through a machine. He was saved by a son who would not kill him, and he died in the moment he consented to be seen. The Force he had served in armor received him without it. The self, the saga teaches, survives not by being protected but by being given. ☼

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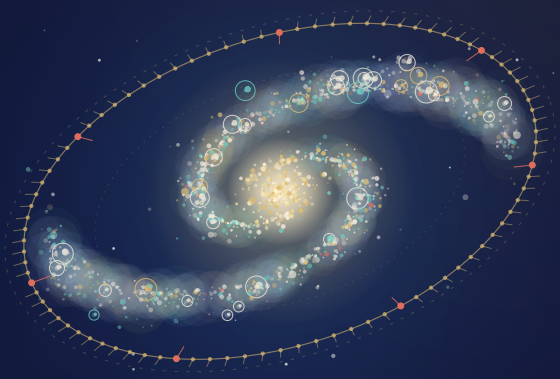
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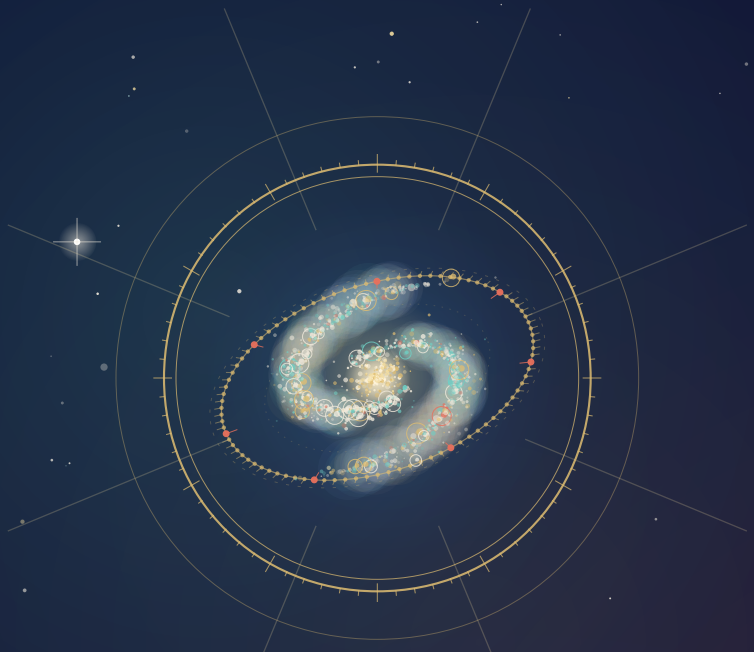
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Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

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